

THE LITTLE PLUMBER THAT COULDN'T

How Plumbers Who Take Action Turn Can't Into Done.

SEARCH
Plumbers Near Me



Ryan Pietrzak - Licensed Plumber - Over 250 Plumbing Websites Built

THE LITTLE PLUMBER THAT COULD

HOW PLUMBERS WHO TAKE ACTION
TURN CAN'T INTO DONE

RYAN PIETRZAK

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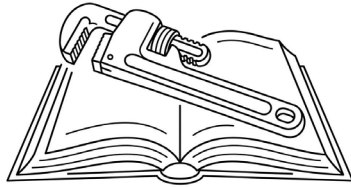
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FOREWORD

I'M A PLUMBER. AND SOMEHOW, I WROTE A MARKETING BOOK.

I've snaked more drains than I can count, replaced more water heaters than I'd like to admit, and crawled under more houses than any sane person should. I've had sewage in my boots, spiders in my hair, and customers who swore they "only flushed toilet paper" - while plumbers have literally pulled out Barbie dolls, socks, keys, and things we all wish we could unidentify.

I'm a plumber. I've been one since 2009. And somehow, I ended up writing a marketing book.

If that sounds weird, trust me - it sounds weird to me too. I didn't go to school for marketing. I didn't get an MBA. I didn't intern at some ad agency downtown. I learned marketing the same way I learned plumbing: by messing it up, figuring out what went wrong, and trying again until it worked.

Here's the thing nobody tells you in trade school, or your apprenticeship, or that first year riding shotgun in someone else's van: being a great plumber and **being a successful plumber are two different things.**

You can be the best plumber in your city. You can do cleaner work, charge fairer prices, show up on time, and treat every customer like family. And you can still go broke. It happens every single day. Incredible tradespeople - guys and gals who could replumb an entire house blindfolded - struggle to make payroll because they don't know how to get the phone to ring.

That's not a skills problem. That's a marketing problem.

And nobody taught you how to fix it. Trade school taught you how to plumb. Your apprenticeship taught you the craft. Your first boss taught you how to deal with customers (or, more likely, how NOT to deal with customers). But at no point did anyone sit you down and say: "Here's how to get customers in 2026. Here's how Google works. Here's why your website matters. Here's what to do when a competitor with half your talent is getting twice your calls."

Nobody taught you that. So I wrote it down.

What This Book Is

This is a field guide. Not a textbook. Not a pitch. Not some 400-page theory book written by a guy in a suit who's never held a wrench.

This is the book I wish someone had handed me right after I finished my apprenticeship. I spent years working for other companies, watching owners struggle with the business side while being incredible on the tools. I saw firsthand what happens when a great plumber doesn't know how to market - the stress, the slow months, the guys who eventually gave up and went to work for someone else. I didn't live all of those struggles myself, but I had a front-row seat and with the internet and technology advancement, it has become more than obvious that it is not a rare thing.

Every chapter in this book follows the same pattern:

- 1. A story you'll recognize**

I'm going to introduce you to plumbers who sound a lot like you - or like the guy in the truck next to you at the supply house. Their names are made up. Their situations are very real. Every character in this book is a recreation - pulled from my own memory, from friends

in the industry, from Reddit posts, from forums, and from the real-life stories that plumbers share every day. This stuff actually happens. If you recognize yourself in one of them - good. That means you're paying attention.

2. **A lesson you need**

I'm going to explain WHY something matters - not in marketing jargon, but in plumber terms. Why your website is costing you money. Why your competitor with worse work gets more calls. Why that \$5/day Google Ads experiment was doomed before you hit "launch."

3. **Something you can do THIS WEEK**

Every chapter ends with "Wrench Turn" action items. Not "consider developing a strategic framework." Actual things. Google this. Text that. Film this. Five minutes or less for at least one of them.

*****A note on the stories in this book:** I want to be completely upfront about something. The conversations, scenarios, and characters in this book are artistic recreations. None of these dialogues happened word-for-word as written. I took real situations - things I've personally experienced, things friends and colleagues in the plumbing industry have told me, things I've read on Reddit, YouTube, trade forums, and across the internet - and I recreated them in a way that teaches the lesson. The names are fictional. The exact details are dramatized. But the underlying situations, the mistakes, the wins, and the lessons? Those are 100% real. They happen every single day in this industry. I took some artistic liberties to make them readable, but I did not make them up. If anything, the real versions are usually worse.***

You'll also find two recurring callouts throughout the book:

"Pipe Dream vs. Pipeline" - a side-by-side of what plumbers tell themselves versus what actually works. One sentence each. The myth and the reality.

"Ryan's Rant" - short sections where I get on my soapbox about something that drives me crazy. I tried to keep these professional. I mostly succeeded.

What This Book Is NOT

This is not a sales pitch for my company. Yes, I run OnlyPlumbingSites.com. Yes, I'm trying to build the most complete plumbing only resource on the internet at ThePlumbingDirectory.com. Yes, we help plumbers with their marketing. But this book gives you everything you need to understand what's happening and take action - whether you hire us, hire someone else, or do it all yourself.

This is not a step-by-step technical manual. I'm not going to teach you how to write code, build a website from scratch, or set up a Google Ads campaign click by click. That's what the website is for (more on that in a second).

And this is not theory from someone who's never run a service business. Every piece of advice in this book comes from the field. From plumbers. From my own experience. From watching what works and what doesn't across hundreds of plumbing companies.

How to Read This Book

Here's the best part: **you don't have to read it front to back.**

I created every chapter to stand on its own. You can open this book to whatever topic is keeping you up at night and start there. Worried about your website? Jump to Chapter 3. Confused about SEO? Start at Chapter 6. Want to know why your competitor has 300 Google reviews and you have 7? Chapter 5 is waiting.

Each chapter is organized under a bigger section:

- **Part I: The Wake-Up Call** - Why word of mouth isn't enough, and why you need to know your numbers
- **Part II: Your Digital Foundation** - Your website, Google Business Profile, and reviews
- **Part III: Getting Found on Google** - SEO, service pages, content, and the technical stuff

- **Part IV: Paying for Leads** - Google Ads, Local Service Ads, and lead services like Angi
- **Part V: Social Media & Brand** - Being visible, Facebook Marketplace, building a brand, and video marketing
- **Part VI: Systems & Scale** - CRM, follow-up, CSR training, AI tools, recruiting, and customer retention
- **Part VII: The Payoff** - The transformation story and your 90-day action plan

Skip around. Dog-ear the pages. Spill coffee on it. This is a field guide - it's supposed to get beat up.

The Three Lanes

Every chapter in this book is going to give you enough information to understand WHY something matters. But I know you're a plumber, not a marketer. You've got pipes to fix and customers to call back. So here's the deal:

Lane 1 - THE WHY: That's this book. I explain why your website matters, why reviews are critical, why SEO isn't optional anymore. Enough information to get it, to stop getting burned, and to make smart decisions.

Lane 2 - THE HOW: Every chapter links to a detailed guide on OnlyPlumbingSites.com. Want to set up your Google Business Profile step by step? There's a guide for that. Want to build service pages that actually rank? There's a guide for that too. Scan the QR code or type the URL at the end of each chapter. Free. No strings.

Lane 3 - THE WE DO IT: If you read a chapter and think "I get it, but I don't have time to do this" - that's what my team is for. OnlyPlumbingSites.com/call. We build websites, run ads, do SEO, and manage the whole marketing machine so you can focus on what you actually want to do: plumbing.

No pressure on which lane you pick. I'd rather you do it yourself and crush it than hire us and not be committed to it. But I want you to know the options exist.

One Last Thing Before We Start

I created this book because I'm tired of watching good plumbers fail at business. I'm tired of seeing talented tradespeople - people who solve real problems for real families every single day - lose to competitors who are half as good but twice as visible. I pretty much live, eat, sleep and breath this stuff and it has become fairly easy to me, so i want to share it with others.

You deserve better. Your family deserves better. The customers who would LOVE your work but can't find you? They deserve better too.

So here's my ask: read this book with an open mind. If something makes you uncomfortable, lean into it - that's probably the chapter you need most. If something makes you say "I already know that," ask yourself honestly: am I doing it? Knowing and doing are two very different things.

And when you're done - or even before you're done - do ONE THING. Pick one Wrench Turn action item from any chapter and do it before you go to bed tonight. Not tomorrow. Not "when things slow down." Tonight.

Consistency beats intensity every time and the plumber who takes action is the plumber who wins. Every time.

Let's get to work.

- **Ryan Pietrzak** *Plumber since 2009. Marketer by necessity. Founder, OnlyPlumbingSites.com*



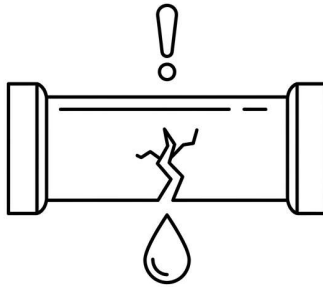
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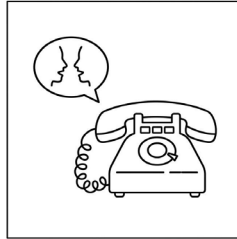
PART I

THE WAKE UP CALL

*“You won't even begin to try to fix your business until
you realize just how broken it truly is.”*

-Ryan Pietrzak





CHAPTER I

"I GET ENOUGH WORK FROM WORD OF MOUTH"

THE DENIAL STAGE

"I've never had to advertise. My work speaks for itself." - Every plumber who's about to have a bad year

Dave has been plumbing for 22 years.

Twenty-two years of showing up on time. Twenty-two years of doing the job right the first time. Twenty-two years of treating every customer like they're his only customer. Dave is, by every measure, an excellent plumber. His hands know the difference between a good joint and a great one without looking. He can diagnose a slab leak by sound. He once repaired a 1940s cast iron stack in a historic home that three other plumbers had walked away from.

Dave is proud of his work. He should be.

Dave is also proud of the fact that he's never spent a dime on advertising. "I get all my work from word of mouth," he tells anyone who'll listen. He says it at the supply house. He says it at his kid's baseball games. He says it at Thanksgiving when his brother-in-law asks how business is going. It's his badge of honor. Proof that he's the real deal. That his reputation does the talking.

And for 20 of those 22 years, it worked.

Then came the winter that changed everything.

Dave's two biggest referral sources - a realtor named Karen who'd been sending him 3-4 jobs a month for a decade, and a property manager named Bill who handled 40 rental units - both retired within three months of each other. Just like that. Karen moved to Florida. Bill sold his properties and bought a boat.

Dave figured it would be fine. He'd built relationships. He had other people sending him work. But here's the thing about word of mouth that Dave didn't realize until it was too late: it's not a faucet you can turn up when the pressure drops. It's a trickle. Sometimes it flows. Sometimes it doesn't. And you have absolutely zero control over which one it's going to be.

Around the same time Karen and Bill rode off into the sunset, a new plumbing company opened up on the other side of town. Dave didn't think much of it. He'd seen competitors come and go. But this one was different. This one had a professional website that showed up when you searched "plumber in [Dave's city]." This one had 200 Google reviews and a 4.9-star rating. This one was running Google Ads that popped up every time someone in town had a plumbing emergency.

By February, Dave's phone was quiet. Not silent - he was still getting a few calls a week. But not enough. Not the steady stream he'd built his life around. He told himself it was seasonal. He thought plumbing always slows down... in winter, right...? I guess it depends where you live, but for him it was very real.

By March, he was sweating payroll.

By April, he was dipping into savings.

By May, Dave finally Googled his own business name. What he found wasn't pretty. A half-finished Google listing someone had created for him years ago - wrong phone number, no photos, no reviews. When he searched "plumber near me," his competitor showed up first. Then another competitor. Then another. Dave was on page three. Page three might as well be page three hundred.

Dave had 7 Google reviews after 22 years in business.

His competitor - the new guy, the one who'd been in town for 18 months - had 312.

Sound familiar?

Word of Mouth Is a Compliment. It's Not a Strategy

Let me be clear about something before we go any further: **word of mouth is amazing**. If you're getting referrals, that means you're doing great work. It means customers trust you enough to put their name on the line and recommend you to their friends, their family, their neighbors. That's not nothing. That's everything.

But here's what word of mouth is NOT: a marketing strategy.

A strategy is something you can control. Something you can scale. Something you can predict, measure, and adjust when it's not working.

Word of mouth is none of those things.

You can't call up Karen in Florida and say, "Hey, I need more referrals this month - can you send me five?" You can't predict whether your best referral source is going to retire, move away, get sick, or just... stop thinking about you. You can't scale referrals because they depend entirely on other people remembering to mention your name at exactly the right moment.

And that's the part nobody talks about. Word of mouth requires three things to happen in perfect sequence:

1. **Someone you've worked for has to encounter someone who needs a plumber.** They have to be in the right place at the right time.
2. **They have to remember your name and your number.** Not their cousin's friend who's "pretty handy." Not the ad they saw on Facebook yesterday. **YOU.**

3. **They have to actually say it out loud.** Not think “oh, I should tell them about Dave.” Actually pull out their phone and share your info.

All three of those things have to happen. And you control exactly zero of them. Compare that to a Google Ads campaign where you show up every time someone in your city searches “emergency plumber.” Or a Google Business Profile that displays your name, phone number, reviews, and photos to anyone within 20 miles who types “plumber near me.” Or a website that ranks on page one and gets clicks 24 hours a day, 7 days a week, whether you’re on a job or asleep.

Those are things you control. Those are strategies.

Word of mouth? That’s a bonus. A beautiful, wonderful, never-take-it-for-granted bonus. But it’s not a plan.

The Numbers Don’t Lie

I know some of you are reading this and thinking, “Yeah, but I really DO get enough work from referrals. I’m busy.”

Let me ask you a few questions.

Are you “busy” or are you “booked out three weeks and hiring your second tech” busy? Because there’s a massive difference between surviving and thriving. A lot of plumbers tell me they’re busy when what they really mean is “I have enough work to not panic this week.” That’s not busy. That’s getting by.

Here are some numbers to think about:

97% of consumers search online before hiring a local service provider. Ninety-seven percent. That means for every 100 people in your city who need a plumber today, 97 of them are going to Google before they ask their neighbor. If you’re not showing up on that search, you don’t exist to 97 out of 100 potential customers.

Now, some of those 97 people will ALSO get a referral from a friend. Great.

But when they get that referral, you know what most of them do next? **They Google you anyway.** They check your reviews. They look at your website. They compare you to whoever else showed up in the search results.

And if you've got 7 reviews and a website your nephew built in 2019, while your competitor has 312 reviews and a site that loads in two seconds with a click-to-call button? That referral just became a comparison shop. And you just lost.

Here's another number: Dave was getting 6-8 calls a week from word of mouth. Sounds decent, right? But let's do the math. If he closes 80% of those calls (Dave's good, remember), that's about 5-6 jobs a week. At an average ticket of \$400, that's \$2,000-\$2,400 a week. Around \$100,000-\$125,000 a year.

Dave's been at roughly the same revenue for a decade. He's comfortable. He's not growing. He's not saving for retirement. He's not building a business he can sell someday. He's surviving. And the moment his referral sources dried up, "surviving" became "scrambling."

Meanwhile, the plumber across town with 312 reviews and a real marketing system? He's getting 25-30 calls a week. Closing \$8,000-\$10,000 a week. Growing year over year. Hiring techs. Building something he can retire on.

Same town. Same services. Same quality of work. Different visibility.

Word of mouth gave Dave a floor. Marketing gave his competitor a ceiling he hasn't hit yet.

"But I've Never HAD to Advertise"

I hear this one a lot. And I want to be respectful about it, because I understand the pride behind it. When a plumber says "I've never had to advertise," what they're really saying is "I'm so good that work finds me." And honestly? That IS impressive. You should feel good about that.

But let me reframe it.

“I’ve never had to advertise” often really means:

- **“I’ve hit a ceiling and I don’t realize it.”** You’re getting 6-8 calls a week. You could be getting 30. But you’ll never know because you’ve never tried.
- **“I’m one bad quarter from panic.”** You’re riding a wave of referrals that could dry up any month for reasons completely outside your control.
- **“I’m leaving a fortune on the table.”** Every day, dozens - maybe hundreds - of people in your service area search for a plumber online. If they can’t find you, they’re finding someone else. That’s not theoretical revenue. That’s real money going to your competitor.
- **“I don’t have a business I can sell.”** A plumbing company that depends 100% on the owner’s personal relationships has almost zero sellable value. Who would buy it? The moment you leave, the referrals leave with you. A company with a marketing machine - a website that ranks, reviews that convert, ads that generate leads - that’s a business with real value.

I’m not saying word of mouth is bad. I’m saying word of mouth **ALONE** is dangerous.

The plumbers who are absolutely crushing it? They get referrals **AND** they market. They’ve got the reputation **AND** the visibility. Their existing customers love them **AND** new customers can find them online.

That’s not either/or. It’s both.

Word of mouth is the foundation. Marketing is the megaphone. And if you want to **CREATE** word of mouth on purpose instead of waiting for it to happen? Chapter 21 shows you exactly how.

The Seasonal Panic Cycle

Here’s a pattern I see with word-of-mouth-only plumbers, and see if this rings true:

Winter hits. Pipes freeze. Furnaces die. Water heaters give up. The phone rings off the hook. You're slammed. You're turning down work. You're telling people it'll be a week before you can get there. Life is good. "See? I don't need marketing."

Spring comes. Things slow down. The phone still rings, but less. That's normal, right? Seasonal.

Summer arrives. Crickets. You're sitting in your truck wondering why nobody's calling. You start thinking about maybe posting on Facebook or something, but you don't really know how, and besides, you're too stressed about money to focus on it.

Fall picks up a little. Some water heater jobs. A few remodels. Enough to pay the bills but not enough to breathe easy.

Then winter hits again and you're slammed, and the cycle repeats, and you tell yourself "I don't need marketing" because right now, in this moment, the phone is ringing.

That's not a business. That's a rollercoaster. And the only person screaming is you.

Marketing doesn't just get you MORE calls. Marketing smooths out the dips. It fills the gaps between the busy seasons. It means July doesn't have to be a month of dread. A plumber with a steady stream of calls from Google, from social media, from their website - that plumber doesn't know what "slow season" means. Their phone rings year-round because they're visible year-round.

Dave's competitor doesn't have slow seasons. Dave does.

What About Dale?

I want to tell you about one more plumber before we get to the action items. His name isn't really Dale, but his story is real.

Dale has been plumbing for 27 years. All word of mouth. Never marketed a day in his life. He's 58 years old and he's starting to think about retirement. So he goes to a business broker to find out what his company is worth.

The answer? About \$90,000.

Twenty-seven years of blood, sweat, and sewage, and his company - his legacy, the thing he built from nothing - is worth ninety grand. That's less than a new truck.

The reason? Dale's company has no systems. No website that generates leads. No review profile that attracts customers. No recurring revenue. No marketing machine that works independently of Dale. The only asset is Dale himself - his name, his relationships, his reputation. And when Dale retires, all of that walks out the door with him.

Across town, a plumber with 15 years of experience - seven years fewer than Dale - sold his company for \$350,000. That plumber had 400 Google reviews, a website that ranked on page one for 30 keywords, a Google Ads campaign generating 50 calls a week, and a maintenance plan with 200 recurring customers. The buyer didn't need the original owner's relationships. The marketing machine was the business.

Dale's reputation was worth compliments. The other plumber's system was worth \$350,000.

Which one do you want to be?

Pipe Dream vs. Pipeline

Pipe Dream: "I don't need marketing. My reputation speaks for itself."

Pipeline: "My reputation is the foundation. Marketing is the megaphone."

Ryan's Rant

Every plumber I've ever met who says they get enough work from word of mouth falls into one of three categories:

(a) They're lying. Not maliciously - they just don't want to admit that things are slower than they should be. Business is "fine." Revenue is "good." But they haven't taken a real vacation in four years and they're driving a truck with 180,000 miles on it.

(b) They're turning down growth. They've decided - maybe without realizing it - that this is as big as they want to get. And look, if that's a conscious choice, I respect it. But most of the time it's not a choice. It's a comfort zone disguised as a philosophy.

(c) They're one bad quarter from panic. Everything's great until it isn't. One referral source retires. One competitor shows up. One slow season lasts a little too long. And suddenly "I don't need marketing" becomes "I should've started marketing two years ago."

Which one are you? Be honest. Not with me - with yourself.

Wrench Turn Action Items

Here are five things you can do this week. Right now. Today. Not "when things slow down." Today.

1. Write down your top 5 referral sources by name. Actual names. The people who send you the most work. When's the last time you talked to each of them? When's the last time you thanked them? When's the last time you sent them a gift card, a thank-you note, or even a text? If your answer is "I don't know" - that's a problem. Referral sources need maintenance, just like plumbing.

2. Google your own business name. Right now. Open an incognito browser window (so your past searches don't affect the results) and type in your company name. What shows up? Is there a Google Business Profile? Is the information correct? Are there reviews? Or is it a ghost town? Whatever you see is what every potential customer sees.

3. Google "[your main service] + [your city]." Type in something like "water heater repair Dallas" or "emergency plumber Tampa." Where do you show up?

Page one? Page two? Nowhere? Now look at who IS showing up. Those are the plumbers getting the calls you're not.

4. Answer this honestly: if your top referral source stopped sending you work tomorrow, what's your backup plan? If the answer is "I'd figure it out" or "I'd ask around" - you don't have a backup plan. You have a hope. Hope is not a strategy. Not in plumbing, and not in marketing.

5. Set one meeting this week to discuss marketing. Even if it's with yourself. Block 30 minutes on your calendar. Sit down with a coffee and ask: "What am I doing to make my phone ring? What should I be doing? What's stopping me?" If you can't answer those questions, keep reading. That's what the rest of this book is for.

Now you know WHY word of mouth isn't enough. Want to learn how to systematize your referrals so they actually scale? Here's the guide:

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/word-of-mouth

Want us to build the marketing machine for you? Book a free strategy call:

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/call



CHAPTER 2

“I DON’T EVEN KNOW WHAT I SPEND ON MARKETING”

KNOW YOUR NUMBERS OR LOSE YOUR SHIRT

“How’s business?” “Busy!” “Are you profitable?” “...I think so?” - A conversation I’ve had with roughly 400 plumbers

I want to tell you about a plumber named Jerome.

Jerome’s been running his company for 11 years. One truck when he started, three trucks now. He’s got two techs and a part-time office person who answers the phone when she’s not at her other job. Jerome is, by most definitions, a real plumbing company. Not a one-man show anymore. He’s got payroll, insurance, overhead - the whole deal.

I sat down with Jerome last year and asked him five questions. Simple questions. Questions that any business owner should be able to answer faster than it takes to change a wax ring.

- **Question 1: What’s your average job ticket?**
Jerome: “Uh... it depends. Probably like... \$300-ish? Maybe \$400?”
- **Question 2: What’s your cost per lead?**
Jerome: “My what?”

- **Question 3: What's your close rate? What percentage of calls turn into paying jobs?**
Jerome: "I don't know. Most of them?"
- **Question 4: What's your customer lifetime value? What's a single customer worth to you over time - not just one job, but all the jobs they'll ever hire you for?**
Jerome: blank stare
- **Question 5: What's your marketing ROI? For every dollar you spend on marketing, how many dollars come back?**
Jerome: "I mean... I don't really track that. I just... spend money and work comes in."
- Eleven years. Three trucks. And Jerome can't answer a single one of those questions with confidence.

Here's the thing about Jerome: he's not dumb. He's not lazy. He's not bad at business. He's just never been taught to think about these numbers. Nobody at trade school handed him a spreadsheet and said "track this." His first boss didn't sit him down and explain customer acquisition costs. Jerome learned plumbing from plumbers, and plumbers - God bless us - are not known for our spreadsheet skills.

But here's what Jerome doesn't realize: he's flying blind. He's making marketing decisions - spending money, hiring people, running ads, choosing where to advertise - based entirely on gut feel. And gut feel is the most expensive accounting method in the plumbing industry.

Jerome spends about \$3,000 a month on marketing. Some Google Ads. A listing on Angi. A buddy who "does his social media" for \$500 a month (we'll get to THAT in later chapters). He has no idea which of those is working. He has no idea what a new customer costs him. He has no idea if that \$3,000 is making him \$30,000 or losing him \$3,000.

He just spends. And hopes.

Sound familiar?

The Five Numbers Every Plumber Must Know

I'm not going to turn you into an accountant. I promise. But there are five numbers that separate plumbers who build wealth from plumbers who just build calluses. And once you know these numbers, every marketing decision you make goes from gambling to investing.

Number 1: Average Job Ticket

This is the simplest one. **How much revenue does the average job bring in?**

Add up your total revenue for the last few months. Divide by the number of jobs. That's your average ticket.

Why it matters: If you don't know this number, you can't figure out any of the other numbers. You also can't set proper goals. "I want to make \$500,000 this year" sounds great, but it means nothing unless you know: at a \$400 average ticket, that's 1,250 jobs. At a \$650 average ticket, that's 769 jobs. See how different those two businesses look?

Most plumbers I talk to guess their average ticket is lower than it actually is. They remember the small jobs - the \$150 garbage disposal install, the \$89 service call. They forget the \$2,800 water heater replacement and the \$5,000 repipe that pull the average way up. This is why guessing doesn't work. Pull the actual numbers.

Number 2: Cost Per Lead (CPL)

How much does it cost to get your phone to ring?

Take what you spend on marketing in a month. Divide by the number of leads (calls, form fills, messages) you got that month. That's your cost per lead.

Example: You spend \$2,000/month on marketing. You got 40 leads last month. Your cost per lead is \$50.

Why it matters: This is the number that tells you whether your marketing is efficient or wasteful. If you're paying \$50 per lead and your average job is \$500,

that looks pretty good. If you're paying \$200 per lead and your average job is \$300... you've got a problem.

But here's the thing - you need to know this per channel, not just overall. Your Google Ads might be generating leads at \$40 each while your Angi listing generates them at \$150 each. If you don't track by channel, you'll never know which one to invest in and which one to kill.

This is the number Jerome couldn't answer. And without it, he has no way of knowing if his \$3,000/month in marketing spend is brilliant or bonkers.

Number 3: Close Rate

What percentage of leads become paying customers?

If you got 40 leads last month and 28 of them turned into actual jobs, your close rate is 70%.

Why it matters: Your close rate tells you two critical things. First, how many leads you need to hit your revenue goals. If you close at 70% and you need 50 jobs this month, you need about 72 leads. Second - and this is the sneaky one - your close rate reveals problems that have nothing to do with marketing.

A low close rate usually means one of these: - **You're getting the wrong leads.** Your marketing is attracting people outside your service area, or people looking for services you don't offer. - **Your price is off.** You're losing bids because you're too high (or too low - yes, being too cheap can scare people off). - Your sales process needs work. You're showing up late, not following up on estimates, or not closing the deal on-site. - **Your dispatcher is losing calls.** We'll talk about this in Chapter 17. But some plumbing companies are losing 30-40% of calls before a tech ever shows up.

A close rate below 50% means something is broken. A close rate above 70% means your sales process is solid. Above 80% and you're either a closer or you're underpriced. Either way - you need to know the number.

Number 4: Customer Lifetime Value (CLV)

What's a single customer worth to you over their lifetime - not just one job, but every job they'll ever hire you for?

This is the number that changes how you think about EVERYTHING.

Most plumbers think about customers in terms of single transactions. "That was a \$400 job." But that customer might call you again next year. And the year after that. And they might refer two friends. And they might sign up for a maintenance plan.

Here's how to think about it simply:

If your average customer uses you twice over 5 years, and your average job ticket is \$500, that customer is worth \$1,000 to you. If they also refer one friend who becomes a customer, that's another \$1,000. So that single customer is really worth \$2,000.

Why it matters: When you know a customer is worth \$2,000, suddenly spending \$150 to acquire them doesn't seem expensive - it seems like a steal. But when you think a customer is worth \$400 (one job), spending \$150 to get them feels painful.

CLV is what separates plumbers who invest in marketing from plumbers who think marketing is "too expensive." They're looking at different numbers. One is looking at the job. The other is looking at the relationship.

Number 5: Marketing ROI

For every dollar you spend on marketing, how many dollars come back?

Take the revenue generated from your marketing efforts. Divide by what you spent. That's your ROI.

Example: You spent \$3,000 on Google Ads. Those ads generated 20 customers. Those customers brought in \$12,000 in revenue. Your ROI is 4:1 - four dollars back for every dollar spent.

Why it matters: This is the ultimate number. This is the number that tells you whether your marketing is a money printer or a money pit. And once you know it, you can make decisions with confidence instead of anxiety.

A plumber named Rex told me his numbers once, and I almost fell off my chair.

Rex spends \$3,000 a month on Google Ads. He gets about 20 new customers from those ads. His average job is \$420. That's \$8,400 in revenue. But here's where it gets good: his cost per acquisition (CPA) is \$150. And his customer lifetime value is \$1,200. So that \$3,000 in ad spend actually generates about \$24,000 in lifetime value.

Rex calls his Google Ads account a “money printer.” He's not wrong.

But Rex only knows this because he TRACKS it. He knows his CPA. He knows his CLV. He knows his ROI. And because he knows those numbers, he doesn't flinch at spending \$3,000/month on ads. He'd spend \$10,000 if he could handle the volume. Because the math works.

Jerome, on the other hand, spends \$3,000/month and has no idea if it's working.

Same spend. Completely different levels of confidence.

“Gut Feel” Is the Most Expensive Accounting Method in Plumbing

Let me tell you what happens when you run your marketing on gut feel.

You hear about Google Ads from a buddy. You try it. After two weeks you don't “feel” like it's working, so you stop. You hear about Angi from another buddy. You sign up. You get some leads, but they feel expensive, so you cancel after three months. You hear about SEO from a guy at a trade show. You hire the first company that calls you back. Six months later you're not sure what they're doing, but you don't want to be rude, so you keep paying.

Sound familiar? That's Jerome. That's a lot of plumbers.

When you don't know your numbers, every marketing decision is emotional. "It feels expensive." "It doesn't feel like it's working." "I feel like I should try something different." Feelings are great for marriages. They're terrible for business decisions.

When you DO know your numbers, every marketing decision is mathematical. "My Google Ads generate leads at \$50 each and my CLV is \$1,200 - that's a 24:1 lifetime return. I'm doubling my budget." "My Angi leads cost \$180 each with a 25% close rate - that's \$720 per customer. I'm cutting that and reinvesting in ads that cost me \$150 per customer."

See the difference? One plumber is guessing. The other is calculating. One is gambling. The other is investing.

"I Track Every Penny on a Job. Why Not on My Marketing?"

This is the part that gets me.

You walk into a supply house and you know what a 3/4-inch ball valve costs. Not roughly - you know to the penny. You know it's \$14.99 at Ferguson, \$15.50 at the local shop, and \$12.75 online but you have to wait two days. You know what PEX costs per foot. You know what a water heater install costs you in parts, labor, and time.

You track every penny on a job because you know that if you're not making money on the job, there's no point doing it.

But when it comes to marketing? You throw money at the wall, don't track where it goes, and hope something sticks.

Imagine running your plumbing business the way you run your marketing. Imagine not knowing what parts cost. Imagine not tracking your hours on a job. Imagine quoting prices based on "gut feel." You'd be broke in a month.

So why is marketing any different?

It's not. The only difference is that nobody taught you to think about marketing the way you think about plumbing. Until now.

The Calculator Test

Here's a quick test. Answer these as honestly as you can:

1. **What's your average job ticket?** (If you said "it depends" - that's not an answer.)
2. **What did you spend on marketing last month?** (All of it - ads, agencies, listings, that buddy who does your social media, everything.)
3. **How many new leads did you get last month?** (Not jobs - leads. Calls, messages, form fills.)
4. **How many of those leads became paying jobs?** (This is your close rate.)
5. **What's a customer worth to you over 3-5 years?** (Not one job - their whole relationship with your company.)

If you can answer all five with real numbers, congratulations - you're ahead of 90% of plumbing companies. If you couldn't answer even two of them, don't feel bad. You're in the majority. But now you know the problem.

And the fix isn't complicated. It starts with tracking.

Setting Up Tracking (Without Losing Your Mind)

You don't need an MBA. You don't need expensive software. You need a few basic systems:

Call tracking. A service like CallRail or WhatConverts gives every marketing channel its own phone number. Google Ads calls come in on one number. Your website calls come in on another. Your Angi calls on a third. Now you know exactly how many leads each channel generates. Without call tracking, you're guessing. With it, you're measuring.

A simple spreadsheet. Yes, really. If you don't want to buy CRM software (more on that in Chapter 17), start with a Google Sheet. Columns: Date. Lead source. Customer name. Job type. Revenue. That's it. Fill it in every day. At the end of the month, sort by lead source. Now you know exactly what's working.

Your bookkeeper or accountant. Ask them one question: "Can you break down what we spent on marketing last year by category?" Ads, agencies, listings, website, everything. Get the real number. You might be surprised. The goal isn't perfection. The goal is going from blind to aware. From guessing to knowing. From "I think marketing works" to "I know exactly which marketing works, and I'm doubling down on it."

Pipe Dream vs. Pipeline

Pipe Dream: "I think we're doing okay - we're busy."

Pipeline: "I know exactly what every lead costs, what every customer is worth, and which channels are printing money."

Ryan's Rant

You track every penny on a job. You know what a 3/4-inch ball valve costs at three different supply houses. You know your labor rate to the quarter-hour. You'd NEVER start a \$5,000 job without knowing what it's going to cost you in parts and labor.

But you've been spending \$2,000-\$5,000 a MONTH on marketing for YEARS and you have NO IDEA what it costs you to get a new customer?

Come on. You're better than that.

Your marketing budget is the second-biggest expense after payroll for most plumbing companies. Treat it like one. Know what goes in. Know what comes out. Cut what doesn't work. Double what does. It's the same math you do on every job - just applied to the business instead of the pipes.

Wrench Turn Action Items

1. Pull your total revenue and total marketing spend for the last 12 months. Divide. Revenue / Marketing Spend = your basic ROI. Is it 3:1? 10:1? Are you even positive? This one number tells you more about your business health than any feeling ever will. If you don't know your total marketing spend, call your bookkeeper. Get the number. Today.

2. Calculate your average job ticket from your last 50 jobs. Open your invoicing software, your QuickBooks, your notebook - whatever you use. Add up the last 50 jobs. Divide by 50. Write that number down. That's your average ticket. If it's lower than you thought, that's useful. If it's higher than you thought, that's useful too. Either way - now you KNOW.

3. Set up call tracking this week. Even a basic plan from CallRail starts around \$40/month. It gives you a different phone number for each marketing channel. When a call comes in, you know if it came from Google Ads, your website, or your Angi listing. This single tool will teach you more about your marketing in 30 days than the last 5 years of guessing.

4. Ask your bookkeeper: "What did we spend on marketing last year, by category?" Not just the total - the breakdown. How much went to Google Ads? How much to Angi? How much to that SEO company? How much to your buddy who "does your social media"? Once you see where the money goes, you can start asking "is it working?" about each piece.

5. Write these 5 numbers on a sticky note and put it where you'll see it every day. Average job ticket. Cost per lead. Close rate. Customer lifetime value. Marketing ROI. Even if you can only fill in one or two right now, the act of seeing those blank lines every morning will motivate you to fill them in. And once they're filled in, you'll never make a blind marketing decision again.

Now you know WHY these numbers matter. Want the calculator that does the math for you?

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/know-your-numbers. The Plumber's Marketing Math Cheat Sheet - free calculator, plug in your numbers, see your ROI instantly.

Want us to run the numbers and build a custom marketing plan for your company? Book a free strategy call:

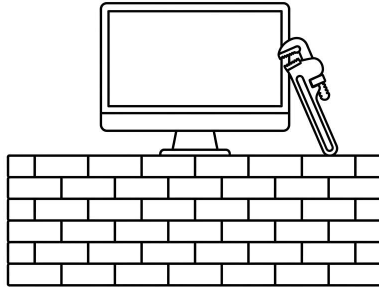
OnlyPlumbingSites.com/call

PART II

YOUR DIGITAL FOUNDATION

“A good marketing strategy built on a bad foundation is like connecting Copper to a cracked main line. Doesn’t matter how pretty the work is - it’s going to leak.”

-Ryan Pietrzak





CHAPTER 3

“MY NEPHEW BUILT MY WEBSITE”

THE \$200 DISASTER

“*M*y buddy’s kid did my website for \$200 and a case of Monster.” - Very Likely quote from an actual plumber somewhere....maybe this quote is from you?

Tony saved three thousand dollars.

At least, that’s what he told himself. His nephew - good kid, nineteen years old, studying graphic design at the community college - offered to build Tony a website over a weekend. Tony paid him \$200 and a case of Monster. The nephew sat at Tony’s kitchen table on a Saturday afternoon, signed up for a free Wix account, picked a template called “Professional Business Blue,” and started clicking.

By Sunday night, Tony had a website.

It had a stock photo of a wrench on the homepage. Not Tony’s wrench. Not Tony’s hand. A generic, perfectly-lit wrench sitting on a perfectly clean white surface that has never been within 50 feet of an actual plumbing job. The kind of wrench photo you’d find if you Googled “wrench” and clicked the first result.

It had a phone number in the header. The phone number was correct on a laptop. On a phone - where 70% of people would see it - the number was cut off. The last two digits were hidden behind the menu button. You couldn't tap to call. You'd have to memorize the number, close the browser, open your phone app, and type it in manually. Nobody does that. Ever.

It had a "Services" page. One page. A single paragraph that said: "Tony's Plumbing offers a wide range of plumbing services including repairs, installations, and maintenance. Call us today!" That's it. No details about water heaters. No mention of drain cleaning. No emergency services. No service areas. Just a paragraph that could describe any plumbing company on planet Earth.

It had a blog. The blog had one post, auto-generated by the Wix template: "Hello World - Welcome to Our New Website!" Posted in 2019. Never updated.

It took 8 seconds to load on mobile. Eight. For context, Google's recommendation is under 3 seconds. Most people abandon a website after 3 seconds of loading. Tony's site takes almost triple that. By the time it loads, the customer has already hit the back button and clicked on his competitor.

Tony's competitor, by the way, has a site that loads in 1.8 seconds. It has a click-to-call button the size of your thumb, right at the top of every page. It has separate pages for water heater repair, drain cleaning, sewer line replacement, emergency plumbing, and 8 other services - each one optimized for Tony's city. It has real photos of the crew, the trucks, and actual jobs they've done. It has 312 Google reviews embedded right on the homepage.

Tony's competitor gets 15-20 calls a day from his website.

Tony gets zero. Literally zero. In three years, Tony's website has not generated a single phone call that he knows of. Not one.

Tony saved \$3,000 on his website. And it has cost him every single customer who searched online and found nothing professional.

The \$200 website is the most expensive mistake Tony ever made.

Your Website Is Your 24/7 Salesperson

Here's how I want you to think about your website: it's an employee.

It's the employee who greets every potential customer who looks you up online. It's the employee who answers the question "should I hire these guys?" at 10pm on a Saturday when a pipe bursts and someone needs help RIGHT NOW.

Now imagine you hired an actual person for this job. And that person showed up to work in a stained shirt, mumbled when they talked, couldn't remember what services you offer, took 8 seconds to answer any question, and handed customers the wrong phone number.

How long would that person last? You'd fire them before lunch.

But that's exactly what Tony's website does. Every single day. Twenty-four hours a day. Seven days a week. It greets potential customers with a stock photo, mumbles through a vague services description, loads slower than a dial-up modem, and can't even display the phone number correctly.

And Tony wonders why his website "doesn't work."

Tony's website works exactly as well as it was built to work. Which is to say: it doesn't work at all. It's not a marketing asset. It's a marketing liability. Every person who visits it and leaves without calling is a person who probably called someone else.

The "Cheap Website" Trap

Tony's not alone. I can't tell you how many plumbers I've met who have some version of the nephew website. Sometimes it's the nephew. Sometimes it's a buddy. Sometimes it's the plumber himself, who spent a weekend on Wix or Squarespace or GoDaddy's website builder, got frustrated, slapped something together, and declared "good enough."

Here's the thing about "good enough" when it comes to your website: there is no good enough. There is "it works" and "it doesn't work." A website either converts visitors into phone calls or it doesn't. And the difference between one that does and one that doesn't isn't \$200 versus \$20,000. It's about getting the fundamentals right.

I talked to a plumber named Travis a while back. Travis is a smart guy - runs a tight operation, does quality work. He built his own website on Wix one weekend. Three pages total: Home, About, Services. He thought it looked "pretty good." It did look pretty good, actually. Nice colors. Clean layout.

It was on page 4 of Google.

Travis said, "At least I have a website." And sure, technically that's true. But a website on page 4 of Google is like a billboard in the middle of a forest. It exists. Nobody sees it.

And then there's Ray. Ray's story is the one that hurts.

Ray's been plumbing for 16 years. Mostly residential, but he'd been trying to break into commercial work. A property management company with 200 units reached out to him about a maintenance contract. We're talking \$200,000+ in annual revenue. Steady, recurring, year-round work. The dream.

Ray had a great meeting with the property manager. Shook hands. Felt good about it. Two days later, the property manager called and said they'd decided to go with someone else.

Ray asked why. The answer: "We Googled you. Your website... didn't instill confidence."

Ray's nephew website - the one with the broken contact form and the homepage that said "Website Under Construction" for the last two years - cost him a \$200,000 contract. His nephew had moved on to other things and never finished the site. Ray never thought to check.

Two hundred thousand dollars. Because of a website that said "Under Construction."

What Your Plumbing Website MUST Have

I'm not going to teach you how to build a website in this chapter. That's what the website guides are for (link at the end). But I AM going to tell you what your website needs to do its job. These are non-negotiable. If your current site doesn't have these, it's costing you money every single day.

Mobile-First Design

Over 70% of people searching for a plumber are doing it on their phone. Not their laptop. Not their desktop. Their phone. Usually because something just went wrong and they need help fast.

If your website doesn't look good on a phone - if the text is too small, if you have to pinch and zoom, if the buttons are too close together, if the phone number isn't tappable - you've lost them. They'll hit the back button and click the next result faster than you can say "wax ring."

Mobile-first doesn't mean "it also works on mobile." It means the phone experience is the PRIMARY design. Everything else is secondary.

Click-to-Call Button Above the Fold

"Above the fold" means visible without scrolling. The very first thing someone sees when your site loads.

There should be a button - big, obvious, impossible to miss - that says "Call Now" or "Tap to Call" or just displays your phone number in a way that, when tapped, immediately dials your number.

If someone has to scroll, search, or squint to find your phone number, you're losing calls. Make it stupid easy. One tap. Done.

Service Pages - One for EACH Service

This is the one that kills most plumbing websites. They have one “Services” page that lists everything in a paragraph or a bullet list.

That’s like having one page in the Yellow Pages that says “We do plumbing stuff.”

You need a separate page for each major service you offer: - Water heater repair and installation - Drain cleaning - Sewer line repair and replacement - Emergency plumbing - Bathroom remodeling - Garbage disposal repair - Faucet repair and installation - Gas line repair

And each of those pages needs to be written for your city. Not just “Water Heater Repair” - “Water Heater Repair in [Your City].” This is how Google knows to show you when someone in your city searches for that service. We’ll dig deeper into this in Chapter 7, but for now: one page per service is the rule.

City and Service Area Pages

If you serve multiple cities or areas, you need pages for those too. A page for each city you serve, mentioning the services you provide there. This tells Google: “Hey, I’m a plumber in Plano, TX. And also in Frisco. And Allen. And McKinney.”

Without these pages, Google doesn’t know where you work. And if Google doesn’t know, your customers won’t find you.

Real Photos

Stock photos are the fastest way to tell a potential customer “this isn’t a real company.”

People can smell a stock photo from a mile away. The perfectly-lit wrench. The model in a clean uniform who’s clearly never touched a pipe. The spotless bathroom that no plumber has ever actually worked in.

You know what works better? A photo taken on your phone of an actual job you did. Before and after shots. Your team standing in front of your truck. A finished water heater install. A cleared drain. Real work. Real people.

Is it going to look as polished as a stock photo? No. Is it going to build 10x more trust? Yes. Because it's REAL. Customers can tell the difference. And they want real.

Fast Load Time

Your site needs to load in under 3 seconds. Ideally under 2.

Every second over 3 seconds costs you roughly 7% of your visitors. At 8 seconds - Tony's site - you've lost about a third of everyone who tried to visit you. They clicked. They waited. They left. They're calling your competitor now.

You can check your site speed for free at pagespeed.web.dev. Run it. Look at the score. If it's under 50, you have a problem. If it's under 30, you have an emergency.

SSL Certificate (HTTPS)

If your website URL starts with "http://" instead of "https://", Google literally puts a "Not Secure" warning in the browser bar. Think about that. A potential customer visits your site and the first thing they see is their browser telling them your site isn't safe.

That's like hanging a sign on your truck that says "We Might Be Sketchy."

Most modern hosting platforms include SSL for free. There is zero reason not to have it.

Clear Calls to Action on Every Page

Every page on your website should make it painfully obvious what you want the visitor to do next. Call you. Fill out a form. Request a quote.

Not buried at the bottom. Not hidden in a paragraph. Front and center, on every page, in language even a panicking homeowner can understand: “Call us now.” “Get a free quote.” “Schedule service today.”

“I Have a Website” vs. “I Have a Website That Works”

This is the distinction that trips up most plumbers. They think having a website is the checkbox. It’s not. Having a website that actually converts visitors into calls is the checkbox.

Gene learned this the hard way. Gene paid a “marketing company” (a guy he found on Craigslist) \$5,000 for a website three years ago. The guy built something that looked decent on the surface but had zero SEO, no call tracking, broken links on half the pages, and contact forms that emailed a Gmail address the marketing guy still controlled. Gene sent messages into a black hole for 18 months before he realized the forms weren’t going to him.

Gene is now terrified of spending money on a website again. He has what I call “Website PTSD.” He got burned once, and now he’s convinced the whole thing is a scam.

It’s not a scam. Gene just hired the wrong person. And that’s a theme you’ll see throughout this book - the tools aren’t the problem. The strategy (or lack of strategy) is the problem.

A good plumbing website doesn’t need to cost \$10,000. But it does need to be built by someone who understands: - How plumbing customers search online - What Google needs to see to rank your pages - How to convert a visitor into a phone call - The basics of site speed, mobile design, and local SEO

That someone might be a plumbing-specific web company (like mine, like others). That someone might be a local web designer who’s willing to learn

your industry. That someone is NOT your nephew, your buddy's kid, or yourself at midnight with a Wix template and a bit of boredom.

Kenneth's 19-Year Mistake

I'll leave you with one more story before the action items.

Kenneth has been plumbing for 19 years. Nineteen years. He didn't know Google Business Profile was free. He didn't know he could create a listing that shows up on Google Maps when someone searches "plumber near me." For 19 years, Kenneth was invisible to every single person in his city who searched for a plumber online.

When he finally set up his Google Business Profile - a process that took about 20 minutes - he got 8 calls in the first week.

Eight calls. One week. Free.

Nineteen years of lost calls because of a 20-minute setup he didn't know existed.

Kenneth's story isn't really about Google Business Profile (that's the next chapter). It's about this: the things you don't know CAN hurt you. And the gap between "I have a website" and "I have a website that works" might be the most expensive gap in your entire business.

Close the gap.

Pipe Dream vs. Pipeline

Pipe Dream: "I have a website, so I'm good."

Pipeline: "I have a website that's built to convert visitors into phone calls."

Ryan's Rant

Your nephew is a great kid. I'm sure he is. He's probably talented. He's probably learning real skills. And I'm sure he appreciated the Monster.

But building a plumbing company website is not the same as building a Squarespace portfolio for his photography class. It's not the same as making a site for his friend's band. It's not the same as a school project.

A plumbing website has ONE job: make the phone ring. That requires understanding how Google works, how customers think, how mobile design converts, and how local search operates. Your nephew doesn't know any of that. And why would he? He's nineteen.

You wouldn't let me rewire your house because I watched a YouTube video. You wouldn't let your neighbor do your gas line because he "seems handy." You'd want a licensed professional who knows what they're doing.

So why are you letting a non-professional build the single most important marketing asset your business has?

Pay a professional. Get it done right. Stop saving \$3,000 and losing \$300,000.

Wrench Turn Action Items

1. Pull up your website on your phone right now. Not your laptop - your PHONE. Can you call with one tap? Is the phone number visible without scrolling? Does it load in under 3 seconds? If the answer to any of those is no, you have a problem, and it's costing you money today. Not someday. Today.

2. Run your site through Google PageSpeed Insights. Go to pagespeed.web.dev. Type in your website URL. Screenshot the score. If it's below 50 on mobile, your site is actively driving customers away. Show the score to whoever built your site and ask: "Can we fix this?"

3. Count your service pages. Go to your website's navigation. How many service pages do you have? Do you have a separate page for each service you offer? Or is it one "Services" page with a paragraph? Count them. Write the number down. Now count how many services you actually offer. The gap between those two numbers is the gap in your Google visibility.

4. Check for your service area. Look at your website. Does it mention the actual cities and areas you serve? Not just your office address - the places where you drive to do work? If someone in a neighboring city searches “plumber in [that city],” will your website show up? If your city names aren’t on your site, the answer is no.

5. Ask 3 customers this week: “Did you look at our website before you called us?” Listen to what they say. If they say “yes,” ask what they thought. If they say “I couldn’t find it” - that’s your answer. If they say “I looked at a few and chose the one that looked most professional” - that tells you everything you need to know about how your site compares.

Now you know WHY your website matters. Want to see exactly where yours stands?

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/website-checklist. Download the free Website Audit Scorecard - grade your site in 5 minutes.

Want a website that’s actually built to get you calls? Let’s talk:

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/call



CHAPTER 4

“I THINK I HAVE A GOOGLE PAGE... SOMEWHERE”

YOUR GOOGLE BUSINESS PROFILE IS FREE. AND IT’S A GOLDMINE.

“*Wait - that’s free?*” - Kenneth, after 19 years of being invisible on Google

Kenneth has been plumbing for 19 years.

Nineteen years of crawling under houses. Nineteen years of 2am emergency calls. Nineteen years of doing excellent work in a mid-size city with a couple hundred thousand people - plenty of homeowners, plenty of pipes, plenty of demand.

For 19 of those 19 years, Kenneth was invisible.

Not invisible to his existing customers. They knew him. They loved him. They told their friends about him. Kenneth had a small, loyal base of referral clients who kept him busy enough to pay the bills. Not thriving, but surviving. The word-of-mouth story from Chapter 1, basically.

But to the thousands of people in his city who searched “plumber near me” on their phones every single week? Kenneth didn’t exist. He wasn’t on Google Maps. He wasn’t in the search results. He wasn’t anywhere. For 19 years, potential customers looked for a plumber in Kenneth’s city and Kenneth never appeared. Not once.

Because Kenneth didn't know that Google Business Profile existed.

Let me say that again: Kenneth - a licensed plumber, a business owner, a guy running a real company with a truck and tools and 19 years of experience - didn't know that Google offers a FREE listing that puts your business on Google Maps and in local search results. Free. Zero dollars. No catch.

I found this out when I was talking to Kenneth about his marketing. I asked him if his Google Business Profile was optimized. He said, "My what?"

I pulled out my phone. Searched "plumber" plus his city. His competitor popped up first - 4.7 stars, 200+ reviews, photos of the crew, hours listed, services listed, a click-to-call button right there in the results. Second result: another competitor. Third result: another one.

Kenneth was nowhere. Not on page one. Not on page two. Not anywhere. Because he didn't have a listing.

I walked him through setting one up. It took about 20 minutes. Business name, address, phone number, service area, business hours, a few services, a couple of photos he took on his phone of his truck and a recent job.

That week, Kenneth got 8 calls from people who found him on Google Maps.

Eight calls. One week. From a free listing that took 20 minutes to create.

Kenneth told me later: "I've been doing this for 19 years and I never knew this existed. How many calls did I miss?"

I didn't answer him. Because the math was too depressing.

What Is Google Business Profile?

Let's start with the basics, because if Kenneth didn't know this existed after 19 years in business, I'm guessing some of you don't either. And that's okay. That's why I wrote this chapter.

Google Business Profile (GBP) - which used to be called “Google My Business” until Google changed the name because tech companies can’t stop renaming things - is a free tool from Google that lets you manage how your business appears in Google Search and Google Maps.

When someone in your city types “plumber near me” or “emergency plumber” or “water heater repair [your city]” into Google, the results usually show three things:

1. **Ads** at the top (if anyone’s running them - more on that in Chapter 10)
2. **The Map Pack** - a map with three business listings underneath it, showing the business name, star rating, number of reviews, address, phone number, and hours
3. **Organic results** - the regular website links below the map

That Map Pack? The three businesses that show up there? That’s powered by Google Business Profile. If you don’t have a GBP listing, you will NEVER appear in the Map Pack. You’re invisible to anyone who searches on Google Maps. And since nearly half of all Google searches have local intent, you’re invisible to a massive chunk of your potential customers.

Here’s the kicker: **it’s free**. Completely free. Google doesn’t charge you a dime to create and maintain your Business Profile. They WANT you on there, because the more complete and accurate Google Maps is, the better it works for users, which means more people use Google, which means more ad revenue for Google. It’s in their interest to have you there.

You’re not paying for a listing. You’re claiming space that Google is literally giving you for free. And most of your competitors have already claimed theirs.

The Google 3-Pack: The Most Valuable Real Estate in Plumbing Marketing

Here’s something that’ll change how you think about this.

When someone searches “plumber near me” on their phone, the first thing they see (below any ads) is the Map Pack. Three businesses. Just three. With their name, star rating, review count, and a link to call or get directions.

Most people don’t scroll past the Map Pack. They look at those three options, compare the ratings and review counts, and call one. The entire decision - who to trust with their plumbing emergency - happens in about 30 seconds based on what shows up in those three slots.

Being in the 3-Pack is like having a permanent billboard on the busiest intersection in your city. Except it’s not a billboard - it’s an invitation. The person seeing it **ALREADY** needs a plumber. They’re not browsing. They’re not “thinking about it.” They need help **NOW** and they’re looking for someone to call.

And the way you get into the 3-Pack? A complete, optimized, active Google Business Profile.

Not magic. Not luck. Not expensive. Just doing the work of filling out your profile, getting reviews, and keeping it active.

Javier figured this out. He spends about 45 minutes a week on his Google Business Profile. That’s it. Forty-five minutes. He updates his photos, responds to reviews, posts a weekly update about a recent job, and makes sure his information is current.

Javier dominates the local 3-Pack in his area. He shows up first or second for almost every plumbing-related search in his city. He doesn’t run Google Ads. He doesn’t pay for SEO. He just takes care of his GBP listing like a pro.

Forty-five minutes a week. Free. And he gets more calls from Google than he can handle.

What Your Google Business Profile Must Include

If you already have a GBP listing but it’s half-finished, or if you’re about to set one up for the first time, here’s what needs to be there. All of it. No shortcuts.

Business Name, Address, and Phone Number (NAP)

This sounds obvious, but you'd be amazed how many plumbers have the wrong phone number on their Google listing. Or a different business name than what's on their website. Or an old address from before they moved their office.

Your NAP (Name, Address, Phone) needs to be identical everywhere online. Same on Google. Same on your website. Same on Yelp, Facebook, the BBB, everywhere. Google uses consistency across the internet as a trust signal. If your phone number is different on Google than it is on your website, that's a red flag to Google's algorithm. It makes Google less confident about your information, which means you rank lower.

Check this today. Right now. Is everything correct?

All Services Listed Individually

GBP lets you list your services as individual items. Don't just put "Plumbing." List every single service you offer: - Water heater repair - Water heater installation - Drain cleaning - Sewer line repair - Emergency plumbing - Faucet repair - Toilet repair - Gas line repair - Garbage disposal repair - Bathroom remodeling - And whatever else you do

Each service you list gives Google another reason to show you when someone searches for that specific service. The plumber who lists 15 services gets shown for more searches than the plumber who listed "Plumbing" and called it a day.

Business Hours (Including Emergency/After-Hours)

If you offer emergency or after-hours service, say so. A huge number of plumbing searches happen at night and on weekends - because that's when pipes burst and water heaters die. If your listing says "Closed" and your competitor's says "Open 24 Hours," guess who gets the call?

Even if you don't have a 24/7 shop, you can list extended hours or add a note

about emergency service availability. Google shows business hours prominently in search results. Make sure yours are right.

Service Area Defined Properly

If you travel to your customers (which... you're a plumber, so yes, you do), you should set up a service area instead of just showing your office address. You can define the cities, zip codes, or radius you serve. This tells Google where to show you in search results.

A plumber who only lists his office address in Dallas might not show up for searches in Plano, even if Plano is 15 minutes away and well within his service area. Defining your service area fixes that.

Real Photos - Job Photos, Team Photos, Truck Photos

This is where most plumbers leave money on the table.

GBP listings with photos get 42% more requests for directions and 35% more click-throughs to websites than listings without photos. Google published these numbers. They're not theoretical - they're measured.

And yet, most plumbers either have zero photos or have a blurry logo from 2018.

Upload real photos: - Your truck (clean, wrapped if possible) - Your team (even if it's just you) - Before/after shots of jobs you've done - Your work in progress - Happy customers (with their permission)

These don't need to be professional. Phone photos are fine. Actually, phones geotag photos, which is a fancy way of saying that they put coordinates of the location that photo was taken and Google can see this data. This actually makes phones very viable for this. Local photos help prove you didn't pull it from a stock photo site. Real beats polished every time. A photo of you actually fixing a pipe in someone's kitchen builds more trust than any stock photo ever will.

Add new photos regularly. Google notices when a profile is actively updated. Profiles with recent photos rank better than stale ones. Aim for at least 3-5 new photos per month.

Regular Posts

Here's the feature almost nobody uses: GBP posts.

Google Business Profile has a "Posts" feature that lets you publish short updates directly to your listing. Think of them like social media posts, but they show up on your Google listing. You can post about: - A recent job you completed - A seasonal tip ("How to prevent frozen pipes this winter") - A promotion or special offer - A new service you're offering - An event or community involvement

Posts stay visible for about 7 days, so the key is to post at least weekly. This tells Google your business is active and engaged, which helps your ranking. And it gives potential customers more reasons to trust you and call.

Javier posts every Monday. Takes him about 10 minutes. A photo of last week's best job, a quick description, and a call to action. That's part of his 45-minute weekly GBP routine, and it's one of the reasons he dominates the 3-Pack.

GBP Mistakes That Are Costing You Calls

Let me run through the most common mistakes I see plumbers make with their Google Business Profile. If any of these describe you, fix them this week.

Mistake 1: Not Claiming Your Profile

Some plumbers have a Google listing they didn't create. Google sometimes auto-generates listings based on public data - your business name might show up on Maps with basic info even if you never set it up. But if you haven't CLAIMED it, you can't control what it says. The phone number might be wrong. The hours might be wrong. There might be no photos. And worst

of all, anyone can suggest “edits” to an unclaimed listing - including your competitors.

Claim it. Go to business.google.com. Verify ownership. Take control.

Mistake 2: Incomplete Profile

A half-finished profile ranks worse than a complete one. Google has stated this explicitly. If your listing has a name and phone number but no services, no hours, no photos, and no description - you’re telling Google you’re not serious about being found.

Fill out every single field. Every one. The description, the services, the attributes (licensed, woman-owned, veteran-owned, etc.), the hours, the payment methods - everything. It takes 20 minutes. Do it once. Then maintain it.

Mistake 3: No Photos (or Only Old Photos)

We covered this, but it bears repeating. Listings with zero photos get dramatically fewer clicks. Listings with photos from 2019 don’t look much better. Upload new photos regularly. Make it part of your routine.

Mistake 4: Never Responding to Reviews

Google tracks whether you respond to reviews. Businesses that respond to reviews rank higher than those that don’t. Plus, when a potential customer reads your reviews and sees that you respond to every one - thanking the happy ones, professionally addressing the unhappy ones - it builds enormous trust.

Respond to every review. Every single one. We’ll cover reviews in depth in the next chapter.

Mistake 5: Set It and Forget It

Setting up your GBP and never touching it again is like installing a water heater and never doing maintenance. It'll work for a while, but eventually it stops performing. Google rewards active, regularly updated profiles. The plumber who posts weekly, adds photos monthly, and responds to reviews within 24 hours will always outrank the plumber who set up his profile in 2020 and forgot it existed.

The “Free” That’s Actually Free

I know what some of you are thinking. “Ryan, nothing is really free. What’s the catch?”

There is no catch. Google Business Profile is legitimately free. You don’t need to pay Google to create it. You don’t need to run Google Ads to have it (although they complement each other - more on that in Chapters 10 and 11). You don’t need to hire anyone to set it up.

The only “cost” is your time. About 20 minutes to set it up. About 15-45 minutes a week to maintain it. And the return on that time investment is - and I don’t say this lightly - the best ROI in plumbing marketing.

Kenneth got 8 calls his first week from a 20-minute setup. Javier gets 15-20 calls a week from 45 minutes of weekly maintenance. Neither of them pays a dime to Google for those calls.

Find me another marketing channel that costs \$0 and generates 15-20 calls a week. I’ll wait.

Pipe Dream vs. Pipeline

Pipe Dream: “I think someone set up a Google page for me years ago.”

Pipeline: “My Google Business Profile is fully optimized, actively updated, and generating free calls every week.”

Ryan's Rant

This one physically hurts me. Every time I meet a plumber who doesn't have a Google Business Profile, or who has one that's half-finished and abandoned, I feel actual pain. In my chest.

Google - the biggest tech company in the world, the search engine that literally everyone uses to find everything - is giving you a FREE listing. FREE. It shows up when people in YOUR city search for a plumber. It displays your name, your phone number, your reviews, your photos, and a button that calls you with one tap.

And you either haven't claimed it, haven't finished filling it out, or haven't touched it since 2020.

This is free money sitting on the sidewalk. You're stepping over it every single day. You're walking past hundred-dollar bills on your way to the truck and wondering why business is slow.

Go pick up the money. It takes 20 minutes.

Wrench Turn Action Items

1. Google your business name right now. Open an incognito window and search your exact business name. Do you see a Google Business Profile panel on the right side of the screen? If yes - great. Check if the information is correct. If no - go to business.google.com and claim or create your profile TODAY. Not tomorrow. Today.

2. Check the basics: services, hours, phone number. If you have a listing, open it and check. Are ALL your services listed individually? Are your hours correct - including emergency availability? Is the phone number the one that rings your actual phone or office? If any of these are wrong, fix them right now. It takes 5 minutes.

3. Upload 5 real job photos this week. Not stock photos. Real photos from real jobs you've done in the last few months. Before and after shots, completed

installations, your truck, your team. Five photos. This week. Set a timer for 10 minutes and just do it.

4. Write your first Google Business Profile post. Open your GBP dashboard (business.google.com). Click “Add Update.” Post a photo from a recent job with a sentence or two: “Just finished a water heater replacement in [City]. If yours is over 10 years old, it might be time for an upgrade. Give us a call!” That’s it. Done. Your first post.

5. Set a weekly reminder: “Update GBP” - 15 minutes, every Monday. Put it on your calendar. Every Monday morning, before your first job: upload a photo or two from last week’s work, write a quick post, check for new reviews and respond to them. Fifteen minutes. That’s less time than you spend at the supply house. And it’s worth more than you think.

Now you know WHY Google Business Profile is a goldmine. Want the step-by-step setup and optimization guide?

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/google-business-profile. Full walkthrough: creating, verifying, and optimizing your GBP from scratch.

Want us to set up and manage your Google presence for you?

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/call



CHAPTER 5

“MY COMPETITOR HAS 300 REVIEWS AND I HAVE 7”

THE REVIEW RECKONING

“I do good work. The reviews should come naturally.” - The most expensive lie in plumbing

I want you to do something for me right now. Pull out your phone. Open Google Maps. Search “plumber” plus whatever city you’re in.

Look at the first three results - the Map Pack we talked about in the last chapter. Look at two things: the star rating and the number of reviews.

Now let me tell you what your potential customer sees at 10pm on a Saturday night when their basement is flooding.

They see Company A: 4.8 stars, 312 reviews.

They see Company B: 4.6 stars, 47 reviews.

They see Company C: 4.2 stars, 7 reviews.

All three companies might do excellent work. All three might show up on time, fix the problem right, and treat the customer like gold. But the customer doesn’t know that yet. The customer has a flooded basement, a screaming spouse, and about 30 seconds to make a decision.

Who do they call?

They call the one with 312 reviews and 4.8 stars. Every time. It's not even close.

This is the Review Reckoning. And a plumber named Curtis is living it right now.

Curtis has been plumbing for 15 years. Good plumber. Honest. Reliable. The kind of guy who leaves the job site cleaner than he found it. His existing customers love him. They'd vouch for him to anyone.

But Curtis has 7 Google reviews. Seven. After 15 years in business.

It's not that his customers wouldn't leave reviews. It's that Curtis never asked. Not once. In 15 years of fixing toilets, replacing water heaters, snaking drains, and saving people from their own plumbing disasters - Curtis never once said the words: "Hey, would you mind leaving us a Google review?"

He told me why: "I do good work. I figured the reviews would come naturally."

Some did. Seven of them, apparently. Across 15 years and thousands of happy customers, exactly seven people thought to go home, pull out their phone, find Curtis's Google listing, and write a review without being asked.

Seven out of thousands.

Here's the thing about reviews that Curtis didn't understand: **happy customers don't leave reviews. They leave reviews when you ASK them to.** It's not that they don't want to help you. It's that they forget. They're busy. They got their plumbing fixed and moved on with their lives. The thought "I should leave a review" crosses their mind for about 4 seconds while they're still standing in their kitchen watching you pack up your tools. By the time they sit down on the couch, it's gone. Replaced by whatever's on Netflix.

You have to capture that moment. You have to ask.

Curtis didn't ask. And it cost him more than he realizes.

The Fake Review That Almost Killed Curtis's Business

Here's where Curtis's story gets worse.

Last year, a competitor - or someone pretending to be a customer - left a one-star review on Curtis's Google listing. The review was vague, aggressive, and clearly not from an actual customer. Something like "Terrible service, overcharged, would never use again. AVOID." Curtis had never heard of the person. The job described in the review didn't match anything in his records.

Before the fake review, Curtis had a 4.5-star rating with 7 reviews. After it? His rating dropped to 4.1 stars with 8 reviews. One fake review tanked his rating by nearly half a star.

If Curtis had 200 reviews at 4.7 stars, that same fake one-star review would have barely moved the needle - maybe dropping him to 4.69 stars. Invisible. Meaningless. Absorbed by the sheer volume of legitimate positive reviews.

But with only 7 reviews, Curtis had no armor. One bad review - a fake one, no less - did serious damage. He went from "looks decent" to "maybe I should keep scrolling" in the eyes of every potential customer who saw his listing.

Volume isn't just about looking impressive. Volume is protection. The more reviews you have, the less any single negative review can hurt you. It's basic math. And it's the reason plumbers with 300+ reviews sleep better at night than plumbers with 7.

Curtis eventually got the fake review removed (which took 3 months and a lot of back-and-forth with Google support - not a fun process). But for those 3 months, every person who searched for a plumber in his city saw a 4.1-star rating and kept scrolling.

93% of Consumers Say Reviews Impact Their Buying Decisions

Let that number sink in.

Ninety-three percent. That's according to BrightLocal's annual consumer survey, and the number has been climbing every year. When someone needs a plumber, they're not just looking at who shows up on Google. They're looking at what other people say about who shows up on Google.

Here's what reviews do for you:

They build instant trust. A customer who's never heard of you sees your listing with 200 reviews and a 4.8-star rating and thinks: "These guys are legit." That trust took you zero effort to build in that moment - it was built by every previous customer who left a review. It's trust at scale.

They influence the click. When someone sees the Map Pack with three plumbers listed, the one with the most reviews and the highest rating gets the click. Not always - but the vast majority of the time. More reviews = more clicks = more calls.

They help your Google ranking. Google has confirmed that reviews are a ranking factor for local search. More reviews, higher ratings, and recent review activity all signal to Google that your business is legitimate, active, and trusted. This means reviews don't just look good to customers - they help you show up higher in search results.

They provide social proof. When a potential customer reads your reviews and sees things like "showed up on time," "explained everything clearly," "fair price," "fixed it right the first time" - they're basically reading a pre-written sales pitch from people who have no reason to lie. That's more powerful than anything you could say about yourself.

They create a compound effect. This is the big one. Every review you get makes it easier to get the next one (because you look more established) and harder for competitors to catch up. It's a snowball rolling downhill. And the longer you wait to start rolling it, the bigger the gap gets between you and the plumber who started rolling theirs a year ago.

The Review Generation System

Alright. You know reviews matter. You know you don't have enough. So how do you fix it?

It's simpler than you think. You need a system. Not a complicated one. Not an expensive one. Just a repeatable process that turns happy customers into Google reviews consistently.

Here's the system that works. It's the same system that Connor - a plumber I talked to - uses to generate 15 reviews per month on autopilot.

Step 1: Identify the Magic Moment

There's a moment during every successful service call when the customer is at peak satisfaction. It's usually right after you've finished the job, shown them the completed work, and they've said something like "Oh my God, thank you so much" or "You saved my life" or just given you that look of pure relief.

That's the magic moment. That's when their gratitude is at its highest and their resistance to doing you a favor is at its lowest. That is the moment you ask.

Not before the job - they don't trust you yet. Not a week later - they've forgotten. RIGHT THEN. When they're standing in their kitchen, relieved, grateful, and happy.

Step 2: Ask. Out Loud. In Person.

"Hey, if you're happy with the work, I'd really appreciate a Google review. It helps us out more than you'd think."

That's it. That's the script. You don't need a 3-paragraph speech. You don't need to be awkward about it. You just ask.

Here's what's wild: the vast majority of customers will say yes. They WANT to help you. You just fixed their plumbing problem. They're grateful. Leaving a review is a small way to say thank you. But they need the nudge. They need you to ask.

Dwight - another plumber I talked to - has 14 reviews after 14 years. When I asked him why, he said he was afraid of asking. “What if they say no? What if they’re not happy?” Dwight’s fear of an awkward moment has cost him 14 years of review growth. Don’t be Dwight.

Step 3: Send a Follow-Up Text Within 1 Hour

This is the step that 10x’s your conversion rate.

After you leave the job, send a text message. Within an hour. While the experience is still fresh in their mind. Here’s a template:

“Hey [Name], thanks for choosing [Your Company]! If you had a great experience, a Google review would mean the world to us. Just tap here: [direct review link]. Thanks again! - [Your Name]”

That direct review link is critical. It takes them straight to the Google review form for your business - no searching, no clicking around, no confusion. One tap and they’re writing.

How do you get that link? Go to OnlyPlumbingSites.com/Local-Business-Review-Link and follow the instructions. You will get a link + a QR code you can use and It takes less than a minute. Save it in your phone. You’ll use it every single day.

Connor automates this. He uses a simple CRM that sends the text automatically after a job is marked complete. He doesn’t even have to think about it. The system runs itself.

If you don’t have a CRM, you can do it manually. Save the text template and the review link in your phone. After every job, open your messages, paste the template, change the name, and send. Takes 30 seconds.

Step 4: Follow Up Once More at 24-48 Hours

Not everyone will leave a review right away. Life gets in the way. A gentle follow-up - just one - at 24-48 hours catches the people who meant to do it but forgot.

“Hey [Name], just checking in - hope everything is working great! If you get a chance, that Google review really helps us out: [link]. No worries if not. Thanks!”

That’s it. One follow-up. Not five. Not ten. You’re not pestering anyone. You’re giving them a gentle reminder.

Step 5: Make It Stupid Easy

The number one reason people don’t leave reviews (after not being asked) is that it’s too hard. They don’t know where to go. They can’t find your listing. They give up.

Your direct review link solves this. One tap. They’re on the review form. All they have to do is pick a star rating and write a sentence or two. Make it so easy that the only excuse not to do it is “I’m literally unconscious.” You can use the QR code as well on your business cards, invoices and anywhere you can print it for your customers. It works. Do it.

Technology is advancing so fast that now you can even insert your code into a ‘tap to review’ NFC card. They simply tap their phone and it opens the review link on their phone. At this rate we will eventually be able to think about asking them for a review and they will get the ping in their brain and tell us what they really think of us...scary... but in all seriousness, the easier you make it for your customers to leave a review the more likely you are to get one.

The Compound Math

Let me show you what this system looks like over time.

If you start asking for reviews and get 5 per week - which is absolutely achievable if you’re doing 3-5 jobs a day and asking every customer - here’s what happens:

- **After 1 month:** 20 new reviews
- **After 3 months:** 60 new reviews
- **After 6 months:** 130 new reviews
- **After 1 year:** 260 new reviews
- **After 2 years:** 520 new reviews

In two years, you'd have over 500 Google reviews. That's not a nice-to-have. That's a fortress. That's an impenetrable wall of social proof that no competitor can tear down.

Curtis went from 7 reviews to 7 reviews in 15 years because he never asked. Connor went from 0 to 180 in one year because he has a system. Same amount of time on the job. Same quality of work. Completely different visibility and growth trajectory.

The difference isn't talent. It's a system.

How to Handle Negative Reviews

Let's talk about the thing plumbers fear most about reviews: the bad ones.

Here's the truth: **you will get negative reviews**. It doesn't matter how good you are. Someone will be unhappy. Someone will leave a one-star review. It's not a matter of if - it's when.

And here's the other truth: **negative reviews are not the end of the world**. In fact, handled correctly, they can actually help you.

Rule 1: Don't Panic

One negative review among 200 positive ones is not a crisis. It's a blip. Most customers actually trust businesses MORE when they see a mix of reviews, because a perfect 5.0 with 15 reviews looks fake, while a 4.8 with 300 reviews looks real.

Rule 2: Don't Fight

Never, ever argue with a reviewer publicly. Never get defensive. Never accuse them of lying (even if they are). The response isn't for them - it's for every future customer who reads it.

Dante learned this the hard way. He got a fake review, responded with an angry paragraph calling the reviewer a liar, and ended up getting threatened with a defamation lawsuit. Cost him \$12,000 in legal fees. All because he fought a review instead of responding professionally.

Rule 3: Respond Professionally

Here's a template for negative reviews that works every time:

"Hi [Name], I'm sorry to hear about your experience. This isn't the standard we hold ourselves to, and I'd like to make it right. Please reach out to us at [phone/email] so we can discuss this directly. Thank you for your feedback."

That's it. Professional. Empathetic. Takes it offline. Every potential customer who reads that response thinks: "These guys care enough to respond. That's a good sign."

Rule 4: Bury Them With Volume

The best defense against negative reviews is positive volume. If you're getting 5 positive reviews a week, a single negative one disappears into the background immediately. It's like a drop of food coloring in a swimming pool - technically it's there, but nobody notices.

This is another reason the system matters. It's not just about looking good. It's about protection.

Responding to Positive Reviews (Yes, Do This 'Too)

Most plumbers ignore positive reviews. “They said something nice. Cool. Moving on.”

Wrong.

Responding to positive reviews matters for two reasons:

1. Google notices. Businesses that respond to all reviews - positive and negative - rank higher than businesses that don't respond at all. Google has confirmed that responsiveness is a factor in local search ranking. Free ranking boost for 30 seconds of typing.

2. It builds loyalty. When a customer takes the time to leave a nice review and you respond personally - “Thanks, Mike! It was great working with you. That kitchen faucet was a beast but we got it done!” - they feel appreciated. They become a fan. They refer you to everyone. They're YOUR customer for life.

Respond to every review within 24 hours. Positive and negative. Make it personal - use their name, reference the specific job if possible. It takes 30 seconds per review and the ROI is enormous.

Want an extremely useful tip? Throw some keywords into your response for SEO. “Thanks Mike! I love doing plumbing in Buffalo Grove, it's such a nice area. Truly enjoyed helping you with your water heater replacement.”

Did you see what I did there? I am using another way of ‘helping’ Google to understand that I do ‘plumbing in Buffalo Grove’, specifically for this customer, a ‘water heater replacement’. It's even better if your customer uses the keywords, but don't push them too hard for it. You want them to be organic. Pair this with a geotagged image of the work that was performed on your website or GBP and Google is sure to give you more potential to rank for those keywords when a future customer searches. Let's be honest, If you don't send those signals to Google, how will they ever know?

Otis's Secret: Timing Is Everything

One more data point before the action items.

A plumber named Otis discovered something interesting about review timing. He tested asking for reviews at different points in the customer interaction:

- Asking right after the job, before payment: **18% left a review**
- Asking right after payment, at the door: **35% left a review**
- Sending a text 2 hours after payment: **25% left a review**

The sweet spot? Right after payment. That's when the transaction feels complete, the customer is satisfied, and the relief is still fresh. They've paid, they feel good about the value, and they're in a generous mood.

Otis adjusted his process: finish the job, collect payment, then immediately say "Thanks so much. If you're happy, a Google review would really help us out. I'll send you a link right now." or even better, "scan this QR code or Tap this 'Review Us' card for convenience!" His review conversion rate nearly doubled.

The lesson: timing matters. Right after payment. That's the magic moment.

Pipe Dream vs. Pipeline

Pipe Dream: "I do good work. The reviews will come naturally."

Pipeline: "I do good work AND I have a system that turns every happy customer into a Google review."

Ryan's Rant

You just fixed someone's toilet at 11pm on a Saturday. They called you in a panic. You showed up in 45 minutes. You solved the problem. They hugged you. They literally HUGGED you. They told you you're a lifesaver.

And then you... packed up your tools. Collected payment. Said goodnight. Drove home.

You didn't ask for a review.

That customer - the one who was so grateful they'd name their firstborn after you - went back to watching TV and forgot about the whole thing by Monday. That's like catching a fish and throwing it back. You had it. It was right there. And you let it go.

EVERY. SINGLE. TIME.

Five words. That's all it takes. "Would you leave a review?" Five words. Say them today. Say them tomorrow. Say them on every single job for the rest of your career. Watch what happens.

Wrench Turn Action Items

1. Create your direct Google review link right now. Visit OnlyPlumbingSites.com/Local-Business-Review-Link. Follow the steps. It takes less than a minute. Save the link and/or the QR code in your phone's notes. This is the link you'll text to every customer from now on. If you don't have this link, you can't run the system. Get it now.

2. Save the review link and text it to your next 5 customers TODAY. Use this template: *"Hey [Name], thanks for choosing [Company]! If you had a great experience, a Google review would mean the world: [link]. Thanks! - [Your Name]."* Send it to your next 5 customers. Don't overthink it. Just send it.

3. Write your standard follow-up text and save it as a template. Most phones let you save text templates or shortcuts. Write the review request text once, save it, and you'll never have to type it again. Change the customer name each time. That's it.

4. Set a goal: 5 new reviews per week minimum. Write it on a whiteboard. Tell your team. Track it weekly. Five per week is 260 per year. In 12 months, you'll have transformed your online presence. In 24 months, you'll be untouchable.

5. Respond to EVERY existing review within 24 hours - starting today. Go to your Google Business Profile right now. Read every review you've received.

Respond to each one. Thank the positive ones personally. Address the negative ones professionally. Then make it a daily habit: check for new reviews every morning and respond before your first job.

Now you know WHY reviews are the new word of mouth. Want the complete system - scripts, templates, automation setup?

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/reviews. The Complete Google Review System for Plumbers - everything you need to go from 7 to 700.

Want us to set up an automated review system for your company?

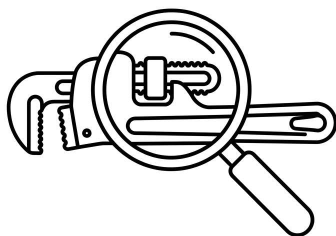
OnlyPlumbingSites.com/call

PART III

GETTING FOUND ON GOOGLE

“If you’re not on page one, you don’t exist. Page two of Google is where businesses go to die.”

-Ryan Pietrzak





CHAPTER 6

“HOW MUCH DOES SEO COST?”

YOU'RE ASKING THE WRONG QUESTION

“I’ve spent \$40,000 on SEO and I still don’t know what they did.” - Marcus, a plumber who’s been burned four times

I get this question every week. Usually in an email. Sometimes on a phone call. Occasionally someone walks up to me at a trade show and asks it before they even say hello.

“How much does SEO cost?”

And every week, my answer is the same: “That’s the wrong question.”

It’s not that the question doesn’t matter. It does. But starting with “how much does it cost?” is like starting a plumbing job by asking “how much does the fitting cost?” before you even know what’s broken. You need context. You need to understand what you’re buying, what it does, and what happens if you don’t buy it.

The right question - the question that changes everything - is this:

“What is it COSTING me to NOT show up on Google?”

Let me do the math for you.

The average plumbing customer is worth somewhere between \$500 and \$1,500 on a single job. Higher if you factor in lifetime value (Chapter 2). Let's use a conservative number: \$700 average job.

If you're not showing up on page one of Google for your main services in your city, you're missing out on somewhere between 20 and 50 potential calls per month. Those are people actively searching for a plumber. In your area. Right now. And they're calling someone else because they can't find you.

Let's say you're missing 30 calls a month. With a 60% close rate, that's 18 jobs. At \$700 each, that's \$12,600 per month in revenue you're not getting. Per month. That's \$151,200 per year.

Now. How much does SEO cost? Typically \$1,000-\$5,000 per month for a legitimate provider doing real work for a plumbing company.

So the question isn't "can I afford \$1,500/month for SEO?" The question is "can I afford to lose \$12,600/month because I'm invisible on Google?"

That's the reframe. And it's the one that changes how plumbers think about SEO.

But before we go any further, I need to tell you about Marcus. Because Marcus's story is the reason most plumbers are terrified of SEO - and it's not because SEO doesn't work.

Marcus has been plumbing for 18 years. Good plumber. Smart business owner. And over the last 8 years, Marcus has hired four different marketing agencies to handle his SEO.

Agency #1 charged him \$800/month. They said they'd "optimize his website and build backlinks." After 6 months, Marcus asked what they'd actually done. They sent him a report full of graphs and arrows pointing up. The graphs showed "impressions" and "crawl activity." Marcus didn't understand any of it. His phone wasn't ringing any more than before. He fired them.

Agency #2 charged him \$1,200/month. They redesigned his website (which was fine, but didn't need redesigning) and wrote a few blog posts about topics like "The History of Indoor Plumbing." Interesting stuff if you're writing a term paper. Useless for getting calls from homeowners with burst pipes. Eight months in, Marcus asked for his ranking report. He was on page 3 for "plumber Kansas City." He fired them.

Agency #3 was the most expensive - \$2,000/month. They were aggressive in their pitch. "We'll get you on page one in 90 days." Four months later, Marcus was still on page 2 for his main keywords. When he confronted them, they said "SEO timelines can vary." He fired them.

Agency #4 was the one that really stung. They charged \$1,500/month and seemed to be doing real work. Monthly reports, keyword tracking, the whole thing. After a year, Marcus looked at the keywords they'd ranked him for. His top-ranking keyword? "Residential plumbing pipe repair Kansas City Missouri emergency licensed." A 10-word keyword that exactly zero humans have ever typed into Google. His report showed a #1 ranking. His phone showed zero new calls.

Marcus has spent over \$40,000 on SEO across four agencies. His phone doesn't ring any more than it did before he started. He's not on page one for a single keyword that anyone actually searches for.

Marcus isn't anti-SEO. He's been burned. Four times. By four different companies that either didn't know what they were doing, didn't care, or were actively taking advantage of him.

And here's the thing: **Marcus's experience is not unusual.** I talk to plumbers every week who have a version of this story. They hired someone for SEO, paid thousands of dollars, and got nothing to show for it. And now they think SEO is a scam.

SEO is not a scam. Bad SEO providers are a scam. And the plumbing industry is full of them.

So What IS SEO, Actually?

Let me strip away all the jargon and explain this the way I'd explain it to a plumber buddy at dinner.

SEO stands for Search Engine Optimization. It's the process of making your website show up higher in Google search results when someone searches for something related to your services.

When someone in your city types “emergency plumber near me” or “water heater repair [your city]” into Google, the results they see are determined by Google's algorithm. That algorithm looks at hundreds of factors to decide which websites to show first. SEO is the practice of making your website as appealing as possible to that algorithm.

Think of it this way: Google is like a homeowner looking for a plumber. The homeowner wants someone who's: - **Relevant** (actually does the service they need, in their area) - **Trustworthy** (other people vouch for them - reviews, references) - **Professional** (their “storefront” - your website - looks legit) - **Active** (they're currently in business, not a ghost) - **Experienced** (they've been doing this for a while and have a track record).

Google looks for the same things, just in digital form: - **Relevant:** Does your website have pages about the specific services people are searching for? - **Trustworthy:** Do other websites link to yours? Do you have reviews? - **Professional:** Is your website fast, mobile-friendly, and well-built? - **Active:** Is your content recent? Is your Google Business Profile updated? - **Experienced:** How long has your website been around? How much quality content does it have?

That's SEO. It's not magic. It's not a secret code. It's making your digital presence as strong as possible so Google trusts you enough to recommend you to searchers.

The Three Pillars of Local SEO

For plumbers - and really any local service business - SEO breaks down into three main areas. I'm going to give you the overview here, and then Chapters 7, 8, and 9 go deeper into each one.

Pillar 1: Google Business Profile

We covered this in Chapter 4. Your GBP listing is a massive part of local SEO. A complete, optimized, active profile with lots of reviews is one of the strongest signals you can send to Google. If you skipped Chapter 4, go back and read it.

Pillar 2: On-Page SEO

This is everything **ON** your website that helps Google understand what you do and where you do it. Service pages, city pages, title tags, meta descriptions, headers, content - all the stuff that makes your website relevant to the searches people are typing in. Chapter 7 covers this in detail.

Pillar 3: Off-Page SEO and Technical Foundations

This is everything **OUTSIDE** your website that builds trust. Backlinks (other websites linking to yours), citations (your business listed in online directories with consistent information), and technical factors like site speed, mobile-friendliness, schema markup, and security. Chapters 8 and 9 cover these.

All three pillars work together. You can't dominate local search with just one. A great GBP listing with a terrible website won't get you to page one. A great website with zero reviews and no GBP listing won't either. It's the combination that works.

How to Evaluate an SEO Provider (Without Getting Burned)

Since Marcus's story is unfortunately common, let me give you the red flags and green flags to look for when hiring someone for SEO.

Red Flags - Run Away If You See These:

“We'll get you to page one in 30 days.” No they won't. SEO takes time. Legitimate results take 3-6 months minimum, often longer in competitive markets. Anyone promising page one in 30 days is either lying or using tactics that will get your site penalized by Google.

“We can't tell you exactly what we'll do.” A good SEO provider should be able to explain their strategy in plain English. If they hide behind jargon, that's a red flag. You deserve to know what you're paying for.

“Just trust us - look at the reports.” Reports full of graphs and arrows mean nothing if your phone isn't ringing. The only metrics that matter are: ranking for keywords people actually search, website traffic from your target area, and leads/calls generated. If a provider can't connect their work to those three things, they're hiding something.

Long-term contracts with no performance clauses. Be very cautious about 12-month contracts with no ability to cancel if results aren't delivered. Good providers don't need to lock you in. Their results keep you around.

No plumbing or home service experience. SEO for a plumbing company is different from SEO for a restaurant or a law firm. The keywords are different, the competition is different, the customer behavior is different. A provider with experience in your industry will get results faster.

They own your website or content. Some agencies build your website on their own hosting, using their own accounts. If you leave, you lose everything. Make sure you own your domain, your hosting, your Google Business Profile, and your content. Always.

Green Flags - This Is What You Want:

They explain their strategy clearly. They should be able to tell you: “In month one, we’re going to do X, Y, and Z. Here’s why. Here are the keywords we’re targeting. Here’s how we’ll measure success.”

They show you what they’re doing monthly. Not just graphs - actual work. Pages created, content written, links built, GBP updates made. You should be able to see and understand what your money bought.

They track rankings AND calls. Rankings matter, but only if they translate to calls. A good provider tracks both and shows you the connection. Roland - another plumber I talked to - had an SEO company that tripled his website traffic. Sounds great, right? Except the traffic was all from people searching informational keywords like “how does a toilet work.” Traffic tripled. Calls stayed flat. Revenue unchanged. The provider was targeting the wrong keywords - informational instead of transactional.

They have references from other plumbing companies. Ask for them. Call them. Ask the references: “Did your phone ring more? How long did it take? Are you still using them?”

Results take 3-6 months, and they tell you that upfront. Honesty about timelines is one of the best indicators of a legitimate provider. SEO is a long game. Anyone who tells you otherwise is selling you something that doesn’t exist.

Neil’s Three Questions

A plumber named Neil got burned by an SEO company that charged him \$18,000 over 12 months. They ranked him for zero-volume keywords - terms that technically existed in Google but that nobody ever searched for. Lots of green arrows in reports. Zero phone calls.

After that experience, Neil developed three questions he now asks every marketing provider before hiring them:

1. **“What specific keywords are you going to target, and what’s the monthly search volume for each one?”** If they can’t answer this with specific keywords and real numbers, walk away. You want to rank for things people actually type into Google - like “emergency plumber [city]” or “water heater repair near me” - not made-up long-tail phrases nobody searches.

2. **“How will you report on calls and leads - not just rankings?”** Rankings are a means to an end. The end is calls. If a provider can’t show you how many calls their work generated, they’re tracking the wrong thing.

3. **“Can you give me three references from plumbing companies you currently work with?”** Not testimonials on their website. Actual phone numbers of actual plumbing company owners you can call and ask: “Is your phone ringing more?” If they can’t provide this, that tells you everything.

Neil says these three questions have saved him from two more bad hires since then. They’re simple. They’re direct. And they expose providers who can’t deliver.

The Javier Approach: DIY Google Domination

Not every plumber needs to hire an SEO company. Javier doesn’t have one. He dominates local search with a combination of:

1. **A well-built website** with service pages for each service and city page for his main service area (Chapter 7)
2. **An active Google Business Profile** he updates weekly (Chapter 4)
3. **200+ Google reviews** from his systematic review process (Chapter 5)
4. **Consistent directory listings** on Yelp, BBB, Angi, and 12 other platforms with identical NAP information
5. **A few blog posts** answering common customer questions (Chapter 8)

Total monthly cost: \$0 (beyond his website hosting). Total weekly time investment: about 2 hours. Result: dominates the 3-Pack in his area and gets 15-20 calls a week from Google.

Javier is proof that you don't NEED to pay for SEO to get results. You need a solid foundation, consistency, and patience. The paid SEO route gets results faster and goes deeper, but the fundamentals are available to anyone willing to put in the time.

The Real Question

So let me come back to where we started.

“How much does SEO cost?”

The answer: \$0 to \$5,000+ per month, depending on whether you do it yourself or hire someone.

But that was always the wrong question. The right questions are:

1. **What is it costing me to NOT show up on Google?** (Probably \$5,000-\$15,000+ per month in missed revenue.)
2. **Do I want to do this myself or hire someone?** (Both are valid - Chapter 7 and the website give you the DIY tools.)
3. **If I hire someone, how do I avoid getting burned?** (Neil's three questions. Red flags and green flags above.)

SEO isn't optional anymore. Not in 2026. Not when 68% of online experiences start with a search engine and 75% of people never scroll past page one. You're either on page one or you're invisible. There's no in between.

The only question left is: how are you going to get there?

Pipe Dream vs. Pipeline

Pipe Dream: “SEO is too expensive and takes too long.”

Pipeline: “SEO is an investment that compounds over time. Every month I’m more visible, getting more calls, and making my competitors more irrelevant.”

Ryan’s Rant

You drop \$10,000 on a new jetter without blinking. Because it makes you money. You spend \$5,000 on a camera system. Because it gets you jobs. You buy a \$60,000 truck. Because you need it for the work.

But \$1,500 a month to show up when people are LITERALLY typing “I need a plumber” into Google?

“That’s too expensive.”

Make it make sense.

Your jetter is a tool that makes you money. SEO is a tool that makes you money. The only difference is that one fits in your truck and the other lives on the internet. But they both do the same thing: they bring in revenue that’s worth more than what you paid.

Stop thinking of SEO as a cost. Start thinking of it as a tool. The plumber who invests in the right tools wins every time. On the job AND online.

Wrench Turn Action Items

1. Google “[your main service] + [your city]” in an incognito browser. Right now. What shows up? Are you on page one? Page two? Nowhere? Write down where you are and who’s above you. That’s your starting point. You can’t improve what you don’t measure.

2. Check your Google Business Profile: is every section filled out? Go to business.google.com and look at your profile completeness. Services listed? Hours correct? Photos uploaded? Description written? Every empty field is a missed opportunity to rank higher.

3. Count your top 3 local competitors' Google reviews. Write the numbers down. Search for plumbers in your area. Look at the top 3 in the Map Pack. How many reviews do they have? What's their star rating? Now look at yours. The gap between their numbers and yours is the gap you need to close.

4. Calculate your average customer value times 20. Take your average job ticket (from Chapter 2) and multiply by 20. That's a rough estimate of what you're leaving on the table each month if you're invisible on Google. Write that number down. Look at it. Let it make you uncomfortable. Then keep reading.

5. If you're going to invest in SEO, interview at least 3 providers. Ask each one Neil's three questions: What keywords and what's the volume? How will you report on calls? Can I talk to three plumbing company references? Compare their answers. The one who's clearest, most specific, and most honest is probably the one to hire.

Now you know WHY SEO matters and how to evaluate a provider. Want the complete SEO guide - DIY and done-for-you options?

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/seo-guide. SEO for Plumbers: The Complete Guide - what it is, what it costs, how to not get burned.

Want us to handle your SEO so you can focus on plumbing?

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/call



CHAPTER 7

“WHAT IS A SERVICE PAGE?”

ON-PAGE SEO - WHAT’S ON YOUR WEBSITE MATTERS

“*I have a Services page. That covers it, right?*” - Travis, page 4 of Google

Travis is a smart plumber. Runs a clean operation. Shows up on time. Does quality work. Charges fair prices. He also built his own website one weekend on Wix because he figured, “How hard can it be?”

Here’s what Travis built:

Page 1: Home. A photo of his truck, his company name, his phone number, and a paragraph that says “Quality plumbing services for the greater [city] area.”

Page 2: About. Two paragraphs about how he started plumbing in 2011, loves serving his community, and treats every customer like family.

Page 3: Services. A single page with a single paragraph: “We offer residential and commercial plumbing services including water heater repair, drain cleaning, sewer line repair, faucet installation, toilet repair, garbage disposal replacement, gas line repair, bathroom remodeling, and more. Call us today for a free estimate!”

Three pages. That's the whole website.

Travis looked at it when he was done and thought, "That looks pretty good." And honestly? The design wasn't terrible. Clean layout. Nice colors. His logo looked sharp.

But Travis is on page 4 of Google. Page 4 might as well be page 400. Nobody has ever in the history of the internet said, "You know what? Let me check page 4 of Google for a plumber." It doesn't happen.

Meanwhile, Travis's competitor has 25 pages on his website. Not because he likes writing - because each page targets a specific service in a specific city. "Water Heater Repair in [City]." "Drain Cleaning in [City]." "Emergency Plumber in [City]." "Sewer Line Replacement in [City]." Twenty-five pages. Twenty-five chances to show up on Google. Twenty-five fishing lines in the water.

Travis has one bullet. His competitor has a machine gun.

And the thing is, Travis's competitor doesn't do better work than Travis. His website just TALKS about more things. And Google can only rank you for things your website talks about.

Google Can Only Rank You for What Your Website Says

This is the single most important concept in on-page SEO, and I need you to understand it before we go any further.

Google is not psychic. It can't read your mind. It doesn't know you're great at water heater repair unless your website has a page that talks about water heater repair. It doesn't know you serve Plano, Texas, unless your website mentions Plano, Texas. It doesn't know you offer emergency service unless your website says you offer emergency service.

Google reads your website and says: "Okay, this website talks about [these topics] in [these areas]. When someone searches for one of those topics in one of those areas, I'll consider showing this website."

That's it. That's how it works. If your website doesn't mention it, Google doesn't know about it. And if Google doesn't know about it, you won't show up when someone searches for it.

Travis's website mentions "plumbing services" once, on a single page, in a single paragraph. That's one signal to Google. His competitor's website mentions "water heater repair" on a dedicated 800-word page with photos, FAQs, pricing context, and a call to action - all targeted at a specific city. That's a hundred signals to Google. For one service. Multiply by 25 pages and you start to see why Travis is on page 4 and his competitor is on page 1.

This is not about writing novels. This is about giving Google enough information to confidently rank you for the searches your customers are typing in.

The Service Page Formula

A service page is a dedicated page on your website for ONE specific service. Not all your services crammed onto one page. ONE service per page.

Here's what each service page needs:

A Keyword-Focused Title

The page title should include the service AND your city. This is the most basic and most important element of on-page SEO.

- **Good:** "Water Heater Repair in Dallas, TX | [Your Company Name]"
- **Bad:** "Services"
- **Worse:** "What We Do"

This title appears in two places: in the browser tab when someone visits your page, and in Google's search results as the clickable blue link. It's the first thing Google reads to understand what the page is about. Make it count.

A Clear Header That Matches the Search

The main heading on the page (the big text at the top) should clearly state what the page is about.

- **Good:** “Professional Water Heater Repair in Dallas”
- **Bad:** “Our Services”
- **Worse:** “Welcome!”

Think about what your customer is typing into Google. They’re typing “water heater repair Dallas.” Your page heading should match that intent as closely as possible without sounding robotic.

Useful Content - 500 to 1,000 Words

This is where most plumbers freeze up. “I’m not a writer. I don’t know what to put on the page.”

Here’s what to write about. Answer these questions on each service page:

1. **What is this service?** Explain what water heater repair involves. Not in technical jargon - in language a homeowner understands.
2. **Why might someone need it?** Common signs their water heater needs repair: no hot water, strange noises, rusty water, leaking, pilot light won’t stay lit.
3. **What should they expect?** What happens when they call you? How long does it take? What does the process look like?
4. **Pricing context.** You don’t need exact prices (though some plumbers do - and it works, like Dennis who puts prices on his website and does \$1.1M/year). But give a range or a starting point: “Water heater repair typically ranges from \$150-\$500 depending on the issue.”
5. **Why choose you?** Licensed, insured, experienced, local, great reviews. One or two sentences.

- 6. Call to action.** “Need water heater repair in Dallas? Call us now at [number] or fill out the form below.”

That’s it. That’s a service page. You could write it in an hour. And it’ll work for you 24/7 for years.

Real Photos

Include at least one or two photos on each service page. A before/after of a water heater you replaced. A photo of you working on a water heater. Your team standing next to a completed install.

Real photos build trust and keep people on the page longer. Both are good for SEO.

A Strong Call to Action

Every service page should end (and ideally also start) with a clear CTA. A phone number. A “Call Now” button. A contact form. Something that makes it easy for the visitor to become a customer.

Don’t be subtle. Don’t bury it. Make it obvious. “Ready to get your water heater fixed? Call [number] now - we’re available 24/7.”

The City Page Strategy

Service pages tell Google what you do. City pages tell Google where you do it.

If you serve multiple cities - and most plumbers do - you need pages for those cities too. A city page is similar to a service page, but focused on a geographic area rather than a specific service.

For example, if you're based in Dallas but also serve Plano, Frisco, Allen, and McKinney, you'd want pages like:

- “Plumber in Plano, TX”
- “Plumber in Frisco, TX”
- “Plumber in Allen, TX”
- “Plumber in McKinney, TX”

Each page talks about the plumbing services you offer in that specific city. Mention the city name naturally throughout the content. Reference local landmarks or neighborhoods if you can. Include your service area map.

Without these pages, Google has no reason to show you when someone in Plano searches “plumber near me.” Your website doesn't mention Plano. As far as Google knows, you don't serve Plano. Even if it's 15 minutes from your shop.

City pages fix that. They tell Google: “Yes, I serve this area. Show me to people who search here.”

The Power Combo: Service + City Pages

For maximum coverage, you can combine the two. Instead of just “Water Heater Repair” and “Plumber in Plano,” you create:

- “Water Heater Repair in Plano, TX”
- “Drain Cleaning in Plano, TX”
- “Emergency Plumber in Plano, TX”

Now you're targeting specific service + specific city combinations. These are the exact phrases customers type into Google. And when your page matches exactly what they searched for, Google is much more likely to show you.

Is this a lot of pages? It can be. A plumber with 8 services and 5 cities could have 40+ pages. But each of those pages is another fishing line in the water.

Another chance to get found. Another potential customer who finds YOU instead of your competitor.

You don't have to build all 40 at once. Start with your highest-revenue service in your primary city. Then add one or two pages a week. In a few months, you'll have a website that covers your entire service area for every major service.

Title Tags, Meta Descriptions, and Headers - The Basics

I'm going to keep this simple because I promised I wouldn't turn you into a web developer. But there are three elements on every page that Google pays special attention to, and you (or whoever manages your website) need to get them right.

Title Tag

This is the text that appears in the browser tab and as the blue clickable link in Google search results. It's the most important on-page SEO element.

Formula: [Service] in [City], [State] | [Company Name] **Example:** "Water Heater Repair in Dallas, TX | Johnson Plumbing"

Keep it under 60 characters so it doesn't get cut off in search results.

Meta Description

This is the short description that appears under the title in Google search results. It doesn't directly affect rankings, but it affects whether someone clicks on your link. Think of it as a mini ad.

Formula: [Brief description of service]. [Why choose you]. [CTA]. **Example:** "Fast, reliable water heater repair in Dallas. Licensed, insured, and rated 4.9 stars. Call now for same-day service."

Keep it under 155 characters. You can even add your phone number towards the beginning for an added CTA. **Example:** “Call 777-777-7777 for Fast, reliable water heater repair in Dallas. Licensed, insured and rated 4.9 stars. Call now for same-day service.”

Headers (H1, H2, H3)

These are the headings and subheadings on your page. Your main heading (H1) should include your target keyword. Subheadings (H2, H3) should break up the content into scannable sections.

H1: “Water Heater Repair in Dallas, TX” **H2:** “Signs Your Water Heater Needs Repair” **H2:** “Our Water Heater Repair Process” **H2:** “Water Heater Repair Cost in Dallas” **H2:** “Why Choose Johnson Plumbing?”

Google reads headers to understand the structure and topic of your page. Use them. Break up your content. Make it scannable for both Google and humans.

Internal Linking - Connecting Your Pages

Here’s a quick win that most plumbing websites miss completely: internal linking.

Internal linking means linking from one page on your website to another page on your website. For example, your “Water Heater Repair” page might include a sentence like: “We also offer if your unit is beyond repair.”

Why this matters:

1. **It helps Google discover all your pages.** Google follows links to find and index pages. If a page isn’t linked from anywhere else on your site, Google might not find it.
2. **It helps Google understand relationships between pages.** When your water heater repair page links to your water heater installation page, Google understands those topics are related and that your site is an authority on water heaters.
3. **It keeps visitors on your site longer.** A visitor reading about drain cleaning might also need sewer line inspection. If you link to that page,

they stay on your site instead of going back to Google and potentially clicking on a competitor.

The rule of thumb: every page on your site should link to at least 2-3 other relevant pages. And your homepage should link to all your main service pages. It's a web, not a dead end.

The Content Gap Exercise

Let me give you a practical exercise you can do right now to see where your website stands.

Step 1: Open a document or grab a piece of paper. Write down every service you offer. All of them. Be specific.

Not just “plumbing.” Write down: - Water heater repair - Water heater installation - Tankless water heater installation - Drain cleaning - Sewer line repair - Sewer line replacement - Emergency plumbing - Faucet repair and installation - Toilet repair and installation - Garbage disposal repair - Gas line repair - Bathroom remodeling - Kitchen plumbing - Slab leak detection - And anything else you do

Step 2: Next to each service, write down whether your website has a dedicated page for it. Not a mention in a paragraph - a full, dedicated page.

Step 3: Now write down every city or area you serve.

Step 4: Next to each city, check if your website has a page for it.

Step 5: Count the gaps.

If you offer 12 services and your website has pages for 3 of them, you have 9 gaps. If you serve 6 cities and your website mentions 1, you have 5 gaps. Each gap is a keyword you're invisible for. Each gap is a customer who can't find you.

That list of gaps? That's your on-page SEO roadmap. Start with the highest-value gaps - your biggest revenue services in your primary city - and work your way through the list.

Pipe Dream vs. Pipeline

Pipe Dream: “My website has a Services page - that covers it.”

Pipeline: “Every service I offer has its own page, optimized for my city, designed to get me calls.”

Ryan's Rant

Having one “Services” page for your plumbing company is like having one wrench for every job. Sure, it technically exists. But good luck tightening a 2-inch fitting with a 3/8 ratchet. You need the right tool for each job. And Google needs the right page for each search.

Your competitor has 25 pages. You have 3. And you're wondering why he shows up on Google and you don't?

This isn't a mystery. It's math. More pages about more services in more cities equals more chances to show up. Fewer pages equals fewer chances. It really is that simple.

You don't need to be a writer. You need to answer the same questions on paper that you answer on the phone every day. “What does this service involve? How much does it usually cost? How do I know if I need it?” That's a service page. You already know the answers. Write them down.

Wrench Turn Action Items

1. List every service you offer. Count how many have their own page on your website. The gap between those two numbers is your biggest SEO opportunity. Write it down. That's the number of pages standing between you and more Google visibility.

2. List every city you serve. Check if any appear on your website. If you serve 5 cities and your website only mentions your headquarters, you're invisible in 4 cities. Every city needs at least one page.

3. Check your homepage title tag. Look at the text in your browser tab when you're on your homepage. Does it include your company name, your city, and the word "plumber" (or your primary service)? If it says "Home" or "Welcome" or just your company name - that's a missed opportunity. Fix it.

4. Pick your #1 money service. Does it have a dedicated page? What's the service that generates the most revenue for you? Does it have its own page with a keyword-focused title, useful content, photos, and a call to action? If not, that's this week's project. Write it. Or have someone write it. Get it live.

5. Read one competitor's service page. Not to copy it. To see what you're up against. Google your main service + city. Click on the first organic result (not the ad). Read their service page. Look at how it's structured. Look at how much content they have. That's your benchmark. Now beat it.

Now you know WHY service pages matter. Want templates and examples you can use to build yours?

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/service-pages. How to Build Service Pages That Rank and Convert - templates, examples, and a fill-in-the-blank framework.

Want us to build your service pages for you?

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/call



CHAPTER 8

“I WROTE A BLOG POST IN 2019 AND NOTHING HAPPENED”

CONTENT MARKETING - ANSWERING QUESTIONS
YOUR CUSTOMERS ARE ALREADY ASKING

“B*logging is for food bloggers, not plumbers.*” - A plumber who’s never gotten a call from Google

Remember Tony’s nephew website from Chapter 3? The one with the stock photo wrench, the wrong phone number, and the 8-second load time?

That website also had a blog. One post. Auto-generated by the Wix template when the nephew set it up: “Hello World - Welcome to Our New Website!” Published in 2019. Never updated. Never replaced. Just sitting there, like a faded bumper sticker on a truck nobody drives anymore.

Tony told me, “I tried blogging. It didn’t work.”

Tony didn’t try blogging. Tony’s nephew’s website template auto-generated a placeholder post that says nothing, provides no value, and answers no questions. That’s not blogging. That’s a software default.

Now let me tell you about Nathan.

Nathan is a plumber who filmed one video. Five minutes long. Shot it on his phone in a customer's garage. No editing. No fancy intro. No graphics. Just Nathan, a camera, and a water heater that was showing signs of failure.

The title: "How to Tell If Your Water Heater Is About to Die."

Nathan walked through the five warning signs - strange noises, rusty water, age of the unit, inconsistent temperatures, and visible corrosion. He explained each one in plain English, the same way he'd explain it to a homeowner standing in their garage.

He uploaded it to YouTube. Posted it to Facebook. Shared it on his Google Business Profile.

That video has 40,000 views. It generates 15 calls per month. Nathan spent \$0 making it.

Nathan didn't "blog." He didn't write a 2,000-word essay. He answered a question that his customers were already typing into Google and YouTube. And Google rewarded him for it by showing his answer to thousands of people in his area.

That's content marketing. Not blogging. Not writing essays. Answering questions.

You're Already Creating Content - You're Just Not Writing It Down

Here's the thing about content marketing that most plumbers don't realize: **you already do it every single day.**

Every time a customer calls and asks "how much does a water heater cost?" - that's a blog post.

Every time someone asks "should I repair or replace my water heater?" - that's a blog post.

Every time your uncle corners you at Thanksgiving and asks about his garbage disposal AGAIN - that's a blog post.

Every time you explain something to a homeowner on the job - what's wrong, why it happened, what they can do to prevent it, what it's going to cost - you're creating content. You're just doing it verbally, one person at a time, and then it disappears.

Content marketing is taking those same explanations and putting them on your website (or YouTube, or social media) so they work for you at scale. Instead of answering the same question for one customer at a time, you answer it once and Google shows it to thousands of people who are asking the same question.

That's not "blogging." That's leverage.

Why Content Gets You Found on Google

In Chapter 7, we talked about service pages - pages that target specific services in specific cities. Those are your bread and butter. But service pages only cover what you DO. Content pages cover what your customers ASK.

And customers ask a LOT of questions before they ever pick up the phone:

- "How much does a water heater cost?"
- "Tankless vs. traditional water heater - which is better?"
- "Why is my toilet running?"
- "How to unclog a drain without calling a plumber"
- "What to do if a pipe bursts at 2am"
- "How to winterize your pipes"
- "How often should you have your sewer line inspected?"
- "Is a dripping faucet an emergency?"

Every single one of those questions is being typed into Google right now. By real people. In your city. And the plumber whose website answers those questions is the plumber who shows up in the search results.

Here's how it works:

1. **Someone types a question into Google.** “How much does a water heater cost in Dallas?”
2. **Google scans every website it knows about** looking for pages that answer that question.
3. **Google shows the best answers.** The pages that are most relevant, most helpful, most authoritative.
4. **The searcher reads the article.** They're impressed. This plumber clearly knows what they're talking about.
5. **The searcher sees the phone number.** Or the “Get a Free Quote” button. Or the “Call Now” banner at the top of the page.
6. **They call.** Not because of an ad. Not because of a referral. Because they found a plumber who answered their question and earned their trust.

That's the content marketing funnel. It's simple. It's free (beyond your time). And it works year-round, 24/7, without you touching it again after you publish.

The Types of Content That Work for Plumbers

You don't need to become a writer. You don't need to publish daily. You need to answer the questions your customers are already asking, in a format that Google can find and display.

Here are the four types of content that consistently work for plumbing companies:

1. FAQ Posts

These are the simplest and most effective. Take a question your customers ask and answer it in 500-800 words.

Examples: - “How Much Does a Water Heater Cost in [City]?” - “How to Know If You Need a Sewer Line Replacement” - “Is a Dripping Faucet Wasting Money? (Yes - Here’s How Much)” - “What to Do When Your Toilet Won’t Stop Running”

The title should be the actual question people ask. The content should be a clear, honest, helpful answer. Include your city name naturally. End with a call to action.

These posts rank well because they match exactly what people are searching for. Google’s job is to answer questions. If your page IS the answer, Google will show it.

2. Comparison Posts

People love to compare options before making a decision. Give them the comparison and position yourself as the expert.

Examples: - “Tankless vs. Traditional Water Heaters: Which Is Right for You?” - “PEX vs. Copper Piping: Pros, Cons, and Cost” - “Repair vs. Replace: When Is It Time for a New Water Heater?” - “DIY Drain Cleaning vs. Professional - When to Call a Plumber”

These posts establish authority. When someone reads your comparison and finds it fair, informative, and helpful - they trust you. And when they decide they need help, you’re the plumber they call.

3. Seasonal Posts

Plumbing has seasons. Your content should too.

Examples: - “How to Winterize Your Pipes in [City] (Prevent Frozen Pipes This Winter)” - “Spring Plumbing Checklist: 5 Things to Inspect After Winter” - “Summer Water Conservation Tips for [City] Homeowners” - “Holiday Plumbing Survival Guide: How to Avoid Thanksgiving Disasters”

Publish these 4-6 weeks before the season hits. They'll rank when people start searching for seasonal plumbing topics, and they build year-over-year as Google sees them as reliable recurring content.

4. Emergency Guides

These target the highest-intent searchers - people who have a plumbing emergency RIGHT NOW and need help immediately.

Examples: - "What to Do If Your Pipe Bursts at 2am in [City]" - "Emergency: My Basement Is Flooding - What Do I Do First?" - "My Water Heater Is Leaking - Is This an Emergency?" - "Gas Smell in the House? Here's What to Do (and When to Call a Plumber)"

These posts serve two purposes: they provide genuinely helpful information (which earns trust), and they position you as the emergency plumber to call. Someone reading "What to Do If Your Pipe Bursts" at 2am is someone who needs a plumber at 2am. If your article is the one they find, your phone number is the one they call.

You Don't Need to Write a Novel

I want to address the elephant in the room. Most plumbers read "content marketing" and think: "I'm not a writer. I barely passed English class. There's no way I can write blog posts."

Here's the truth: **you don't need to be a good writer. You need to be a helpful answerer.**

A 500-word blog post that clearly answers "how much does a water heater cost in Dallas?" in plain, conversational language will outperform a 3,000-word masterpiece that reads like an encyclopedia. Google doesn't reward fancy writing. Google rewards relevance, clarity, and helpfulness.

Write like you talk. If a customer asked you "how much does a water heater cost?" in person, you wouldn't respond with "The thermal dynamics of residential water heating systems vary based on a multitude of factors including..." No.

You'd say: "Depends on the type and size. A standard 50-gallon tank usually runs \$1,200-\$2,000 installed. Tankless is more like \$2,500-\$4,500. Here's what affects the price..."

Write THAT. That's your blog post. Done.

And if you really can't write - or really don't want to - there are other options:

- **Film a video and have it transcribed.** Talk into your phone for 3 minutes answering a customer question. Use a free transcription tool to turn it into text. Clean it up a little. Post it.
- **Hire a writer.** Content writers who specialize in home services can write a solid plumbing blog post for \$50-\$150 each. Two posts a month is \$100-\$300. Not bad for 24 extra ways to be found on Google each year.
- **Use AI tools to draft, then edit.** Write down the key points you'd tell a customer, run them through an AI writing tool, then edit it to sound like you. Don't publish AI content without editing - it'll sound robotic.

The point is: there's no excuse not to create content. The barrier is not talent. It's action.

The Compounding Effect

Here's where content marketing gets really exciting: it compounds.

Every piece of content you publish is a fishing line in the water. It stays there working for you indefinitely. A blog post you write today could be generating calls two years from now.

Publish 2 posts per month. That's 24 new pages on your website per year. Each one targeting a different question or keyword. Each one a new way for potential customers to find you.

After 1 year: 24 content pages. After 2 years: 48 content pages. After 3 years: 72 content pages.

That's 72 additional ways someone can find your website on Google. 72 questions answered. 72 pieces of evidence that you know what you're talking about.

Your competitors who don't create content? They're stuck at the same 3-10 pages they've had for years. You're building an ever-growing web of content that makes you more visible every month.

This is the compound effect. It's slow at first. Your first blog post might get 10 visits in its first month. But as your site builds authority, each new post gets more traction. And the old posts keep working. A post from 6 months ago that now ranks on page one for its keyword is generating traffic and calls without you lifting a finger.

Nathan's one video - filmed in 5 minutes, uploaded once - generates 15 calls a month. That's 180 calls a year. From one piece of content. Imagine what happens when you have 50 pieces of content out there, all working for you simultaneously.

Trent's Warning: Don't Just Consume - Create

I want to share one cautionary tale before the action items.

Trent is a plumber who watched over 500 marketing videos on YouTube. Five hundred. He subscribed to every plumbing business channel. He watched webinars, podcasts, and tutorials. He took notes. He filled notebooks.

Trent never implemented a single thing.

Five hundred videos. Zero action. Trent knows more about plumbing marketing than 95% of plumbing company owners. And his business looks exactly the same as it did three years ago.

Don't be Trent. Don't consume content about marketing. **CREATE** content about plumbing. The plumber who reads 500 articles and does nothing loses to the plumber who reads one chapter and takes action.

You don't need to know everything before you start. You need to start before you know everything.

Write one post. Film one video. Answer one question. Do it today. Do it imperfectly. Do it scared. Just do it.

Pipe Dream vs. Pipeline

Pipe Dream: "Blogging is for food bloggers, not plumbers."

Pipeline: "Every blog post I publish is another way a customer can find me on Google."

Ryan's Rant

You answer plumbing questions for free every single day. On the job. On the phone. At family dinners where your uncle asks about his garbage disposal for the fifth time this year. At barbecues where your neighbor's friend corners you about their water pressure.

You are **ALREADY** a content creator. You create content every day - you just deliver it verbally, one person at a time, and then it vanishes.

Write it down. Film it. Post it. Let Google deliver your expertise to a thousand people instead of one.

You're not "becoming a blogger." You're taking the knowledge you already have - the knowledge you've built over years of hands-on work - and putting it somewhere it can work for you at scale. That's not blogging. That's being smart.

Wrench Turn Action Items

1. Write down the 5 questions customers ask you most often. Not what you **THINK** they ask. What they **ACTUALLY** ask. The questions you hear every week. "How much does X cost?" "Should I repair or replace?" "Why is my Y doing Z?" Those five questions are your first five pieces of content.

2. Film yourself answering one of those questions. Pull out your phone. Hit record. Talk for 2-3 minutes. Answer the question the same way you'd answer it if a customer asked in person. Don't script it. Don't rehearse. Just talk. Upload it to YouTube with a title that includes the question and your city name.

3. Check: does your website have a blog section? Some plumbing websites don't even have a blog or "resources" section. If yours doesn't, add one. It's usually a simple setting in whatever website platform you use. If your web person doesn't know how, ask them to figure it out. This is basic.

4. Write OR record one piece of content this week. Publish it. Not next week. This week. It doesn't need to be perfect. It needs to exist. A published 500-word blog post that's 80% as good as you want it to be is infinitely more valuable than a perfect post that lives in your head forever.

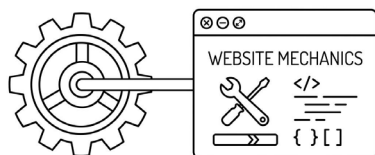
5. Set a goal: 2 pieces of content per month for the next 6 months. That's 12 new pages on your website. 12 new ways to be found. 12 new chances for a customer to discover you, trust you, and call you. Mark it on your calendar. Hold yourself accountable.

Now you know WHY content gets you found. Want a full year's worth of topics planned out for you?

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/content-marketing. The Plumber's Content Calendar: 52 Blog Post Ideas That Actually Get Calls - one for every week of the year.

Want us to create content for your website?

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/call



CHAPTER 9

“WHAT IS SCHEMA AND WHY SHOULD I CARE?”

THE TECHNICAL STUFF THAT WINS (EVEN IF YOU NEVER SEE IT)

“My web guy said something about schema and sitemaps. I nodded and changed the subject.” - Every plumber, at some point

Two plumbing websites. Same city. Same services. Same number of reviews. Same quality content. Both have service pages, city pages, fast load times, and real photos.

But when you search “emergency plumber” plus their city, they look completely different in Google’s search results.

Plumber A’s listing shows up as a plain blue link with a title and a short description. That’s it. A link. Just like every other result on the page.

Plumber B’s listing shows up with a star rating right there in the search results. 4.8 stars, 247 reviews - visible before anyone clicks. Below that, pricing info: “Emergency service starting at \$89.” Below that, a list of FAQs that expand with one tap. And the business hours, phone number, and a “Call Now” button - all displayed in the search result itself.

Plumber B’s listing takes up three times more space on the screen. It looks more professional. It provides more information. It screams “click me.”

Plumber B gets 3x more clicks than Plumber A.

The difference? About 10 minutes of work and a few lines of code called **schema markup** that Plumber A didn't know existed.

Schema Markup in Plumber Terms

I'm going to explain schema the way I'd explain it if you and I were sitting down for dinner and you asked me "what is schema anyways?"

Think about the pipes inside a wall. The water flows through them. It gets from Point A to Point B. The system works. But unless you put labels on those pipes - hot, cold, gas, drain - nobody else knows what's what. A new plumber walking into that mechanical room is going to be lost.

Schema markup is labels for your website. The content is the water flowing through the pipes. It works fine - Google can read your website and generally understand what it says. But schema tells Google EXACTLY what each piece of information means.

Without schema, Google reads your website and thinks: "This page mentions 'Johnson Plumbing,' a phone number, some services, and some reviews. It's probably a plumbing company in Dallas."

With schema, Google reads your website and KNOWS: "This is a local plumbing business called Johnson Plumbing. Their phone number is (555) 123-4567. They're located at 123 Main Street, Dallas, TX. They offer water heater repair, drain cleaning, and emergency plumbing. They have 247 reviews with an average rating of 4.8 stars. Their business hours are Monday-Saturday 7am-8pm and they offer 24/7 emergency service. Their emergency service starts at \$89."

See the difference? Without schema, Google is guessing. With schema, Google knows. And when Google knows, it can display that information beautifully in search results - star ratings, pricing, FAQs, business hours, all of it.

Those enhanced search results are called **rich results** or **rich snippets**. They're

the listings that stand out from the plain blue links. They get more clicks. They build more trust. And they're powered by schema markup.

What Schema Does for Plumbers

Let me be specific about what schema can do for your plumbing website:

Star Ratings in Search Results

When your website has review schema, Google can display your star rating and review count right in the search results. A potential customer sees “4.8 stars - 247 reviews” before they even click on your link. That’s instant credibility. Instant trust. And it makes your listing stand out from every competitor who shows up as a plain blue link.

Service and Pricing Information

Service schema tells Google exactly what services you offer and what they cost (if you choose to include pricing). This information can show up in search results, giving potential customers key details before they click. “Emergency plumbing starting at \$89” is a lot more compelling than a generic description.

FAQ Snippets

If you add FAQ schema to your pages, Google can display expandable Q&A sections right in the search results. Each question takes up space, making your listing larger and more prominent. A listing with three FAQ dropdowns takes up way more screen real estate than a plain link - which pushes your competitors further down the page.

Business Hours and Contact Info

LocalBusiness schema tells Google your exact hours, phone number, address, and service area. This makes your information more likely to appear accurately in Google's knowledge panels and local results.

Breadcrumb Navigation

Breadcrumb schema helps Google understand your site structure and can display a navigational path in search results (Home > Services > Water Heater Repair) instead of a generic URL. It looks cleaner and more professional.

You Don't Need to Understand the Code

Here's the part I need to be very clear about: **you do not need to learn how to code schema markup.** This is not a DIY chapter. I'm not going to teach you to write JSON-LD (that's the code format schema uses). That's what your web developer or web company does.

What you DO need to know is:

1. **Schema exists.** It's a real thing that makes a real difference in how your website appears in Google.
2. **It matters.** Sites with schema markup get more clicks and look more professional in search results.
3. **It's not optional anymore.** In 2026, your competitors are adding schema. If you don't have it, you're falling behind.
4. **Someone on your team should be handling it.** Your web developer, your marketing company, whoever manages your site - they should be adding and maintaining schema markup.
5. **You can check if it's there.** Google has a free tool that tells you if your site has schema (I'll give you the link in the action items).

Your job isn't to implement schema. Your job is to know it exists and to make

sure the person who manages your website has it handled. If they don't know what schema is - that's a red flag about their competence. If they know what it is but haven't added it - that's a red flag about their attention to detail.

Either way, it needs to get done.

Other Technical SEO Basics

Schema is an extremely important part of technical SEO. But there are a few other technical fundamentals that matter for your plumbing website. Again - you don't need to implement these yourself. You need to know they exist and make sure your web team is handling them.

Site Speed

We touched on this in Chapter 3, but it bears repeating from an SEO perspective. Google has explicitly stated that site speed is a ranking factor. Slower sites rank lower. Faster sites rank higher. Period.

Every second your site takes to load over 3 seconds costs you about 7% of visitors AND hurts your Google ranking. It's a double penalty - you lose people AND you rank lower, which means even fewer people find you in the first place.

Your web developer should be optimizing images, minimizing code, using a fast hosting provider, and leveraging browser caching. You don't need to know what any of those terms mean. You need to run your site through Google PageSpeed Insights (pagespeed.web.dev), look at the score, and send it to your web person if it's below 70.

Mobile-Friendliness

Google uses mobile-first indexing. That means Google looks at the MOBILE version of your website first when deciding how to rank you. If your mobile experience is bad - slow, hard to navigate, text too small, buttons too close together - your rankings suffer even if the desktop version looks great.

Over 70% of plumbing searches happen on mobile devices. If your site doesn't work perfectly on a phone, you're failing the majority of your potential customers AND Google simultaneously.

SSL/HTTPS

If your website URL starts with “http://” instead of “https://,” you have a security issue. Google penalizes non-secure sites in rankings. Chrome and other browsers display a “Not Secure” warning to visitors. It looks terrible and it hurts your SEO.

Most modern hosting providers offer free SSL certificates. There is zero reason not to have this in 2026. If your site isn't HTTPS, fix it this week.

XML Sitemap

An XML sitemap is a file that lists every page on your website and tells Google exactly what pages exist. Think of it as a table of contents for Google's robots. Without it, Google has to discover your pages by following links - which means some pages might never get found.

Your web developer should create an XML sitemap and submit it to Google Search Console. It's a one-time setup that takes about 15 minutes and ensures Google knows about every page on your site.

Clean URL Structure

Your page URLs should be readable and descriptive, not a random string of numbers and characters.

- **Good:** yoursite.com/water-heater-repair-dallas
- **Bad:** yoursite.com/page?id=847392&ref=svc

Clean URLs help Google understand what the page is about and look better in search results. They're also easier for humans to read and share.

Google Search Console

Google Search Console is a free tool from Google that shows you how your website performs in search. It tells you what keywords people are finding you for, which pages get the most clicks, and whether there are any technical issues Google has detected on your site.

Every plumbing company should have Google Search Console set up. It's free. It takes 10 minutes. And it's the only way to see how Google sees your website.

The Technical SEO Checklist for Plumbers

Here's a simple checklist you can send to whoever manages your website. You don't need to understand everything on this list. They should.

- Does our site have LocalBusiness schema markup?
- Do our service pages have Service schema?
- Do we have Review/AggregateRating schema?
- Do we have FAQ schema on relevant pages?
- Is our site speed above 70 on Google PageSpeed Insights (mobile)?
- Is our site mobile-friendly? (Test at search.google.com/test/mobile-friendly)
- Is our site HTTPS (padlock in browser bar)?
- Do we have an XML sitemap submitted to Google Search Console?
- Are our URLs clean and descriptive?
- Is Google Search Console set up and monitoring our site?

If your web person checks all 10 boxes, you're in great shape technically. If they can't answer some of these questions, it might be time for a conversation about their capabilities.

The “Fire Them” Test

Here’s a quick test I give plumbers when they’re evaluating their current web developer or marketing company:

Send them a text or email with this exact message:

“Hey, quick question - does our website have schema markup? And do we have an XML sitemap submitted to Google Search Console?”

If they respond with a clear, specific answer (“Yes, we have LocalBusiness schema and Service schema on all your service pages. Your sitemap was last submitted in [month]. Here’s your Search Console access.”) - great. They know what they’re doing.

If they respond with confusion, deflection, or jargon that doesn’t actually answer the question - you have a problem. These are basic technical SEO elements. Any competent web professional should know them, have them implemented, and be able to confirm them quickly.

If they respond with “What’s schema?” - fire them. I’m serious. If the person managing your website in 2026 doesn’t know what schema markup is, they are not qualified to manage a plumbing company’s website. You’re paying for expertise you’re not getting.

This isn’t about being mean. It’s about your business. Your website is your most important marketing asset. The person managing it should know the basics. Schema and sitemaps ARE the basics.

The Invisible Advantage

Here’s why I call technical SEO the “invisible advantage”: your customers will never see your schema markup. They’ll never know you have an XML sitemap. They’ll never check your PageSpeed score. These things are invisible to the end user.

But the RESULTS are very visible. The star ratings in search results. The FAQ

snippets that make your listing huge. The fast-loading site that doesn't lose visitors. The top-of-page ranking that gets you the click. Those are all visible. And they're all powered by the invisible technical work happening behind the scenes.

Your competitor who has schema, a fast site, and proper technical SEO? Their listing looks like a premium result. Yours - without those things - looks like an afterthought. Same quality work. Same reviews. Same content. Different presentation. And presentation matters when a homeowner is choosing between 10 plumbing listings in 30 seconds.

The plumber who wins isn't always the one with the best skills. It's the one who shows up looking like a professional in every place a customer might find them. And in 2026, "every place" includes the technical details of how your website communicates with Google.

Pipe Dream vs. Pipeline

Pipe Dream: "That's too technical for me - I'm a plumber, not a coder."

Pipeline: "I don't need to code it myself. I need to know it exists and make sure my web team has it handled."

Ryan's Rant

Nobody expects you to add schema markup yourself. I don't expect you to know what an XML sitemap file looks like. I don't expect you to write a single line of code.

But I DO expect you to know these things EXIST. I expect you to ask the person managing your website: "Do we have schema? Do we have a sitemap? What's our PageSpeed score?" Basic questions. Thirty seconds.

You know what happens when you hire a plumber and ask smart questions? You get better work. Because the plumber knows you're paying attention. It works the same way with your web person. When you ask about schema, they know you're not someone who can be fed fluff reports and green arrows.

Ask the questions. You don't need to understand the answers in detail. You need to know that the right answers exist and that the person you're paying is providing them.

And if they say "what's schema?" - you know what to do.

Wrench Turn Action Items

1. Text or email whoever manages your website right now. Send them this: "Does our site have schema markup? Do we have an XML sitemap submitted to Google Search Console?" See what they say. Their answer tells you everything you need to know about their competence.

2. Run your site through Google's Rich Results Test. Go to search.google.com/test/rich-results. Enter your homepage URL. The tool will tell you if Google detects any schema markup on your page. If it finds nothing - that's your starting point for a conversation with your web person.

3. Check your site speed on mobile. Go to pagespeed.web.dev. Enter your URL. Look at the mobile score. Below 70? Send the report to your web developer with a note: "Can we improve this?" Below 50? That's an emergency.

4. Check if your site is HTTPS. Look at your browser bar right now on your own website. Do you see a padlock icon? Does the URL start with "https://"? If not, this needs to be fixed immediately. It's hurting your rankings and scaring off customers.

5. Bookmark the implementation guide for when you're ready. You know WHY schema matters now. When you're ready for the HOW - or when you need to send your web developer the instructions - the full implementation guide is waiting.

Now you know WHY technical SEO matters. Want the full implementation guide - schema code, sitemap setup, speed optimization?

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/schema. Schema Markup for Plumbers: What It Is, Why It Matters, and How to Add It - complete guide with code snippets your

developer can copy.

Want us to handle the technical stuff?

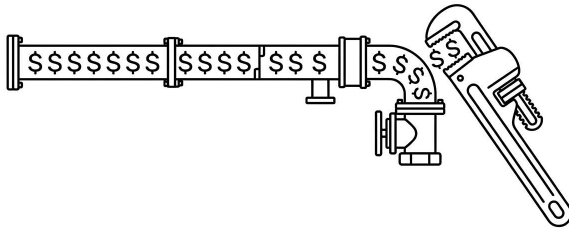
OnlyPlumbingSites.com/call

PART IV

PAYING FOR LEADS

*“Free marketing is great. But sometimes you need to put
gas in the truck to get to the job site.”*

-Ryan Pietrzak





CHAPTER 10

“I TRIED GOOGLE ADS ONCE - IT DIDN'T WORK”

THE \$5/DAY TRAGEDY

“Google Ads is a scam. I tried it.” - Mike, who spent \$35 and declared an entire platform broken

Mike heard Google Ads could get him calls.

A buddy mentioned it at the supply house. “Dude, I’m getting like 15 calls a week from Google Ads.” Mike went home that Saturday night, watched a Youtube video, and decided to set up a campaign himself.

He went to ads.google.com. Created an account. Google walked him through a setup wizard that seemed simple enough. It asked him what keyword he wanted to target. Mike typed “plumber.” Just... plumber. Not “emergency plumber near me.” Not “water heater repair [his city].” Just the word “plumber.” The broadest, most expensive, most useless keyword in the plumbing universe.

Google asked him for a daily budget. Mike figured \$5 a day sounded reasonable. That’s a cup of coffee. He’d test it for a week and see what happened.

Google asked where he wanted to send the traffic. Mike selected his homepage - the nephew website from Chapter 3. The one with the stock wrench photo, the wrong phone number on mobile, and the 8-second load time.

Mike hit “launch.” Campaign live. He went to bed feeling productive.

One week later, here’s what happened:

- **Total spend:** \$35
- **Total clicks:** 4
- **Click 1:** A bot. Not a real person. An automated program that clicks on ads and costs you money.
- **Click 2:** Someone in another state. They searched “plumber” - the keyword Mike chose - but they were 400 miles away.
- **Click 3:** A competitor checking out Mike’s ad to see what he was doing.
- **Click 4:** A real person who landed on Mike’s homepage, couldn’t find the phone number on mobile, and left after 6 seconds.
- **Total calls generated:** Zero.
- **Total new customers:** Zero.

Mike declared Google Ads a scam. He told everyone at the supply house. He told his wife. He posted on Facebook: “Don’t waste your money on Google Ads.” He went back to waiting for the phone to ring.

Meanwhile, his competitor spends \$3,000 a month on Google Ads. That competitor targets keywords like “emergency plumber [city],” “water heater repair near me,” and “drain cleaning [city].” He sends traffic to dedicated landing pages - one for each service - with a single phone number, a single call to action, and customer reviews. He tracks every call. He optimizes every week.

That competitor gets 60 leads a month from Google Ads. Closes 40 of them. At an average ticket of \$550, that’s \$22,000 in monthly revenue from a \$3,000 ad spend. A 7:1 return.

Mike spent \$35 with no strategy, no tracking, and no landing page. His competitor spends \$3,000 with a strategy, tracking, and landing pages. Mike says Google Ads doesn’t work. His competitor says Google Ads is the best investment he’s ever made.

They're both right - about THEIR experience. But only one of them actually tried Google Ads. The other one set \$35 on fire and called it a test.

Google Ads Works. Your Strategy Didn't.

Let me be blunt: Google Ads is one of the most effective marketing channels available to plumbers. When someone types “emergency plumber near me” into Google at 10pm on a Saturday, they NEED a plumber RIGHT NOW. That's not a casual browser. That's not someone “thinking about it.” That's a customer with money in hand looking for someone to give it to.

Google Ads puts you at the top of that search result. Above organic results. Above the Map Pack. Right at the top, where the most desperate, highest-intent customers are looking.

When done right, Google Ads for plumbers generates predictable, measurable, scalable leads. You can turn it up when you want more work and turn it down when you're booked out. It's one of the few marketing channels where you can directly control the volume of leads coming in.

But “when done right” is doing a lot of heavy lifting in that sentence. Because most plumbers who try Google Ads do it wrong. And doing Google Ads wrong isn't just ineffective - it's expensive.

The Six Reasons Most Plumber Google Ads Campaigns Fail

Reason 1: Budget Too Low

Mike spent \$5/day. In most metro areas, a single click on a plumbing keyword costs \$15-\$50. At \$5/day, Mike couldn't even afford ONE click on a competitive keyword. He was showing up on searches where the competition was spending \$100+/day and he was bringing a squirt gun to a fire hose fight.

The reality: You need a minimum of \$1,000-\$2,000/month to compete in most markets. In major metros, \$3,000-\$5,000 is more realistic. I know that sounds

like a lot. But remember the math from Chapter 2: if your average customer is worth \$700 and you're paying \$150 per acquisition, that's a 4.7:1 return. You're not spending \$3,000. You're investing \$3,000 to get back \$14,000.

Reason 2: Wrong Keywords

Mike targeted "plumber." That single word matches every search that includes the word plumber: "plumber salary," "plumber school near me," "plumber movie 2024," "how to become a plumber," "Mario the plumber costume." None of those people need Mike's services. But Mike paid for every one of their clicks.

The fix: Target high-intent, specific keywords. "Emergency plumber [city]." "Water heater repair [city]." "Drain cleaning near me." "Plumber [city] open now." These are the searches from people who need help TODAY. Not people researching a career change.

Reason 3: No Negative Keywords

Negative keywords tell Google what searches you DON'T want to appear for. Without them, your ads show up for all kinds of irrelevant searches.

If you're targeting "plumber" without negatives, you're paying for clicks from people searching "plumber salary," "plumber apprenticeship," "plumber tool set," "DIY plumbing," and dozens of other terms that will never become customers. Every one of those clicks costs you money and generates zero leads.

The fix: Add negative keywords from day one. Common ones for plumbers: "salary," "school," "apprentice," "DIY," "how to," "jobs," "career," "certification," "free," "cheap." Review your Search Terms report weekly and add new negatives as irrelevant searches appear.

Reason 4: Sending Traffic to Your Homepage

Mike sent ad clicks to his homepage. His homepage talks about everything and nothing. It's a general introduction to his company. There's no specific call to action. No focus on the service the person searched for. No urgency. When someone clicks an ad for "emergency plumber," they should land on

a page about EMERGENCY PLUMBING. Not your homepage. Not your “About Us” page. A dedicated landing page that matches their search, addresses their problem, shows your reviews, and has a giant “Call Now” button.

The fix: Create dedicated landing pages for your highest-value services. Each page should match the ad the person clicked on: Emergency plumbing ad emergency plumbing landing page. Water heater repair ad water heater repair landing page. This is called “message match” and it dramatically increases conversion rates.

Reason 5: No Call Tracking

Mike had no way to know if Google Ads generated any calls. He didn’t track which calls came from ads versus which came from other sources. So when he got a call during his ad campaign week, he had no idea if it was related to his ads or not.

The fix: Call tracking is non-negotiable for Google Ads. Services like CallRail give you a dedicated phone number for your ads. When someone calls that number, you know it came from Google Ads. Without call tracking, you’re guessing. And as we covered in Chapter 2, guessing is expensive.

Reason 6: Set It and Forget It

Mike set up his campaign on Saturday night and checked it once, a week later. That’s not managing a campaign. That’s abandoning a campaign.

Google Ads requires weekly optimization. And just as important: make sure whoever answers the phone is trained to convert those calls into booked jobs (Chapter 18). The best ad campaign in the world is worthless if the phone gets answered poorly. Reviewing which keywords are performing, which are wasting money, which ads are getting clicks, which landing pages are converting. The plumbers who get great results from Google Ads are the ones who (or whose agency) actively manage the campaigns every week.

The fix: If you’re managing your own ads, set aside 30-60 minutes per week to review performance and make adjustments. If you’re hiring someone, make sure they’re actively optimizing - not just running the same campaign month after month.

Rex's Money Printer

I mentioned Rex briefly in Chapter 2, but his story is worth expanding here because he represents what Google Ads looks like when done right.

Rex spends \$3,000 a month on Google Ads. He targets specific service + city keywords. He has dedicated landing pages for each campaign. He uses call tracking to measure every lead. His campaigns are optimized weekly.

Here are Rex's numbers:

- **Monthly spend:** \$3,000
- **Monthly leads:** About 45
- **Monthly closed jobs:** About 20 (45% close rate - lower than some because he's selective)
- **Average job ticket:** \$420
- **Monthly revenue from ads:** \$8,400
- **Cost per acquisition (CPA):** \$150

At first glance, \$3,000 in and \$8,400 out looks like a 2.8:1 return. Good, but not incredible.

But Rex thinks in terms of customer lifetime value. His average customer uses him 2-3 times over 5 years and refers one friend. His CLV is about \$1,200. So those 20 customers per month are actually worth about \$24,000 in lifetime value.

\$3,000 in. \$24,000 in lifetime value out. That's an 8:1 return.

Rex calls his Google Ads dashboard his "money printer." He told me: "Every dollar I put in comes back times eight. I'd put in \$10,000 a month if I had the techs to handle it."

That's the difference between Mike and Rex. Mike spent \$35 with no strategy. Rex invests \$3,000 with a system. Same platform. Completely different results.

The Consistency Principle

One more lesson before the action items. Isaac - another plumber - made a mistake that's extremely common. He decided to "try" marketing. He spent \$6,000 on Google Ads in one month. Got some leads. Felt good about it. The next month, he got busy with the work those leads generated and stopped running ads. The month after that, things slowed down, so he started ads again. Then stopped. Then started.

Isaac's marketing looked like a heart monitor: spike, flatline, spike, flatline.

Meanwhile, his competitor spent \$1,000/month on Google Ads. Every month. For 18 months straight. No interruptions. Consistent.

After 18 months, Isaac had spent the same total amount - about \$18,000. But the competitor's consistent \$1,000/month generated far better results than Isaac's sporadic bursts. Why? Because Google's algorithm rewards consistency. Campaigns that run continuously build data, optimize over time, and improve month over month. Campaigns that start and stop lose all that momentum every time they're paused.

Consistency beats intensity. Every single time. \$1,000/month for 12 months will always outperform \$12,000 in one month followed by 11 months of nothing.

Pipe Dream vs. Pipeline

Pipe Dream: "I tried Google Ads and it didn't work."

Pipeline: "I invested in Google Ads with the right strategy, budget, and tracking, and now I know exactly what every lead costs me."

Ryan's Rant

Saying Google Ads doesn't work because you spent \$35 is like saying a pipe wrench doesn't work because you used it as a hammer. The tool isn't the problem. How you used it is the problem.

“I tried Google Ads” should be banned from every plumber’s vocabulary. You didn’t TRY Google Ads. You dabbled. You spent a weekend afternoon setting up something you didn’t understand, funded it with pocket change, sent traffic to a broken website, didn’t track anything, and declared the whole platform a fraud after a week.

That’s not trying. That’s a donation to Google.

If a homeowner called you and said “I tried to fix my own water heater. I watched a YouTube video, bought a \$5 part from Amazon, and spent 20 minutes on it. Plumbing doesn’t work” - you’d laugh. You’d say, “That’s not how this works. You need the right parts, the right tools, and someone who knows what they’re doing.”

Google Ads is the same. Right budget. Right keywords. Right landing pages. Right tracking. Right expertise. Do it properly or don’t do it at all. But don’t tell me the tool doesn’t work because you used it wrong.

Wrench Turn Action Items

1. If you’ve run Google Ads before, log in and check your Search Terms report. Go to ads.google.com. Click into your campaign. Find the “Search Terms” report. This shows you the actual searches people typed before clicking your ad. If you see things like “plumber salary” or “how to become a plumber” in there - you were paying for irrelevant clicks. That’s money you lit on fire.

2. Calculate your current cost per lead from ALL sources. Total marketing spend last month / total leads last month = your cost per lead. This is your baseline. When you run Google Ads properly, you should be able to beat this number - or at least know how it compares.

3. Research what plumbing Google Ads cost in your area. Go to Google Keyword Planner (free with a Google Ads account). Type in keywords like “emergency plumber [your city]” and “water heater repair [your city].” Look at the suggested bid range. This tells you what a click costs in your market and helps you set a realistic budget.

4. If you're going to run Google Ads, commit to a real budget for at least 90 days. \$1,000-\$2,000/month minimum in most markets. For 90 days. Not one week. Not one month. Ninety days gives the campaign time to generate data, optimize, and deliver real results. Anything less is not a test - it's a waste.

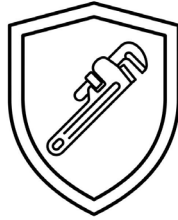
5. Make sure your landing page has these four things. Before you spend a dime on ads: (1) one specific service per page, (2) one clear call to action, (3) a click-to-call button, and (4) customer reviews or testimonials. If your landing page doesn't have all four, fix it before you launch.

Now you know WHY Google Ads works and how not to waste money on it. Want the full setup guide?

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/google-ads. Google Ads for Plumbers: Setup Guide, Budget Calculator, and Landing Page Templates.

Want us to run your Google Ads campaigns for you?

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/call



CHAPTER II

“WHAT’S GOOGLE GUARANTEED?”

LOCAL SERVICE ADS - THE BADGE THAT BUILDS TRUST

“I thought it was another scam. Turns out it’s the best money I’ve ever spent.” - Shane, after his first 90 days on LSAs

Shane is a skeptic. Always has been. When Google Ads came along, he said it was a scam (he was wrong - Chapter 10). When someone suggested SEO, he said it was snake oil (also wrong - Chapter 6). When his buddy told him about Google Local Service Ads, Shane rolled his eyes. “Great. Another way for Google to take my money.”

But his buddy was persistent. He showed Shane his numbers. The buddy was spending \$800 a month on LSAs and getting 35 leads. He closed 22 of those - jobs averaging \$650 each. That’s \$14,300 in revenue from \$800 in ad spend. An 18:1 return.

Shane decided to try it. Ninety days. He’d give it 90 days and see.

The first month, Shane spent \$600. Got 20 leads. Closed 14 jobs. Revenue: \$8,750. His cost per customer: \$43.

Forty-three dollars per customer. On a service where the average job is \$625.

Shane doesn't think LSAs are a scam anymore. Shane thinks LSAs are the best investment he's ever made in his business. He told me: "I wish I'd started this three years ago instead of arguing about it."

What Are Local Service Ads?

Local Service Ads (LSAs) are a Google advertising product specifically designed for local service businesses - plumbers, electricians, HVAC techs, locksmiths, and similar trades.

They show up at the VERY top of Google search results. Above regular Google Ads. Above organic results. Above the Map Pack. The absolute top of the page. When someone searches "plumber near me," LSAs are the first thing they see.

Here's what makes them different from regular Google Ads:

You Pay Per Lead, Not Per Click

Regular Google Ads charge you every time someone clicks on your ad - whether they call you or not. If someone clicks your ad, looks at your page for 3 seconds, and leaves? You still pay. If a bot clicks your ad? You still pay. If a competitor clicks your ad? You still pay.

LSAs charge you only when a potential customer actually contacts you - calls you or sends you a message through the ad. No contact, no charge. That's a massive difference. It means you're paying for actual leads, not for website visitors who might or might not become customers.

The Google Guaranteed Badge

When you sign up for LSAs, Google verifies your business. They check your license, your insurance, and they run background checks. Once you're verified, you get a green "Google Guaranteed" badge on your listing.

That badge tells customers: "Google has verified this business. If you're not satisfied with the work, Google may refund you up to \$2,000."

Think about what that means from the customer's perspective. They're staring at their phone at 10pm with water pouring from the ceiling. They see three plumbing options. One of them has a green badge that says **GOOGLE GUARANTEES THIS GUY**. That's not just an ad. That's the biggest tech company in the world putting their reputation behind your business.

The trust factor is enormous. Customers click on Google Guaranteed listings at significantly higher rates than regular ads or organic results. Because the risk feels lower. Google is backing you up.

Simple Budget Control

You set a weekly budget. Google spends up to that amount and no more. If you want more leads, you increase the budget. If you're booked out, you decrease it or pause. It's straightforward.

Lead Dispute System

Not every lead is real. Sometimes you get spam calls, wrong numbers, or people looking for services you don't offer. With LSAs, you can dispute those leads. Google reviews the dispute and, if it's valid, gives you a credit. You're not paying for garbage leads.

This is a feature regular Google Ads doesn't have. With regular ads, if a bot clicks your link, you're stuck with the charge. With LSAs, if someone calls about carpet cleaning and you're a plumber, you dispute it and get your money back.

Why Plumbers Specifically Benefit from LSAs

LSAs work for all kinds of service businesses, but they work especially well for plumbers. Here's why:

Emergency intent. A huge percentage of plumbing searches are emergencies. The person's pipe just burst. Their water heater just died. Their toilet is

overflowing. They need someone NOW. LSAs show up first. The Google Guaranteed badge gives them confidence to call immediately. Speed + trust = high conversion rates.

High average ticket. Plumbing jobs tend to be higher-ticket than, say, locksmith calls. When your average job is \$500-\$800 and your cost per lead is \$30-\$60, the math works beautifully.

Trust matters. Plumbing is one of those services where customers are letting a stranger into their home. The Google Guaranteed badge reduces the fear factor significantly. It's like having a reference from the most trusted brand on the internet.

Local focus. LSAs are inherently local. You set your service area, and your ads only show to people in that area. No wasted spend on out-of-area clicks like Mike experienced with regular Google Ads.

LSAs vs. Regular Google Ads

A question I get constantly: "Should I do LSAs or regular Google Ads?"

The answer: both. They're not competing - they're complementary.

LSAs show up at the very top. Regular Google Ads show up below LSAs. Organic results show up below that. If you're running both LSAs AND regular Google Ads, you're taking up two spots on the search results page. That means your competitor gets pushed further down. And the customer sees your name twice, which reinforces trust.

But if you can only afford one? Start with LSAs. The pay-per-lead model means less risk. The Google Guaranteed badge builds instant trust. And the cost per lead tends to be lower than regular Google Ads for plumbing services.

Once LSAs are running profitably, add regular Google Ads to capture even more market share.

The Verification Process

Getting set up with LSAs isn't as instant as regular Google Ads. There's a verification process, and it takes some time. Here's what to expect:

Step 1: Apply. Go to ads.google.com/local-services-ads and create a profile. You'll enter your business info, services, and service area.

Step 2: Provide documentation. Google will ask for your plumbing license, your general liability insurance, and your business insurance. They need to verify you're legit.

Step 3: Background check. Google runs background checks on the business owner (and sometimes employees). This is done through a third-party provider and typically takes 1-3 weeks.

Step 4: Approval. Once everything checks out, your profile goes live. You get the Google Guaranteed badge, and your ads start showing to local searchers.

The whole process typically takes 2-4 weeks. It's not instant, but it's worth the wait. Gather your documents now so you're ready.

Managing Your LSA Performance

Once you're live, there are a few things to know about optimizing your LSA performance:

Reviews matter - a lot. Your star rating and review count heavily influence how often your LSA shows up and where it's positioned. More reviews = more visibility. This ties directly back to Chapter 5. Your review system doesn't just help your Google Business Profile - it helps your LSAs too.

Response time matters. Google tracks how quickly you respond to leads. Businesses that respond faster get better placement. If a lead comes in and you take 4 hours to call back, Google notices. If you respond in 5 minutes, Google rewards you with more visibility.

Availability matters. If you mark yourself as unavailable frequently, or if customers report that you didn't show up, your ranking drops. LSAs reward reliable businesses.

Dispute bad leads. Don't just accept every charge. If you get a lead that's clearly spam, a wrong number, or outside your service area, dispute it. Google will review it and give you a credit. But do this honestly - don't dispute legitimate leads you just didn't close.

Pipe Dream vs. Pipeline

Pipe Dream: "That's just another Google scam to take my money."

Pipeline: "I'm Google Guaranteed, I show up first, and I only pay for real leads."

Ryan's Rant

Google is literally putting a badge on your business that says "WE GUARANTEE THIS GUY." They're lending you their reputation. The biggest tech company in the world - a company worth over \$2 trillion - is vouching for you to every person in your city who searches for a plumber.

And you think that's a scam?

That's the best co-sign in the history of small business. It's like if the president of the United States walked around with you, pointed at you, and said "hire this plumber" to every homeowner you passed.

You can't BUY that kind of endorsement anywhere else. And Google is offering it to you for \$30-\$60 per lead. If that's a scam, sign me up for more scams.

Wrench Turn Action Items

1. Search "plumber near me" on your phone right now. Look at the very top of the results. See the listings with the green "Google Guaranteed" badge? Those are LSAs. That's where you want to be. Notice how they appear ABOVE

everything else - above regular ads, above the Map Pack, above organic results.

2. Go to ads.google.com/local-services-ads and check if LSAs are available in your area. LSAs aren't available everywhere yet, but they're in most US markets. Enter your zip code and service category. If they're available, start the signup process.

3. Gather your documentation. You'll need your plumbing license, general liability insurance, and business insurance to get verified. Gather these now so you're ready when Google asks for them. The faster you submit, the faster you get approved.

4. Set a test budget: \$500-\$1,000/month for 90 days. This is a reasonable starting point for most markets. It's enough to generate meaningful data without breaking the bank. Track every lead. Calculate your cost per customer. After 90 days, you'll know if LSAs work in your market (spoiler: they almost certainly will).

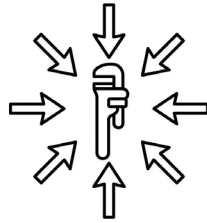
5. Track every lead - LSAs have a built-in dashboard. Unlike regular Google Ads, LSAs have a simple dashboard that shows you every lead, every call, every message. Review it weekly. Dispute bad leads. Calculate your ROI. Let the data guide your budget decisions.

Now you know WHY Local Service Ads are a game-changer. Want the step-by-step setup guide?

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/lsa. How to Set Up Google Local Service Ads for Plumbers - from application to first lead.

Want us to manage your LSA campaigns?

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/call



CHAPTER 12

“I SPEND \$2K/MONTH ON ANGI AND I DON’T KNOW WHY”

LEAD SERVICES VS. OWNING YOUR LEADS

“*I can’t quit Angi. If I do, the leads stop. But I also can’t tell you if it’s actually working.*” - Frank, trapped in a lead service loop

Frank has been paying HomeAdvisor - now Angi - for three years. Two thousand dollars a month. Every month. Rain or shine. That’s \$72,000 over three years.

Frank gets leads from Angi. He does. The phone rings. People need plumbing work. On the surface, it seems like it’s working.

But here’s what Frank’s leads actually look like:

Every lead is shared with 3-4 other plumbers. When a homeowner submits a request on Angi, it doesn’t go to just Frank. It goes to Frank and three of his competitors simultaneously. The homeowner’s phone rings four times in the next 90 seconds. Whoever answers first usually gets the job. If Frank is on another call, under a house, or grabbing lunch - he loses.

Frank’s close rate on Angi leads? About 20%. For every 5 leads he pays for, he gets 1 job. The other 4 go to whoever answered faster.

His cost per lead from Angi is about \$80. At a 20% close rate, his cost per CUSTOMER is \$400. On jobs that average \$550. That's a thin margin. Really thin. Especially when you factor in parts, labor, gas, and overhead.

But here's the part that keeps Frank up at night: if he cancels Angi tomorrow, the leads stop instantly. Immediately. There's no residual effect. No momentum. No compounding. Frank doesn't own anything from those three years and \$72,000. He rented a customer pipeline. And the moment he stops paying rent, he's back to zero.

Frank doesn't have a website that ranks on Google. He didn't invest in SEO. He doesn't run Google Ads. Angi IS his marketing. His entire lead flow depends on a platform he doesn't control, that charges him for shared leads, and that he can walk away from with nothing to show for it.

Frank is renting his customer pipeline instead of owning it.

Lead Services Aren't Evil - They're a Tool

I want to be fair here. Angi, HomeAdvisor, Thumbtack, Yelp, Porch - these lead generation services are not inherently bad. They serve a function. In fact, as I write this, I am currently working towards building a plumbing only lead service like this with a different model to help plumbers and consumers both have a better experience at ThePlumbingDirectory.com. These services connect homeowners with service providers. For a plumber who's just starting out and has no online presence, they can fill the gap while you build your own marketing.

The problem isn't the tool. The problem is how plumbers use it.

Most plumbers who use lead services use them as their PRIMARY - sometimes ONLY - source of new customers. They get dependent. They can't imagine where leads would come from without Angi. And that dependency creates a trap:

- You can't negotiate the price because you need the leads
- You can't leave because you have no backup

- You keep paying even when the ROI doesn't make sense
- You never build your own marketing because Angi fills the gap just enough to survive

Sound familiar? That's not a marketing strategy. That's a dependency.

The Renting vs. Owning Problem

Let me use an analogy every plumber will understand.

Renting: You pay \$2,000/month for an apartment. Every month. For years. At the end, you own nothing. The landlord owns the building. You have a roof over your head as long as you keep paying, but you're not building equity. The moment you stop paying, you're homeless.

Owning: You pay \$2,000/month on a mortgage. Every month. For years. At the end, you own a house. It's yours. The payments built equity. Even if you stop paying (don't do this), you still have an asset you can sell.

Lead services are renting. Your own marketing - your website, your SEO, your reviews, your Google Ads - is owning.

When you pay \$2,000/month to Angi, that money goes to Angi's equity. Their platform gets stronger. Their customer relationships get deeper. Your brand doesn't grow. Your website doesn't improve. Your Google ranking doesn't change. When you leave, you leave with nothing.

When you put \$2,000/month into your own website, SEO, and Google Ads, that money builds YOUR equity. Your website gets stronger. Your rankings improve. Your review count grows. Your brand gets more visible. After 12 months, you have an asset that generates leads whether you're actively paying or not. Your SEO keeps working. Your reviews keep attracting customers. Your content keeps ranking on Google.

\$72,000 over three years into Angi: zero long-term assets. \$72,000 over three years into your own marketing: a website that ranks, 500+ reviews, content that drives traffic, and a brand customers recognize. An asset with real, sellable value.

The Shared Lead Problem

Here's the other issue with most lead services: shared leads.

When a homeowner requests a plumber through Angi, that request goes to multiple plumbing companies. You're not the only one getting that lead. You're competing with 3-5 other plumbers for the same customer, often in real-time.

This creates a few problems:

Speed becomes everything. The plumber who calls back first usually wins. If you're on a job, under a house, or eating lunch - you lose. It turns lead management into a speed contest rather than a quality contest.

Close rates plummet. On a dedicated lead (someone who found YOUR website and called YOU), close rates are typically 60-80%. On a shared lead, close rates drop to 15-25%. The customer is talking to multiple plumbers, comparing prices, and going with whoever picks up first or cheapest.

Price pressure increases. When the customer is comparing 4 quotes simultaneously, there's pressure to be the lowest price. That's a race to the bottom. You end up competing on price instead of value, quality, or reputation.

You're paying full price for a fraction of the opportunity. If Angi charges you \$80 for a lead that's shared with 3 other plumbers, you're really paying \$80 for a 25% chance at a customer. That's effectively \$320 per customer - before you even account for the ones who choose someone else.

Compare that to a Google Ads lead where someone searched for YOUR company, clicked on YOUR ad, and landed on YOUR landing page. That's an exclusive lead. They came to you specifically. Your close rate is 3x higher and your cost per customer is lower.

Marco's Groupon Nightmare

Let me tell you about Marco. Marco tried Groupon for his plumbing business. He offered a drain cleaning special: \$49, normally \$129. He figured he'd take a hit on the first job but win the customer for life.

Groupon sold 200 vouchers in the first week. Sounds like a win, right?

Here's what actually happened:

- 200 customers, all expecting \$49 drain cleaning
- Many of them only wanted the discounted service - no upsells, no follow-up work, no loyalty
- Marco's techs were booked solid for 6 weeks doing \$49 jobs that cost him \$75 in labor and overhead
- He LOST money on every single one
- Of the 200 Groupon customers, exactly 3 became repeat clients
- Meanwhile, his regular customers - the ones who pay full price - couldn't get appointments because he was booked with Groupon jobs

Marco lost about \$5,000 in direct costs, weeks of productive capacity, and several regular customers who got frustrated with long wait times. All because he tried to buy customers at a loss.

The lesson: not all leads are created equal. A customer who finds you on Google and calls you is fundamentally different from a customer who's clicking through Groupon looking for the cheapest deal. One is looking for a plumber they can trust. The other is looking for a coupon.

The Right Way to Use Lead Services

I'm not saying you should cancel every lead service today. For some plumbers - especially newer ones without an established online presence - lead services fill an important gap. Here's how to use them smartly:

As a Supplement, Never Your Only Channel

Lead services should be ONE source of leads among many. Not the only one. If Angi disappeared tomorrow, you should still have leads coming from your website, Google Ads, LSAs, reviews, and referrals. If losing one

platform would cripple your business, you're too dependent. This goes for ThePlumbingDirectory.com as well. NEVER be fully dependent on any one service, even if it happens to be created by your favorite plumbing marketing guy.

Track ROI Ruthlessly

Know your numbers (Chapter 2). What's your cost per lead from each service? What's your close rate? What's your cost per CLOSED customer? Compare those numbers to your other channels. If Google Ads generates customers at \$150 each and Angi generates them at \$400 each, where should your money go?

Use Them to Fill Gaps While Building Owned Channels

Here's the smart play: use lead services to keep revenue flowing while you invest in building your own marketing machine. Run Angi for 12 months while you build a real website, rack up Google reviews, start SEO, and launch Google Ads. As your owned channels grow, you'll naturally rely less on lead services. Phase them down as your organic pipeline ramps up.

Phase Them Down as Your Pipeline Grows

Set a timeline. "In 6 months, I want at least 50% of my leads coming from owned channels. In 12 months, I want lead services to be less than 25% of my total leads." Track your progress. Celebrate when you hit those milestones. The day you cancel your lead service subscription because you don't need it anymore is a great day for your business.

Eli's \$72,000 Wake-Up Call

One final story. Eli runs a mid-size plumbing company. Four trucks. When I sat down with him, he was spending \$72,000 a year on marketing spread across 4 vendors:

- Angi: \$1,500/month
- A “social media guy”: \$800/month
- An SEO company: \$2,000/month
- A website maintenance service: \$1,700/month

Total: \$6,000/month. \$72,000/year.

I asked Eli what each vendor was doing for him. He couldn’t tell me. Not specifically. He knew Angi sent him leads (though he didn’t know how many or at what cost). He thought his social media guy was posting something somewhere. His SEO company sent monthly reports he never read. His website maintenance service... he wasn’t sure what they maintained.

Eli was spending \$72,000 a year and had NO IDEA what he was getting for it.

We pulled the numbers. The results were painful:

- Angi: generating customers at \$375 each (shared leads, low close rate)
- Social media guy: zero trackable leads in 8 months
- SEO company: ranking him for zero-volume keywords (the Marcus story from Chapter 6, all over again)
- Website maintenance: charging \$1,700/month to update a WordPress plugin once a quarter

Eli was getting robbed. Not maliciously in most cases - but through ignorance, lack of tracking, and vendors who knew he wasn’t paying attention.

We cut the social media guy and the overpriced website maintenance. Redirected that money into Google Ads with proper tracking and a real SEO provider who targeted actual keywords. Within 6 months, Eli’s cost per customer dropped from \$375 to \$140. Same total marketing spend. Dramatically better results.

The difference wasn’t the money. It was knowing where the money was going and holding every dollar accountable.

Pipe Dream vs. Pipeline

Pipe Dream: “Lead services give me all the work I need.”

Pipeline: “Lead services supplement my pipeline while I build marketing channels I actually OWN.”

Ryan’s Rant

Paying Angi \$2,000/month for shared leads is like paying rent on a house you’ll never own. Every dollar goes to THEIR equity, not yours. Three years from now, you’ll have paid \$72,000 and you’ll own exactly nothing. No website that ranks. No reviews that compound. No brand that customers recognize. Just a receipt.

Now imagine you put that same \$2,000 into your own website, your SEO, and your Google Ads. In 12 months, you’d have a website that generates leads while you sleep. You’d have 200+ reviews that attract customers on autopilot. You’d have Google Ads generating exclusive leads at half the cost of shared Angi leads.

In three years, you’d have an asset worth \$350,000 instead of a pile of invoices worth \$0.

I’m not saying cancel Angi today. I’m saying start building something you OWN today. And phase out the rented pipeline as your owned pipeline grows. That’s not a marketing strategy. That’s a business strategy.

Wrench Turn Action Items

1. Add up everything you’ve spent on lead services in the last 12 months. Angi, HomeAdvisor, Thumbtack, Yelp ads, Porch - all of it. Write the total down. Look at it. That’s money you spent renting leads. Now ask: how much of that built a long-term asset?

2. Calculate your cost per CLOSED customer from each lead service. Not cost per lead - cost per customer. Take what you spent, divide by the number of jobs that resulted. If you’re paying \$300-\$400 per customer from shared leads while Google Ads could get you customers at \$150 - you have your answer.

3. Compare to other channels. If you're running Google Ads, LSAs, or getting organic leads, what's the CPA from each? If you're not tracking this (Chapter 2), now's the time to start. You can't make smart decisions with lead services if you don't know how they compare.

4. Ask yourself: if I stopped paying tomorrow, how many leads would I still get? If the answer is "zero" or "very few" - you're too dependent. That's not a crisis today, but it's a vulnerability. Start building owned channels now so you have a backup.

5. Start building one owned channel this month. Even if you keep your lead services running. Get your Google Business Profile set up (Chapter 4). Start asking for reviews (Chapter 5). Look into Google Ads (Chapter 10). Build something that belongs to YOU. Something that grows over time instead of resetting to zero when you stop paying.

Now you know WHY owning your leads matters. Want help building a marketing pipeline you actually own?

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/lead-services. Lead Services for Plumbers: When to Use Them, When to Leave Them - a framework for making the switch.

Ready to build your own marketing machine?

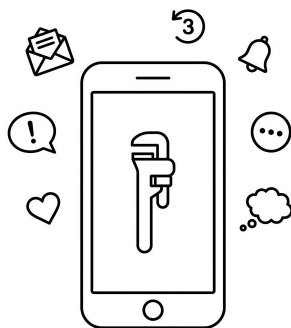
OnlyPlumbingSites.com/call

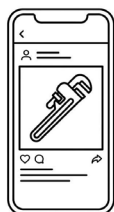
PART V

SOCIAL MEDIA & BRAND

“You don’t need to go viral. You just need to be visible.”

-Ryan Pietrzak





CHAPTER 13

“I DON’T NEED SOCIAL MEDIA, I’M A PLUMBER”

THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK

“**N**obody wants to see me dance on TikTok.” - Rick, confusing visibility with entertainment

Rick’s last Facebook post was a stock photo that said “Happy Thanksgiving from Rick’s Plumbing!” It was posted in 2021. Three years ago. It got 4 likes - his wife, his mom, his sister, and a guy named Derek who Rick went to high school with and hasn’t talked to since.

Rick has 47 followers on his business Facebook page. Forty-three of them are family members. The other four are mystery accounts that may or may not be bots.

Rick says social media is a waste of time. “I’m a plumber, not an influencer. Nobody wants to see me on the internet. Social media is for kids and people who dance on camera.”

Rick is wrong. But I understand why he thinks he’s right.

When Rick hears “social media,” he pictures TikTok dances, Instagram models, and YouTubers with ring lights and editing software. He pictures a world that has nothing to do with plumbing and everything to do with entertainment.

And he's right that THAT world has nothing to do with his business.

But that's not what social media for plumbers looks like.

A plumber in the next town over - let's call him Nathan (you met him in Chapter 8) - posts on Facebook 3-4 times a week. No dancing. No lip-syncing. No pointing at text. He posts before/after photos of jobs he's done. "Replaced a 15-year-old water heater in [City] today. The old one was rusting from the inside out. If yours is over 10 years old, give it a checkup." He posts 30-second tip videos filmed on his phone. "Here's how to tell if your water pressure is too high." He posts customer shoutouts. "Thanks to the Johnson family for trusting us with their bathroom remodel!"

Nathan gets DMs asking for quotes. He gets comments saying "saving this for when I need a plumber." He gets tagged in neighborhood Facebook groups when someone asks for a plumber recommendation.

Nathan doesn't dance. Nathan doesn't point at text. Nathan shows his work. And his phone rings because of it.

Rick is invisible. Nathan is visible. That's the only difference.

You Don't Need to Be an Influencer. You Need to Be Visible.

Let me reframe social media for plumbers in one sentence:

Social media is free advertising that builds trust before a customer ever calls you.

That's it. It's not entertainment. It's not content creation for the sake of content creation. It's showing up in the places where your potential customers spend time, so that when they need a plumber, they think of you.

Think about it from the customer's perspective. They need a plumber. They do two things:

1. **They search Google** (which we've covered in Chapters 3-9)
2. **They ask their network** - and in 2026, "their network" includes Facebook groups, Nextdoor, and Instagram

When someone posts in their local Facebook group "Anyone know a good plumber?" - whose name comes up? If you've been posting regularly, sharing your work, engaging with the community, there's a good chance YOUR name gets mentioned. Not because you asked for the referral, but because you've been **VISIBLE**. People remember you.

If you haven't posted since 2021? Nobody remembers you. You're wearing an invisibility cloak.

What Plumbers Should Actually Post

Here's the content that works for plumbing companies on social media. None of it requires dancing, expensive equipment, or a marketing degree.

1. Before/After Photos

This is the easiest and most effective content type for plumbers. Take a photo of the problem. Fix the problem. Take a photo of the result. Post both side by side.

"Before: a corroded water heater that was one bad day away from flooding the garage. After: a brand new 50-gallon Rheem, installed and ready to go. Another happy customer in [City]."

People LOVE before/after content. It's satisfying. It's visual proof that you solve problems. And the grosser the "before" photo, the more engagement you get. A clogged drain full of grease and hair? Post it. A corroded pipe that's about to burst? Post it. People are fascinated by this stuff.

2. Quick Tip Videos

Thirty to sixty seconds. Filmed on your phone. Answer one question or share one tip.

“Hey, quick tip - if your water pressure seems low, check this valve first before you call a plumber. [Shows valve.] If it’s not fully open, turn it and see if that fixes it. If not, give us a call.”

These establish you as an expert. They provide real value. And they reach people who might not need you today but will remember you when they do.

3. Day-in-the-Life Content

People are genuinely fascinated by trades. “A day in the life of a plumber” content gets incredible engagement. Show your morning routine. Show you loading the truck. Show you arriving at a job. Show the problem. Show the fix. Show the satisfied customer.

You don’t need to narrate it. You don’t need fancy editing. Just film snippets throughout the day and post them. People eat this stuff up.

4. Customer Testimonials

Screenshot a nice Google review and post it with a thank-you message. Share a kind text from a customer (with their permission). Post a photo with a happy customer giving a thumbs up next to the work you did.

Social proof on social media is double social proof. People see that others trust you AND that you’re active and engaged.

5. Team and Culture Content

If you have a team, show them off. Team photos. Birthday celebrations. Work anniversaries. New truck reveals. Training days. This content does double duty: it attracts customers AND it attracts potential employees (more on that in Chapter 20).

Platform Rankings for Plumbers

Not all social media platforms are equal for plumbing companies. Here’s how I rank them, in order of importance:

1. Google Business Profile

Technically not “social media,” but it has a posting feature that most plumbers ignore completely (Chapter 4). Post here first. It directly affects your Google visibility.

2. Facebook (and Facebook Marketplace)

Still the #1 platform for local service businesses, especially if your customers are 35+. Facebook groups are gold mines for plumber recommendations. A strong business page with regular posts keeps you top of mind. And Facebook Marketplace / local groups are where “anyone know a good plumber?” posts live.

3. Instagram

A visual platform - perfect for before/after photos. Instagram Reels (short videos) are getting huge reach in 2026. Post your best job photos here.

4. YouTube

The long-term play. Tip videos and how-to content on YouTube rank in Google search. Nathan’s water heater video has 40,000 views and generates 15 calls a month - and it’ll keep working for years. YouTube is slower to build but has the longest lifespan.

5. TikTok

Optional, but trades content is exploding on TikTok. Aaron filmed a video of himself in a T-Rex costume fixing a pipe. 2.3 million views. Did it get him direct calls? Probably not many. But his brand recognition in his market went through the roof.

6. Nextdoor

Hyperlocal. Gold for service businesses. Lorenzo - a plumber I talked to - has 40 unpaid advocates on Nextdoor. People he’s never marketed to who recommend him every time someone posts “need a plumber” in his neighborhood. He gets 15-20 calls a month from Nextdoor. Cost: \$0.

The Alvin Contrarian Take

Now, here's the part where I play devil's advocate with myself.

Alvin is a plumber who QUIT social media. Completely. Deleted his Facebook business page. Stopped posting on Instagram. Walked away from all of it.

His revenue went UP 15%.

Wait, what?

Here's what happened: Alvin was spending 5-8 hours a week creating social media content. Filming, editing, posting, responding to comments, stressing about engagement. It was consuming him. And the ROI was... meh. A few calls here and there, but nothing that justified the time.

When Alvin quit social media, he redirected those 5-8 hours per week into Google Business Profile optimization, review generation, and working with an SEO company. He focused all his energy on Google - the place where people with IMMEDIATE plumbing needs actually search.

His Google visibility went up. His reviews went from 80 to 200 in 6 months. His organic traffic doubled. And his revenue followed.

The lesson is NOT “quit social media.” The lesson is: **be visible SOMEWHERE. Not everywhere.**

If you're spending 10 hours a week on social media and getting zero calls, while your Google Business Profile has 7 reviews and no recent photos - your time is going to the wrong place. Fix Google first. That's where the emergency calls come from. Social media is dessert. Google is the main course.

But if you can do both? Even at a basic level? A few Facebook posts a week plus a strong Google presence? That's the winning combination.

The “If You Didn't Photograph It, It Didn't Happen” Rule

Dean is a plumber who does 3-4 jobs a day. Good jobs. Interesting problems. Satisfying fixes. And he photographs exactly zero of them.

Three to four content opportunities per day. Every single day. Gone. Because Dean doesn't pull out his phone and snap a quick photo.

Here's my rule: **if you didn't photograph it, it didn't happen.** Not for your records - for your marketing.

Every job is a potential social media post. Every before/after is a trust-building opportunity. Every interesting problem is a story that could attract new customers. But only if you capture it.

Make it a habit. Before you start a job, snap a "before" photo. After you finish, snap an "after." It takes 10 seconds. Those 10 seconds become a Facebook post, an Instagram photo, a Google Business Profile update, and a piece of your portfolio - all from one job.

Dean could have 1,000+ pieces of content from the last year alone. Instead, he has zero. Don't be Dean.

Posting Cadence: How Often Is Enough?

The ideal posting frequency for a plumbing company on social media is 3-5 times per week. That keeps you visible, keeps your page active, and gives the algorithms enough content to show your stuff to people.

But here's the truth: **2-3 posts per week beats silence.** Even 1 post per week beats the "Happy Thanksgiving 2021" post that's been sitting there for three years.

Don't let perfect be the enemy of good. If you can post a job photo three times a week, that's 156 posts a year. That's 156 times someone in your area sees your name, your work, and your professionalism. Compare that to zero.

Batch your content. At the end of each day, take 5 minutes to pick the best

photo from that day's work and write a quick caption. Save it as a draft. Post one per day over the next few days. This way you're never scrambling for something to post.

Pipe Dream vs. Pipeline

Pipe Dream: "Social media is a waste of time for a plumber."

Pipeline: "Social media is free advertising that builds trust before a customer ever calls me."

Ryan's Rant

You don't need to dance. You don't need to lip-sync. You don't need to point at text floating above your head. You don't need transitions. You don't need a ring light. You don't need to go viral. You don't need to become an influencer.

But if you think that NOT showing up online is a strategy, you're wearing an invisibility cloak in a world where everyone finds their plumber on Google and Facebook.

Your customers are on social media. They're scrolling Facebook right now. They're browsing Instagram. They're reading Nextdoor recommendations. And when someone in their feed asks "anyone know a good plumber?" - your name either comes up or it doesn't.

Take off the invisibility cloak. Post a photo of the job you did today. Write two sentences about it. Hit publish. That's it. That's social media for plumbers. And it's a whole lot better than being invisible.

Wrench Turn Action Items

- 1. Take a before/after photo on your NEXT job.** Not next week. Your next job. Before you start, snap a photo. After you finish, snap another. Post them to Facebook with a caption: "Another [service] done right in [City]. Call us at [number]." Done. Your first social media post in however long.
- 2. Film a 30-second tip video on your phone.** What's the most common

question customers ask you? Answer it on camera. Don't script it. Don't rehearse. Just talk for 30 seconds. Post it. Done beats perfect.

3. Claim or update your Google Business Profile (if you haven't from Chapter 4). And post something there too. A photo, a tip, a seasonal message. GBP posts help your Google ranking and they take 2 minutes.

4. Post on Nextdoor introducing your business. If you're not on Nextdoor, sign up. Post a brief introduction: who you are, what you do, what area you serve. Then engage when people ask for plumber recommendations. This alone can generate 5-10 calls a month.

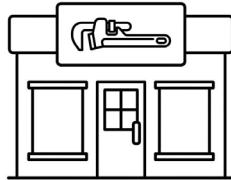
5. Set a phone reminder: "Take a job photo" - every workday. Make it a daily habit. The hardest part of social media is remembering to capture the content. An alarm on your phone that says "take a job photo" every day at 2pm fixes that. Capture first, post later.

Now you know WHY visibility matters. Want a content plan that takes the guesswork out?

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/social-media. Social Media for Plumbers: What to Post, Where to Post, How Often - with templates and a monthly calendar.

Want us to manage your social media presence?

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/call



CHAPTER 14

“FREE LEADS? ON FACEBOOK? YEAH, RIGHT.”

FACEBOOK MARKETPLACE - THE FREE MONEY NOBODY'S
TALKING ABOUT

“I posted a picture of a faucet repair with my phone number on it. Got 6 calls that week. Cost me nothing.” - Vince, who stumbled onto a goldmine

Vince is not a marketing genius. He'll be the first to tell you. He's a plumber who barely uses social media and couldn't tell you the difference between SEO and ESPN.

But Vince figured out something that most plumbers - and most marketing companies - have completely overlooked.

He posted a picture on Facebook Marketplace.

Not an ad. Not a boosted post. Not a paid campaign. A Marketplace listing. The same place people sell couches, lawnmowers, and used PlayStations. Vince posted a photo of a faucet he was installing on a job, overlaid his company phone number on the image with a free app, wrote “Professional Faucet Repair & Installation - [City]” as the title, priced it at \$149, and hit publish.

Six calls that week. From one free post.

Vince thought it was a fluke. So he posted another one the next day. A water heater. “50-Gallon Water Heater + Professional Installation - [City].” Photo of a water heater he’d just installed. Phone number on the image. Price: \$1,899.

Four more calls. Two of them booked jobs.

Vince now posts 1-2 Marketplace listings per day. Every single day. It takes him about 5 minutes total. He rotates between water heaters, faucet installs, garbage disposal replacements, and drain cleaning services. Each listing includes a real job photo, his phone number on the image, and a clear call to action.

His monthly lead count from Facebook Marketplace alone? 20-30 calls. Cost? Zero dollars. Zero.

Why Facebook Marketplace Works for Plumbers

Facebook Marketplace is designed for buying and selling physical goods. Furniture, electronics, cars - stuff you can hold in your hand. It’s not technically designed for services.

But here’s the loophole that makes this work: **you’re not selling a service. You’re selling a physical product with installation included.**

A water heater is a physical product. You’re selling a water heater. The fact that it comes with professional installation? That’s a bonus. A faucet is a physical product. You’re selling a faucet - installed.

You’re not posting “plumbing services” on Marketplace. You’re posting a product listing that happens to include expert installation. There’s a meaningful difference, and it’s the reason these posts get approved.

Here’s why it works so well:

Massive local reach. Facebook Marketplace shows listings to people in your area automatically. You don’t set a target audience. You don’t pay for reach. Facebook’s algorithm does it for you, for free. When someone in your city opens Marketplace, your water heater listing shows up alongside used furniture and baby clothes.

High intent. People browsing Marketplace are in buying mode. They're looking to spend money. When they see "Water Heater + Installation - \$1,899" and they've been dealing with cold showers for a week, that listing hits different.

Zero competition. Almost no plumbers are doing this. Search Marketplace right now for "water heater installation" in your city. You'll probably find very few results. That means you're possibly the only plumber in the entire Marketplace for your area. Very little competition. No bidding war. Likely just you.

Trust through Facebook. People can see your Facebook profile. Your name. Your business page. Your history. It feels more personal and trustworthy than a random Google ad.

How to Post on Facebook Marketplace (Step by Step)

Step 1: Use an Established Facebook Account

This is important. New Facebook accounts that start posting Marketplace listings immediately can get flagged. Use your personal account or your established business account - one that has history, friends, and activity. Facebook's algorithms trust established accounts more.

Step 2: Take Real Job Photos

Every listing needs a photo. Not a stock photo - a real photo from a real job. The faucet you just installed. The water heater you just replaced. The garbage disposal sitting in the box before you install it.

Add your phone number directly on the image. Use a free app like Canva or your phone's built-in photo editor. Put your company name and phone number in bold text right on the photo. This way, even if someone just scrolls past the listing, they see your number.

Step 3: Frame It as a Physical Product

Your listing title should focus on the PRODUCT, not the service:

- **Good:** “50-Gallon Rheem Water Heater + Professional Installation”
- **Good:** “Kitchen Faucet Repair & Replacement - Parts Included”
- **Good:** “Garbage Disposal + Installation - InSinkErator Brand”
- **Not ideal:** “Plumbing Services Available” (this is a service listing, not a product)

Include a price. Even if it’s “starting at” pricing. Marketplace listings with prices get more visibility than listings without.

Step 4: Write a Short, Clear Description

Keep it simple:

“Brand new 50-gallon Rheem water heater with professional installation by a licensed plumber. Price includes the unit AND labor. Serving [City] and surrounding areas. Call or text [number] for a free quote. Same-day and next-day availability.”

Include your service area. Include your phone number again in the description. Include a call to action.

Step 5: Post 1-2 Per Day, Rotate Services

Don’t post the same thing every day. Rotate:

- Monday: Water heater listing
- Tuesday: Faucet repair listing
- Wednesday: Garbage disposal listing
- Thursday: Drain cleaning listing (frame it as “Drain Cleaning Equipment Rental + Service” or similar)
- Friday: Water heater listing (different photo)

One to two posts per day. Five minutes each. That's 30-60 Marketplace listings per month, all working for you in the background.

Step 6: Set Up an Automated Responder

This is where it gets powerful. When someone messages you through Marketplace, Facebook lets you set up automated responses. Use this.

Set up a bot or auto-reply that asks qualifying questions in a conversational format:

"Thanks for reaching out! To help me get you an accurate quote, could you: 1. Send a photo of your current [water heater/faucet/etc.]? 2. What's the model or serial number (usually on a sticker on the unit)? 3. What city/neighborhood are you in? 4. When would you like the work done?"

This qualifies the lead BEFORE you even pick up the phone. By the time you call them back, you already have photos, location, and timeline. You're not starting from zero - you're starting from informed.

You can set this up through Facebook's built-in auto-reply tools, or through a CRM like GoHighLevel (Chapter 17) that integrates with Facebook Messenger.

The Fine Print

Let me be straight with you about a few things:

Not every post will get approved. Facebook's Marketplace policies are designed for physical goods. Some of your listings may get rejected, especially if they're framed too much like a service. If a listing gets rejected, tweak the wording and try again. Focus on the physical product angle.

Don't be deceptive. You're selling a real physical product (a water heater, a faucet, a garbage disposal) with professional installation included. That's a legitimate product listing. You're not pretending to sell something you're not. You're bundling a product with a service - which is exactly what appliance stores, HVAC companies, and car dealerships do every day.

Established accounts perform better. If you're using a brand new Facebook account, you may get flagged more often. Use an account with history.

Results vary by market. In larger metro areas, Marketplace is extremely active and you'll get more eyeballs. In rural areas, traffic may be lighter. Test it for 30 days before making a judgment.

Pair It With Automation

Here's where this strategy goes from good to great.

When a Marketplace lead messages you at 9pm on a Wednesday, you're probably not going to respond immediately. You're eating dinner. You're watching TV. You're asleep.

But your automated responder IS available. It replies instantly: "Thanks for reaching out! Here are a few quick questions so I can get you an accurate quote..." The lead answers. By morning, you have a qualified prospect with photos, address, and timeline sitting in your inbox.

Connect this to your CRM (Chapter 17) or AI tools (Chapter 19) and you have a system that generates, qualifies, and organizes Marketplace leads while you sleep.

Vince set this up in one afternoon. He told me: "I spend 5 minutes a day posting listings and the rest runs itself. I wake up to qualified leads in my inbox. It's like having a salesperson who works for free."

Pipe Dream vs. Pipeline

Pipe Dream: "Facebook is for memes and birthday wishes, not plumbing leads."

Pipeline: "I post one listing a day on Facebook Marketplace and get 20-30 free calls a month."

Ryan's Rant

You're spending \$3,000 a month on Google Ads. You're paying \$1,500 a month for Angi leads. You're investing in SEO, LSAs, and a website that costs you a few grand a year to maintain.

And you're ignoring the platform where 3 BILLION people spend an average of 33 minutes a day - a platform that lets you post product listings for FREE that get shown to people IN YOUR CITY who are IN BUYING MODE.

Facebook Marketplace is not the future of plumber marketing. It's the present that almost nobody has discovered yet. It's a wide-open field with zero competition. And it takes 5 minutes a day.

Five minutes. Zero dollars. Twenty-plus leads a month.

I can't make the math any clearer than that. Post the listing. Get the calls.

Wrench Turn Action Items

1. Open Facebook Marketplace right now and search "water heater installation" in your city. How many results do you see? Probably zero. That's your opportunity. Zero competition.

2. Post your first Marketplace listing TODAY. Take a photo of your last job (or a product in your truck). Add your phone number to the image. List it as a product + installation. Write a 3-sentence description. Hit publish. Done.

3. Set up Facebook's auto-reply for Marketplace messages. Go to your Facebook business page settings and configure an instant reply for Marketplace inquiries. Even a simple "Thanks for reaching out! We'll get back to you within 15 minutes" buys you time and keeps the lead warm.

4. Commit to 1 post per day for 30 days. Rotate services. Different photo each time. Track every call and message that comes from Marketplace. After 30 days, calculate your cost per lead (spoiler: it's \$0) and compare it to your paid channels.

5. Connect Marketplace leads to your CRM or phone. Make sure every Marketplace inquiry gets logged and followed up on. The leads are free - don't waste them by forgetting to respond (Chapter 17).

Now you know WHY Facebook Marketplace is free money for plumbers. Want posting templates and auto-reply scripts?

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/facebook-marketplace. Facebook Marketplace for Plumbers: Posting Templates, Photo Tips, and Automation Scripts.

Want us to set up your Marketplace system?

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/call



CHAPTER 15

“MY LOGO IS MY BRAND, RIGHT?”

BUILDING A BRAND THAT BOOKS JOBS

“*We just got a new logo. Brand is handled.*” - Pat, who has a logo but not a brand

Pat spent \$5,000 on a new logo last year. Hired a design agency. They came back with something sharp - custom typography, a stylized wrench icon, a clean color palette of navy blue and orange. Pat put it on his trucks, his shirts, his business cards, his invoices, his website header.

Pat thinks his brand is done.

Then I asked him a simple question: “What makes your company different from the other 40 plumbers in your city?”

He paused. Looked at the ceiling. Scratched his jaw.

“Uh... we do good work?”

So do the other 40.

“We’re reliable?”

So are most of them.

“We’ve been around for 12 years?”

At least 15 of them have been around longer.

Pat has a logo. He does not have a brand.

A logo is a picture. A brand is the FEELING people have about your company. It’s what customers say about you when you’re not in the room. It’s the reason someone calls you instead of the other 40 plumbers, even when you’re not the cheapest.

Meanwhile, across town, there’s a plumber everyone calls “Hank the Tank.” Real name: Hank. He drives a wrapped truck with a cartoon tank on it. His techs wear orange shirts that say “HANK THE TANK PLUMBING - We’ll Crush Your Clogs.” His Google reviews are full of customers calling him by name. “Hank showed up in 30 minutes and fixed our toilet. Love this guy!” His Facebook page has 2,000 followers - not because he runs ads, but because his customers actually like him and share his posts.

Hank does \$1.3 million a year. He didn’t hire a branding agency. He didn’t spend \$5,000 on a logo. He accidentally built a brand by being himself, being consistent, and giving people something to remember.

Pat has a logo. Hank has a brand.

Which one do you think gets more calls?

A Brand Is Not a Logo

Let me clear this up once and for all.

Your logo is part of your brand. It’s the visual identifier. The thing people see on your truck, your uniform, your website. It matters. But it’s about 5% of your brand.

The other 95%? That's everything else:

Your brand is the feeling a customer gets when they interact with your company. From the first Google search to the final invoice. Every touchpoint. Every interaction. Every impression.

It's whether the customer felt heard when they called. Whether the tech showed up on time. Whether they explained the problem in plain English or mumbled jargon and handed over a \$800 bill. Whether the truck was clean or looked like a crime scene. Whether the follow-up text felt personal or automated.

A brand is the answer to the question: **"When people think about your company, what do they feel?"**

If the answer is "I don't know" - you don't have a brand. You have a business that operates in the background, indistinguishable from every other plumber in the area. That might work for survival. It won't work for growth.

The Five Elements of a Plumbing Brand

1. Differentiator - What Makes You Different?

This is the hardest question for most plumbers to answer. And it's the most important one.

Ivan has been plumbing for 14 years. Smart guy. Does quality work. When I asked him what makes his company different, he said: "We provide quality plumbing services with great customer service." That's not a differentiator. That's a LinkedIn bio. Every plumber says that. It means nothing to a customer comparing you to three other options.

A real differentiator is specific: - "We show up in 60 minutes or less for emergencies - guaranteed." - "We put our prices on our website. No surprises. Ever." - "We clean up so well, you won't know we were there." - "We specialize in older homes built before 1970." - "We're the only plumber in [city] open 24/7, 365 days a year."

Dennis - a plumber doing \$1.1 million a year - put all his prices on his website. Every service. Transparent pricing. His competitors thought he was crazy. His customers thought he was honest. Honesty became his brand. "The plumber who tells you the price before he shows up." That's a differentiator. That's memorable. That's a brand.

What's yours? If you can't say it in one sentence, you need to figure it out.

2. Consistency - Same Experience, Every Time

A brand is built on repetition. The customer experience should be the same whether they get Tech A or Tech B. Whether it's Monday morning or Saturday night. Whether it's a \$150 repair or a \$5,000 repipe.

Consistency means: - Your trucks all look the same (clean, wrapped, professional) - Your techs all wear the same uniform - Your phone greeting is the same every time - Your follow-up process is the same for every customer - Your website, your social media, and your trucks look like they belong to the same company

When a customer sees your truck on Monday, your Facebook post on Wednesday, and your website on Friday - and all three look and feel like the same company - that's brand consistency. It builds recognition. It builds trust.

When your truck is wrapped in blue but your website is red and your Facebook page uses a different logo from 2018 - that's brand confusion. And confusion doesn't book jobs.

3. Personality - What's Your Company's Vibe?

Every strong brand has a personality. Not a fake corporate personality - a real one.

Are you the "fast and friendly" plumber? The "honest pricing" plumber? The "we'll fix anything" plumber? The "emergency specialist"? The "old-school craftsmanship" plumber?

Hank the Tank's personality is fun, loud, and memorable. That's not for everyone - but it works for Hank because it's authentic. He's actually like that in person.

Your brand personality should be an amplified version of who you actually are. If you're a quiet, meticulous craftsman, your brand shouldn't be loud and wild. If you're a high-energy, joke-cracking people person, your brand shouldn't be corporate and stiff.

Authenticity is the key. Customers can smell fake from a mile away.

4. Reputation - What Do People Say About You?

Your Google reviews, your word-of-mouth referrals, your Nextdoor recommendations - these are your brand in action. They're what customers actually say about you, which matters infinitely more than what you say about yourself.

This is why Chapters 4 and 5 matter so much. Your Google Business Profile and your reviews ARE your brand to anyone who finds you online. They're the first impression. And first impressions become lasting impressions.

If your reviews say "showed up on time, explained everything, fair price" - that's your brand. If your reviews say "hard to reach, expensive, left a mess" - that's also your brand. Whether you like it or not.

5. Visibility - If Nobody Knows You Exist, Your Brand Doesn't Matter

This is where everything in this book comes together. You can have the best differentiator, the most consistent experience, the greatest personality, and a stellar reputation - but if nobody can find you, none of it matters.

Visibility is the amplifier. It's what takes your brand from "known by 50 loyal customers" to "known by 5,000 potential customers." Your website, your Google presence, your social media, your ads - they're all tools for making your brand visible to people who don't know you yet.

A brand without visibility is a tree falling in an empty forest. It might be magnificent, but nobody hears it.

Why Truck Wraps Matter More Than You Think

Quick sidebar on truck wraps, because Brett's story is worth telling.

Brett spent \$4,000 wrapping his truck. Full wrap - his company name, phone number, logo, services, and a clean design that stands out in traffic. His wife thought he was crazy spending that much on "stickers."

Brett gets 3-5 calls per week from people who saw his truck. Not from Google. Not from ads. From his truck. Sitting in traffic. Parked at a job site. Parked in his driveway.

Over a year, that's 150-250 calls from a one-time \$4,000 investment. If he closes even half of those at a \$500 average ticket, that's \$37,500-\$62,500 in revenue from a \$4,000 wrap.

Your truck is a mobile billboard. It's in neighborhoods, on highways, in parking lots - everywhere your customers are. A professional wrap turns every mile you drive into a marketing impression.

And here's the brand angle: a wrapped truck says "this is a real company." An unmarked white van says "this might be a plumber or might be a kidnapper." People trust wrapped trucks. They remember them. They call the number they saw in traffic when their toilet breaks three weeks later.

The One-Sentence Test

Here's an exercise I do with every plumbing company I work with:

Write one sentence that answers: "Why should a customer choose you over every other plumber in your city?"

One sentence. Not a paragraph. Not a list. One clear, specific, memorable sentence.

If you can't do it, that's your biggest brand problem. Not your logo. Not your colors. Your inability to articulate why you're different.

Here are some examples that work: - “We’re the only plumber in Austin that guarantees a 60-minute response time for emergencies.” - “We post all our prices online because we believe you deserve to know before we show up.” - “We specialize in homes built before 1960 - old pipes are our specialty.” - “Every job comes with a 2-year warranty. If it breaks, we fix it free.”

Here are examples that DON’T work: - “We provide quality plumbing services.” (So does everyone.) - “Customer satisfaction is our priority.” (That’s a bumper sticker, not a brand.) - “Family owned and operated since 2008.” (Nice, but not a reason to choose you.)

Your one sentence is your brand in miniature. It’s what you put on your truck, your website, your Google description, and your elevator pitch. Get it right and everything else falls into place.

Pipe Dream vs. Pipeline

Pipe Dream: “I got a logo - my brand is handled.”

Pipeline: “My brand is what customers feel, say, and remember about my company.”

Ryan’s Rant

I’m going to save you a lot of money right now: your brand is not your logo. I know you spent \$5,000 on it. I know the designer showed you mood boards and color psychology and font pairing rationale. And the logo looks great. It does.

But your brand is whether the homeowner recommends you to their neighbor or not. Your brand is whether someone sees your truck and thinks “those are the guys!” or doesn’t notice at all. Your brand is the feeling a customer has when they hang up the phone after scheduling an appointment.

You can’t buy a brand at a design agency. You build a brand one customer interaction at a time. One on-time arrival at a time. One honest estimate at a time. One clean job site at a time. One five-star review at a time.

The logo goes on the brand. The brand doesn’t come from the logo.

Wrench Turn Action Items

1. Write one sentence: what makes your company different? Not a paragraph. One sentence. If you can't do it in under 15 words, it's not clear enough. If it could describe any other plumber in your city, it's not specific enough. Keep working on it until it passes both tests.

2. Ask 5 past customers: "Why did you choose us?" Call them. Text them. Email them. Ask the question and LISTEN to the answers. Don't prompt them. Let them tell you in their own words what your brand is. Their answers might surprise you - and they'll be more honest than anything you come up with yourself.

3. Google your company name. What shows up? The first page of Google results for your company name IS your brand to the world. What do people see? Reviews? Your website? A half-finished GBP listing? Nothing? Whatever shows up is your brand's first impression. Make sure it's a good one.

4. Look at your truck, your shirt, and your website. Do they look like the same company? Same colors? Same logo? Same vibe? If your truck is wrapped in blue but your website is green and your Facebook uses a logo from 2016 - you have a consistency problem. Pick one look and apply it everywhere.

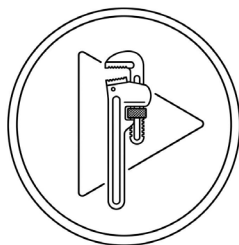
5. Pick one word you want customers to associate with your business. Now live it. Fast. Honest. Reliable. Clean. Friendly. Pick one. Make it your north star. Every decision you make - hiring, training, marketing, pricing - should reinforce that word. That's how a brand is built. Not in a day. Over time. One decision at a time.

Now you know WHY brand matters more than a logo. Want help building a brand that stands out?

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/branding. Building a Plumbing Brand That Stands Out - without spending \$10K on a designer.

Want us to help define and build your brand?

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/call



CHAPTER 16

“NOBODY WANTS TO WATCH A PLUMBER ON THE INTERNET”

VIDEO MARKETING WITHOUT THE CRINGE

“I’m not doing that pointing-at-text thing.” - Every plumber over 35, and they’re right

Nathan filmed one video.

One. Five minutes long. Shot on his phone in a customer’s garage. No editing. No fancy intro. No background music. No ring light. No transitions. Just Nathan - a plumber in a work shirt - standing next to a water heater and talking to his phone like he was talking to a customer.

“Hey, I’m Nathan from [Company]. I’m here on a job and I want to show you something. See this water heater? It’s 14 years old. And there are five signs that tell you yours might be about to die. Let me show you what to look for.”

He walked through each sign. Pointed at the corrosion on the tank. Showed the rust-colored water coming from the drain valve. Tapped on the housing and you could hear the sediment rattling inside. Explained what each sign meant in plain English.

Five minutes. One take. Uploaded to YouTube with the title: “How to Tell If Your Water Heater Is About to Die | [Company Name] [City].”

That video has 40,000 views. It generates 15 calls per month. Nathan spent \$0 making it. He didn’t dance. He didn’t point at text. He didn’t lip-sync. He answered a question people were typing into YouTube, and YouTube answered back with free leads for the next three years and counting.

Fifteen calls a month from one video. That’s 180 calls a year. At Nathan’s average ticket of \$550 and a 60% close rate, that single video generates roughly \$59,400 in annual revenue.

From five minutes of work. Once.

Tell me again how nobody wants to watch a plumber on the internet.

Video Builds Trust Faster Than Any Other Medium

Here’s why video works so well for plumbers: **people hire people they trust. And nothing builds trust faster than seeing someone’s face, hearing their voice, and watching them work.**

A blog post can establish expertise. A Google review can provide social proof. A professional website can create credibility. But a video does all three simultaneously. In 60 seconds, a potential customer sees you, hears you, watches you work, and forms an opinion about whether they’d want you in their home.

That opinion is usually positive - because plumbers who take the time to create helpful video content come across as knowledgeable, approachable, and real. The bar is low. You don’t need to be a polished presenter. You just need to be a competent plumber who can explain things clearly.

And here’s the thing most plumbers don’t realize: **you already have this skill.** You explain plumbing to customers face-to-face every single day. You show them what’s wrong, tell them why it happened, and explain what needs to be done. Customers trust you after that conversation.

Video is that same conversation - but recorded and shared with a thousand people instead of one.

Types of Video That Work for Plumbers

You don't need a YouTube channel with 100 videos. You don't need a content schedule. You need to start with ONE video. Here are the types that work best:

Quick Tips (60-90 seconds)

The bread and butter of plumber video content. Answer one question in under two minutes.

- “How to shut off your water in an emergency”
- “Why your toilet keeps running (and the \$5 fix)”
- “Three signs your water heater is failing”
- “What to do if your pipe freezes”

Film it on your phone. On the job or in your truck. No editing needed. Just hit record, talk, and stop. Post to YouTube, Facebook, Instagram Reels, and your Google Business Profile.

Before/After Walkthroughs (2-3 minutes)

Show the problem. Explain what caused it. Show the fix. Explain what you did. This is the video version of the before/after photos from Chapter 13 - but with narration that adds context and trust.

“This is what the homeowner's sewer line looked like when we scoped it. See that buildup? That's 30 years of grease and roots. Here's what it looked like after we jetted it. Night and day.”

People find this genuinely fascinating. It's satisfying to watch. And it positions you as someone who knows exactly what they're doing.

Customer Testimonials (30-60 seconds)

Emmett - a plumber I talked to - started asking happy customers one simple question on camera: “Would you mind telling people about your experience?”

Most say yes. They talk for 30-60 seconds about how great the experience was. Emmett posts these to his website, Facebook, and YouTube.

His data: one video testimonial generates an average of 3 new calls. He has 20 testimonials. That library of social proof works for him constantly - potential customers watch real people vouch for him, and the phone rings.

Day-in-the-Life (3-5 minutes)

People are fascinated by trades. “A day in the life of a plumber” is genuinely compelling content. Show your morning routine. Loading the truck. Driving to the first job. The diagnosis. The fix. The happy customer. The next call.

You don’t need to narrate it in real-time. Film snippets throughout the day - 10-second clips here and there - and string them together. Or just film one interesting job from start to finish and compress it into 3-5 minutes.

This type of content works especially well on YouTube, TikTok, and Instagram Reels.

Meet the Team (1-2 minutes)

Introduce your team. Who are they? How long have they been plumbing? What do they specialize in? Why do they work for your company?

This builds trust (customers want to know who’s coming into their home) and helps with recruiting (potential employees see your culture and want to be part of it - Chapter 20).

The “Good Enough” Standard

I know what you’re thinking: “My videos will look terrible. I don’t have good equipment. I don’t know how to edit. It’ll be embarrassing.”

Here's the standard for plumber video content: good enough.

Not perfect. Not polished. Not cinematic. **Good enough.**

That means: - **Phone camera.** Your smartphone shoots better video than professional cameras from 10 years ago. It's more than sufficient. - **Decent lighting.** Don't film in a dark basement with your phone flashlight. Natural light or well-lit rooms work fine. Face a window if you're filming yourself. - **Speak clearly.** Talk like you're explaining something to a customer. Not to a camera. To a person. - **Keep it short.** Under 2 minutes for tips. Under 5 minutes for walkthroughs. People's attention spans are short. Get to the point. - **Don't overthink it.** Hit record. Talk. Stop. Post. The video that exists and is published will always beat the perfect video that's still in your head.

Nathan's 40,000-view video was filmed in a garage on a phone with no editing. It's not pretty. It's effective. Those are different things, and effective is the only one that matters.

Where to Post Your Videos

YouTube (Long-Term Play)

YouTube is the second-largest search engine in the world (after Google, which owns YouTube). When someone types "how much does a water heater cost" into YouTube, they're looking for a video answer. If your video is that answer, you get the view and potentially the call.

YouTube videos also show up in regular Google search results. Nathan's water heater video appears not just on YouTube but on Google's first page when someone searches that topic. Double exposure.

YouTube is a long-term play. Videos take time to rank and build views. But once they do, they work for years. Nathan's video is three years old and still generating 15 calls a month.

Title your videos for search: "How to [Problem] | [Your Company] [City]"

Facebook (Immediate Reach)

Facebook videos get shared in local groups. They show up in feeds. They're easy to comment on and tag friends. For immediate local reach, Facebook is hard to beat.

Post your videos natively to Facebook (upload directly, don't just share a YouTube link). Native videos get significantly more reach in Facebook's algorithm.

Instagram Reels (Visual + Discovery)

Instagram Reels are short-form videos (15-90 seconds) that get shown to people who don't follow you yet. This is discovery content - Instagram's algorithm shows Reels to people based on their interests, not just who they follow.

Trade content performs incredibly well on Reels. Before/after transformations, quick tips, and day-in-the-life clips get tons of engagement.

TikTok (Optional - But Trades Content Is Exploding)

Aaron filmed a video of himself in a T-Rex costume fixing a pipe. 2.3 million views. Did it get him direct plumbing calls? Probably a handful. But his brand awareness in his local market went through the roof. People recognized him at the grocery store.

TikTok is optional for plumbers. But if you enjoy it, the potential reach is massive. Trade content - showing the dirty, satisfying, behind-the-scenes reality of plumbing - is one of the fastest-growing content categories on the platform.

Google Business Profile

Post videos directly to your GBP listing. Short clips (30-60 seconds) of your work. This keeps your profile active and gives potential customers another reason to trust you when they find you on Google Maps.

Lionel's Podcast Mistake

Quick cautionary tale. Lionel is a plumber who started a podcast called “Pipe Talk” where he interviews other plumbers about the industry. He’s 15 episodes in. He has 23 listeners.

Twenty-three.

Lionel’s podcast isn’t bad. It’s actually pretty interesting if you’re in the industry. But his customers aren’t in the industry. His customers are homeowners who need their toilet fixed. They’re not searching for plumbing industry podcasts. They’re searching “plumber near me.”

Lionel spent dozens of hours creating content for the wrong audience on the wrong platform. He’d have been better served filming ten 60-second tip videos and posting them to YouTube and Facebook.

The lesson: **meet your customers where THEY are, not where YOU want to be.** Your customers are on Google, YouTube, Facebook, and Nextdoor. They’re not on your niche podcast. Create content on the platforms where your actual customers spend time.

The One-Video Challenge

I’m going to challenge you right now. Before you read any further. Before you turn the page. Before you do anything else.

Film one video today.

Pull out your phone. Hit record. Answer this question: “What’s the most common plumbing problem you see, and what causes it?”

Talk for 60 seconds. Maybe 90. Don’t script it. Don’t rehearse. Just talk like you’re explaining it to a homeowner who just asked you that question on a job.

Stop recording. Upload it to YouTube with a title like: “Most Common Plumbing Problem in [Your City] | [Your Company Name]”

Share it to Facebook. Post it to your Google Business Profile.

That's it. You just did video marketing. It took 5 minutes total. And it might generate calls for the next three years.

Now imagine doing that once a week.

Pipe Dream vs. Pipeline

Pipe Dream: “Nobody wants to watch a plumber on the internet.”

Pipeline: “One video I filmed on my phone in 5 minutes gets me 15 calls a month.”

Ryan's Rant

You explain plumbing to customers face-to-face every day. Every single day. You walk into someone's house, diagnose the problem, explain what's wrong, tell them what needs to happen, and they trust you. They hand you their money. They leave you a five-star review. Because you explained something clearly and they believed you.

Now film that same explanation. Post it online. Instead of one person trusting you, a thousand people trust you. Ten thousand people trust you. Same skill. Same knowledge. Same you. The only difference is a camera.

You're not “becoming a content creator.” You're not “starting a YouTube channel.” You're doing exactly what you already do - explaining plumbing - except you're doing it once and letting the internet share it for you instead of repeating it 4 times a day to 4 individual people.

That's not cringe. That's leverage.

Wrench Turn Action Items

1. Film a 60-second tip video TODAY. Right now. What's the question customers ask you most? Answer it on camera. Phone. 60 seconds. No editing.

Post it to YouTube and Facebook. Don't think about it. Just do it.

2. Post it with a search-friendly title. “How to [Solve Problem] | [Your Company] [City].” This title format helps YouTube and Google understand what your video is about and show it to people searching for that topic.

3. Share it everywhere. YouTube. Facebook (upload natively). Instagram Reels. Google Business Profile. One video, four platforms, 5 minutes of posting. Maximum reach from minimum effort.

4. Ask your next happy customer for a video testimonial. After the job, when they're thanking you: “Would you mind saying a quick word about your experience on camera? It really helps us out.” Most will say yes. Film it on your phone. 30 seconds. Post it.

5. Set a goal: 1 video per week for 4 weeks. Just four videos. Four weeks. See what happens. Track the views. Track any calls that mention “I saw your video.” After four weeks, decide if you want to keep going. (You will.)

Now you know WHY video is the most underused tool in plumbing marketing. Want scripts, setup tips, and posting strategies?

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/video-marketing. Video Marketing for Plumbers: Scripts, Setup, and Where to Post - everything you need to start filming today.

Want us to create video content for your company?

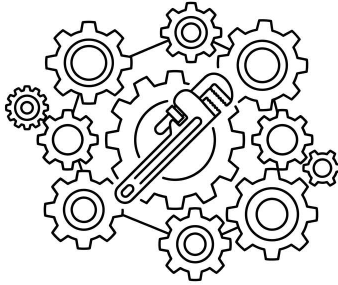
OnlyPlumbingSites.com/call

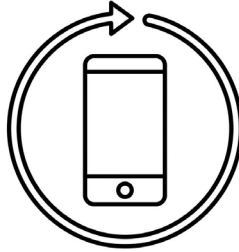
PART VI

SYSTEMS & SCALE

“Getting the phone to ring is only half the battle. What happens when it rings is the other half.”

-Ryan Pietrzak





CHAPTER 17

“I FORGOT TO CALL THEM BACK”

CRM, FOLLOW-UP, AND NOT LOSING THE LEADS YOU PAID FOR

“We spent \$2,500 on marketing last month. We also missed 8 calls and forgot to follow up on 12 estimates.” - Nolan, pouring water into a bucket full of holes

Nolan spent \$2,500 on Google Ads last month. The campaigns worked. He got 45 leads - phone calls, form fills, voicemails. Forty-five people who needed a plumber and found Nolan’s company.

Here’s what happened to those 45 leads:

- **8 calls were missed.** Nolan’s dispatcher was on another line. The calls went to voicemail. Three of those voicemails were never returned.
- **12 voicemails were “meant to be returned later.”** Later never came. Nolan got busy on a job, forgot, and by the time he remembered, those potential customers had already hired someone else.
- **3 estimates were sent out.** Good estimates. Fair prices. But nobody followed up. The estimates sat in customers’ inboxes for a week. Two of those customers went with a competitor who followed up the next day.
- **Of 45 leads, Nolan converted 14 into paying jobs.**

Fourteen out of 45. A 31% conversion rate.

Not because the leads were bad. Not because the marketing didn't work. Because Nolan's follow-up system was a Post-it note stuck to his dashboard and a memory that gets worse every year.

Nolan didn't have a lead problem. He had a bucket problem. He was pouring water in at the top and watching it leak out the bottom. And he was blaming the faucet.

Follow-Up Is Where the Money Lives

Here's a stat that should make every plumber uncomfortable: **80% of sales require at least 5 follow-up contacts. The average plumber follows up zero times.**

Zero.

A potential customer calls. You miss the call. They leave a voicemail. You mean to call back. You get under a house. You forget. That customer calls your competitor. Your competitor answers on the second ring. Your competitor gets the job.

Or: a customer requests an estimate. You send it. They don't respond within 24 hours. You assume they went with someone else. You move on. In reality, they were busy. They meant to call you. They forgot. A week later, they hired someone else - not because your price was wrong, but because the other plumber sent a follow-up text that said "Hey, just checking in - any questions about the estimate?"

The money isn't in getting the lead. The money is in converting the lead. And conversion happens through follow-up.

The Speed-to-Lead Problem

Here's another number: **responding to a lead within 5 minutes makes you 9**

times more likely to convert that lead than responding within 30 minutes.

Nine times.

Think about what happens when a homeowner has a plumbing emergency. They search Google. They find three plumbers. They call all three. The first plumber to answer - or call back - gets the job. Not the cheapest. Not the most experienced. The fastest.

In plumbing, speed is currency. The plumber who responds in 5 minutes beats the plumber who responds in 5 hours every single time. Not because they're better - because they're there.

Lyle's company learned this the hard way. His dispatcher was losing 40% of incoming calls. Not on purpose - she was one person handling phones, scheduling, and customer service simultaneously. When she was on a call, the next call went to voicemail. When she was entering a schedule, she missed the ring. Forty percent of calls, unanswered.

At Lyle's average ticket of \$450, and assuming even half of those missed calls would have converted, that's roughly \$140,000 in annual lost revenue. From missed calls alone.

\$140,000. Because one person couldn't answer two phones at the same time.

What a CRM Does (In Plumber Terms)

CRM stands for Customer Relationship Management. In corporate speak, it's a "platform for managing customer interactions across the lifecycle." In plumber terms, it's **a dispatch board for your leads.**

Here's what a CRM does:

Tracks every lead. Every phone call, every form fill, every text message, every voicemail - all in one place. No more Post-it notes. No more "I think someone called about a water heater yesterday." It's all logged, timestamped, and organized.

Reminds you to follow up. A lead comes in on Monday. You're busy. The CRM sends you a reminder on Tuesday: "You haven't responded to this lead yet." It won't let leads slip through the cracks because it doesn't forget. You do. It doesn't.

Shows you where every lead is in the process. New lead. Contacted. Estimate sent. Estimate follow-up needed. Job scheduled. Job completed. Review requested. You can see your entire pipeline at a glance and know exactly where to focus your attention.

Automates the boring stuff. A lead comes in from your website form? The CRM can automatically send a text: "Thanks for contacting [Company]! We received your request and will call you within 15 minutes." That instant response buys you time and makes the customer feel acknowledged - even if you're under a house.

Tracks your numbers. How many leads came in this month? From which sources? What's your close rate? What's your average response time? The CRM tracks all of this automatically, giving you the data from Chapter 2 without a spreadsheet.

CRM Options for Plumbers

You don't need a \$500/month enterprise system. Here are options from simple to full-featured:

The Free Option: A Google Sheet

Better than nothing. Seriously. A Google Sheet with columns for Date, Lead Source, Customer Name, Phone, Service Needed, Status, Follow-Up Date, and Notes will give you 80% of what you need. Update it every day. Review it every morning. It's not fancy, but it works.

Mid-Range: Jobber, Housecall Pro

These are field service management tools built for trades. They handle scheduling, dispatching, invoicing, AND basic CRM functions. If you're

already using one for scheduling, explore its CRM features - you might be paying for capabilities you're not using.

Full CRM: GoHighLevel, ServiceTitan

These are the heavy hitters. GoHighLevel is popular with marketing agencies and offers automated text follow-ups, review requests, and lead tracking. ServiceTitan is the industry standard for larger plumbing companies - it does everything from lead tracking to dispatch to invoicing.

The Key: Pick One and Actually USE It

The best CRM is the one you'll actually use. A \$200/month system you ignore is worse than a free Google Sheet you update daily. Start simple. Build the habit. Upgrade when you outgrow it.

Winston's \$650/Month Game-Changer

Winston runs a 3-truck plumbing company. He was drowning in follow-up. Leads coming in from Google Ads, LSAs, his website, and phone calls. He couldn't keep track of it all. His close rate was around 40% - decent, but he knew he was losing deals to poor follow-up.

Winston hired a virtual assistant (VA) for \$650/month. The VA's only job: manage the CRM and follow up on every single lead.

- Lead comes in? VA responds within 5 minutes via text.
- Estimate sent? VA follows up at 24 hours and 72 hours.
- Missed call? VA returns it within 10 minutes.
- Job completed? VA sends a review request text.

Winston's close rate went from 40% to 58% in three months. An 18-point increase. On the same number of leads, he was closing 45% more jobs. The math: if he gets 50 leads/month at a \$500 average ticket, that 18-point increase = 9 additional jobs = \$4,500 in extra monthly revenue. From a \$650/month investment.

Winston calls his VA “the best hire I’ve ever made.” She doesn’t plumb. She doesn’t dispatch. She just makes sure no lead falls through the cracks. And that single focus is worth more than most employees he’s ever hired.

The Follow-Up Framework

If you don’t have a CRM and aren’t ready to hire a VA, here’s a simple follow-up framework you can implement today:

For Missed Calls:

Within 5 minutes: Send a text. “Hey, this is [Name] from [Company]. Sorry I missed your call! I’m on a job right now but I’ll call you back within [timeframe]. What’s the best time to reach you?”

Within 1 hour: Call back. If no answer, leave a voicemail AND send another text.

At 24 hours: If still no contact, send one more text: “Hi, just following up - still need plumbing help? Happy to chat whenever works for you.”

For Estimates:

At 24 hours: Text or call. “Hey [Name], just wanted to check in on the estimate we sent. Any questions? Happy to walk through it.”

At 72 hours: One more follow-up. “Hi [Name], just a quick follow-up on your estimate. We’d love to help with this project. Let us know if you’d like to move forward or if you have any questions.”

After that: Stop. Two follow-ups on an estimate is enough. More than that feels pushy.

For Completed Jobs:

Immediately after payment: Ask for a review in person (Chapter 5).

Within 1 hour: Send the review request text with your direct link.

At 24-48 hours: One follow-up text if they haven’t left a review.

This entire framework can be done manually from your phone. It takes 2-3 minutes per lead. And it will dramatically increase your conversion rate.

Pipe Dream vs. Pipeline

Pipe Dream: “If they really want us, they’ll call back.”

Pipeline: “Every lead gets followed up within 5 minutes, and nobody falls through the cracks.”

Ryan’s Rant

You spent \$2,500 on marketing to get the phone to ring. Then you didn’t answer. You didn’t call back. You didn’t follow up on the estimate. You let 31 out of 45 leads walk away - not because they didn’t want you, but because you didn’t RESPOND to them.

That’s like paying for a fishing charter, catching 45 fish, and throwing 31 of them back because you forgot to bring a cooler. **BUY THE COOLER.**

Your cooler is a CRM. Or a Google Sheet. Or a VA. Or just a reminder on your phone that says “call back leads” twice a day. I don’t care what system you use. I care that you **HAVE** a system. Because right now, you’re paying for leads and then ignoring them, and that’s the most expensive way to waste money in plumbing marketing.

Wrench Turn Action Items

1. Check your missed calls from the last 30 days. Pull up your phone. Go to missed calls. How many did you return? How many did you ignore or forget? Be honest. Each one of those missed calls was a potential customer. How many did your competitor get instead?

2. Check your outstanding estimates. How many estimates have you sent in the last 30 days that you haven’t followed up on? Any that are just sitting there, waiting? Send a follow-up text to each one right now: “Hi [Name], just checking in on your estimate. Any questions?”

3. Set up a simple tracking system this week. A Google Sheet. A notebook. An app. Something. Columns: date, name, source, service needed, status, follow-up date. Update it daily. Review it every morning before your first job.

4. Create a standard follow-up text and save it in your phone. “Hey [Name], this is [Your Name] from [Company]. Sorry I missed your call - I’m on a job. I’ll call you back within [time]. What works best for you?” Save it as a text shortcut. Use it every time you miss a call.

5. Calculate: if you closed even 5 more jobs from last month’s leads, how much revenue is that? Take your average ticket and multiply it by 5. Write that number down. That’s how much better follow-up is worth to you per month. Now multiply by 12. That’s the annual cost of bad follow-up.

Now you know WHY follow-up is where the money lives. Want help setting up a system?

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/crm. CRM for Plumbers: How to Stop Losing Leads You Already Paid For - setup guides, templates, and automation.

Want us to build your lead management system?

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/call



CHAPTER 18

“YOUR PHONE IS RINGING. NOW WHAT?”

CSR TRAINING - THE LEAK BETWEEN MARKETING AND REVENUE

“We spent \$4,000 on Google Ads last month and our receptionist answered the phone like she was doing the caller a favor by picking up.” - Wade, who found the most expensive leak in his business

I know what you’re thinking. “CSR training? That’s not marketing.”

You’re right. Technically, it’s not. But I couldn’t write a book about getting your phone to ring without talking about what happens when it actually rings. Because this is where more plumbing companies lose money than anywhere else - and nobody talks about it.

Wade spent \$4,000 on Google Ads. His campaigns were dialed in. Right keywords, right landing pages, right tracking. His phone was ringing 50 times a week from people who needed a plumber RIGHT NOW.

His CSR - the person answering the phone - was Wade’s cousin. Nice person. Zero training. She answered the phone the same way she’d answer her own cell: “Hello?” Sometimes with a sigh. Sometimes while eating lunch. Sometimes she’d put people on hold for 3 minutes and forget about them.

Wade’s close rate on incoming calls? 28%.

Twenty-eight percent. Meaning 72% of the people who called - people Wade PAID to reach through Google Ads - hung up without booking a job. Not because they didn't need a plumber. Because the phone experience was so bad they called someone else.

Wade was pouring \$4,000 a month into a funnel that had a gaping hole at the bottom. His marketing was working. His phone was working. The person answering the phone was the problem.

When Wade finally invested in CSR training, his close rate went from 28% to 61% in 90 days. Same marketing. Same budget. Same number of calls. But now he was booking more than double the jobs from the same leads.

That one change - training the person who answers the phone - was worth more than every marketing dollar he'd ever spent combined.

What Is a CSR?

CSR stands for Customer Service Representative. In plumbing, it's the person (or people) who answers the phone, books appointments, handles customer questions, and creates that critical first impression.

In some companies, the CSR is a dedicated office person. In others, it's the owner's spouse. In a lot of one-truck operations, it's the plumber himself, answering the phone while under a house with one hand on a wrench and the other holding a phone covered in pipe grease.

Regardless of who answers the phone at your company, **THAT PERSON** is the bridge between your marketing and your revenue. Every dollar you spend on Google Ads, SEO, LSAs, social media, and everything else in this book is wasted if the phone gets answered poorly.

Your CSR is the most important "marketing tool" you have. And most plumbing companies treat the role like an afterthought.

The \$200 Phone Call

Let me do the math so this sticks.

You spend \$3,000/month on marketing. You get 60 calls. That means each phone call cost you \$50 to generate.

If your CSR books 60% of those calls, you get 36 jobs. Your cost per booked job: \$83.

If your CSR books 30% of those calls, you get 18 jobs. Your cost per booked job: \$167.

Same marketing spend. Same number of calls. But the difference between a trained CSR and an untrained one is literally DOUBLE the revenue from the same investment.

Every call your CSR fumbles is a \$50 bill thrown in the trash. If they fumble 20 calls a month, that's \$1,000 in wasted marketing spend. Per month. \$12,000 a year. Gone. Not because marketing didn't work - because nobody trained the person answering the phone.

What Great CSRs Do Differently

A great CSR doesn't just answer the phone. They CONVERT the phone call into a booked appointment. Here's what that looks like:

They answer fast. Within 3 rings. Every ring after the third drops your booking rate. If a call goes to voicemail, you've already lost 60-80% of those callers - they're calling your competitor before your voicemail finishes playing.

They sound like they're happy to help. Not bored. Not rushed. Not annoyed. Genuinely glad the customer called. This sounds basic, but you'd be stunned how many plumbing company phones get answered with the energy of a DMV clerk on a Friday afternoon.

They empathize first, sell second. "Oh no, a burst pipe at 10pm? That

sounds stressful. Let me get someone out there for you as quickly as possible.” That one sentence - acknowledging the customer’s problem before jumping to logistics - changes everything. The customer feels heard. Trust is established. The booking follows naturally.

They ask for the appointment. This is the one most untrained CSRs miss entirely. They answer questions. They give information. They say “let me know if you’d like to schedule.” But they never actually ASK: “I have a tech available tomorrow between 8 and 10am. Can I book that for you?” That direct ask is the difference between a 30% close rate and a 60% close rate.

They overcome objections. “How much does it cost?” is not a reason to lose the call. A trained CSR knows how to handle pricing questions: “It depends on the specific situation, but I can tell you our diagnostic fee is \$XX, which gets applied to the repair if you move forward. Most [service] jobs run between \$XX and \$XX. Can I get a tech out there to give you an exact number?” That’s a lot better than “Uh, I’m not sure. It depends.”

They capture information. Name, address, phone, email, the problem, how they found you. Every call. Every time. This data feeds your CRM (Chapter 17), helps you track marketing performance (Chapter 2), and ensures proper follow-up.

Who Should Train Your CSRs?

You can train your CSR yourself if you understand the principles above. But there are companies that specialize in this, and they’re worth every penny.

PowerSellingPros is one of the best in the home service industry. They train CSRs specifically for trades companies - plumbing, HVAC, electrical. Their program teaches phone skills, empathy, booking techniques, objection handling, and follow-up. Plumbers who’ve used them report close rate increases of 15-30 percentage points.

If you have even one person answering phones at your company, investing in professional CSR training is one of the highest-ROI moves you can make. A \$2,000-\$5,000 training investment that increases your close rate by 15-20% will

pay for itself within weeks - sometimes days.

You wouldn't send a tech out on a job without proper training. Why would you put an untrained person on the phone with every customer who calls?

The Owner-As-CSR Problem

If you're a one-person operation and YOU are answering the phone, this chapter applies to you too. Maybe even more so.

When you answer the phone while you're under a house, distracted, covered in grime, and frustrated with the job you're on - that energy comes through the phone. The customer hears it. They hear the sighing. They hear the background noise. They hear you rushing to get off the call. And they think: "This guy doesn't want my business."

Two options:

Option 1: Train yourself. Apply the same CSR principles. When the phone rings, take a breath. Answer with energy. Be present for 60 seconds. Book the appointment. Then go back to your pipe.

Option 2: Use an AI answering agent. If you physically can't answer calls well while on a job, technology can help. We'll cover this in the next chapter (Chapter 19).

Megan's Transformation

Megan is a CSR at a 3-truck plumbing company. When she started, she had zero training. She answered the phone, took messages, and transferred calls. Her booking rate was about 25%.

The company owner invested in CSR training - a 6-week program that covered phone skills, empathy, objection handling, and booking techniques. Megan went through the program while continuing to work.

After 6 weeks, Megan's booking rate jumped to 58%. Same calls. Same marketing. Same person. Just trained.

But here's the part nobody expected: Megan's average ticket went up too. Because part of CSR training teaches how to communicate value, how to present premium options, and how to set proper expectations before the tech arrives. Customers who booked through trained-Megan were better informed, more trusting, and more open to recommendations.

The company's revenue went up 40% without spending a single additional dollar on marketing. All from training one person to answer the phone better.

Pipe Dream vs. Pipeline

Pipe Dream: "The phone's ringing - the marketing is working."

Pipeline: "The phone's ringing AND every call is being handled by someone trained to convert it into a booked job."

Ryan's Rant

You spent THOUSANDS getting that phone to ring. Google Ads. SEO. LSAs. Reviews. Website. Thousands of dollars and hundreds of hours.

And then someone answers the phone and says "Hello?" like they're surprised anyone called.

Or puts them on hold for 4 minutes. Or can't answer a basic pricing question. Or doesn't ask for the appointment. Or lets the caller say "I'll think about it" and just... accepts that.

That's not a phone problem. That's a training problem. And it's the single most fixable leak in your entire business.

I don't care if your CSR is your spouse, your cousin, a hired employee, or you yourself. TRAIN THEM. Invest in it like you'd invest in a new tool. Because this "tool" touches every single lead that comes through your door. Every one. A \$3,000 CSR training program that bumps your close rate by 20% on a

\$3,000/month ad spend is worth \$7,200/year in additional revenue. From one training. Do the math. Then make the call.

Wrench Turn Action Items

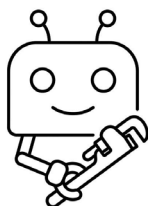
- 1. Listen to your last 5 phone calls.** If you have call tracking (Chapter 2), play back 5 recent calls. Listen to how they were answered. Were they warm? Professional? Did the CSR ask for the appointment? Or did the caller slip away? Be honest about what you hear.
- 2. Calculate your phone-to-booking rate.** Take your total incoming calls last month. Divide by booked appointments. That's your close rate. Below 50%? You have a CSR problem. Below 40%? It's an emergency.
- 3. Write a phone script for your CSR (or yourself).** Greeting. Empathy statement. Qualifying questions. Present availability. Ask for the booking. Handle objections. It doesn't need to be robotic - it needs to be consistent.
- 4. Look into professional CSR training.** Check out PowerSellingPros or similar home service CSR training companies. Get a quote. Compare it to what you're spending on marketing. The ROI math will make the decision obvious.
- 5. If you're a one-person shop answering your own phone - read Chapter 19 next.** AI answering tools can handle calls when you can't, ensuring no lead goes unanswered even when you're under a house.

Now you know WHY CSR training is the highest-ROI investment in plumbing marketing. Want scripts, training resources, and phone handling frameworks?

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/csr-training. CSR Training for Plumbers: Phone Scripts, Booking Frameworks, and Training Provider Recommendations.

Want us to help optimize your call-to-booking conversion?

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/call



CHAPTER 19

“THE TEAM THAT NEVER SLEEPS”

AI TOOLS - SALES AGENTS, CHATBOTS, AND 24/7 COVERAGE

“I missed a call at 2am from a flooded basement. By 2:05am, my AI agent had collected their info, texted me the details, and told the customer I’d call back within 15 minutes. I booked a \$2,200 job before I was fully awake.” - Clay, who hired a robot and it paid for itself on night one

Clay is a one-truck plumber. During the day, he’s on the tools. Crawling under houses, replacing water heaters, snaking drains. He can’t answer the phone when he’s elbow-deep in a sewer line. And he definitely can’t answer it at 2am when he’s asleep.

For years, those missed calls just... disappeared. Voicemail caught some of them. Most people didn’t leave a message. They called the next plumber on Google and moved on. Clay never knew how many calls he was losing.

Then Clay set up an AI sales agent.

Not a fancy, expensive system. A basic AI-powered phone agent through GoHighLevel that answers calls when Clay can’t. The AI greets the caller, asks what plumbing issue they’re dealing with, collects their name, address, phone number, and availability. It sounds conversational - not robotic. The caller doesn’t feel like they’re talking to a machine. They feel like they’re talking to a

friendly, competent dispatcher.

The AI then sends Clay a text and email with all the details: “Incoming lead - John Smith, 123 Oak Street, water heater leaking, available tomorrow morning, phone 555-0123.”

Clay wakes up, reads the text, calls John at 6:30am, and books the job before John has even had his coffee. John is impressed - he called at 2am and by 6:30am someone was calling him back with full knowledge of his problem.

Clay told me: “That AI agent books me 8-10 jobs a month that I would have completely missed. At my average ticket, that’s \$5,000-\$6,000 in revenue from a tool that costs me \$497 a month.”

\$497 in. \$5,000 out. Every month. While Clay sleeps.

AI Is Not the Future. It’s Right Now

I know some of you just read “AI” and your eyes glazed over. Or you thought: “That’s for big companies with tech departments.” Or you pictured some sci-fi robot answering your phone in a creepy monotone voice.

Forget all of that. Here’s the reality in 2026:

AI tools for small businesses are simple, affordable, and shockingly effective. You don’t need to understand how they work. You don’t need a tech degree. You need to sign up, configure a few settings, and let them run. They’re no more complicated than setting up a Google Business Profile - and you already did that (Chapter 4).

There are two AI tools that are immediately relevant for plumbing companies, and both of them can start making you money this week.

AI Sales Agents (Phone Answering)

An AI sales agent is exactly what Clay uses. It’s a virtual phone agent that answers calls when you can’t. Here’s how it works:

1. **A customer calls your number.** You're on a job, in the shower, or asleep.
2. **The AI answers.** It greets the caller naturally, identifies your company, and starts a conversation.
3. **The AI qualifies the lead.** It asks about the plumbing issue, collects contact info, address, availability, and urgency.
4. **The AI notifies you.** You get an instant text/email with all the details - customer name, problem, contact info, when they want service.
5. **You call back.** Armed with all the info, you call the customer back and book the job.

The entire process takes 2-3 minutes for the caller. They feel heard. They feel like they talked to someone who cared. And you didn't miss the lead.

Want to see action? Call (708) 701-9357 to talk to my virtual assistant!

Where to Set One Up

GoHighLevel (GHL) is the most popular platform for this in the home service industry. Their AI agent feature lets you build a phone-answering AI that's customized to your business. You can set the greeting, the questions it asks, the information it collects, and how it notifies you. Monthly cost: \$97-\$297 depending on your plan plus usage for minutes on the phone, messages sent, etc.

Other options: * **Smith.ai** - AI-powered virtual receptionist service designed for small businesses * **Goodcall** - AI phone agent specifically built for local service businesses * **Podium AI** - AI-powered lead conversion tools with phone and text capabilities

Most of these offer free trials. Test one for 30 days. Track how many leads it captures that you would have missed. The math will speak for itself.

Marketing companies typically charge \$297-\$1,497 a month for this service which includes a full setup: All routing, knowledgebase, conversational flow, training you on the platform, etc. Depending on the size of your service team,

service area and services offered this price can vary. Although you ‘can’ set it up yourself, if you have never used Go High Level or a similar tool it can be a very complex task.

Some companies will set it up for you and not charge a monthly fee, but typically they require you to have your own account, use your own card for billing credits and are typically fairly expensive for the setup (I have heard of companies charging \$15,000-\$20,000 for a one time setup fee!).

Is it worth it? Well, yes it is worth it and you will see the money back in the long run, but you will want to weigh your options and compare the DIY vs Monthly vs One-Time Setup and see what makes the most sense for your current budget.

When to Use It

- **After hours.** Set the AI to answer any call that comes in outside your business hours. Plumbing emergencies don’t respect your schedule.
- **When you’re on a job.** Route calls to the AI when you’re unavailable. Better than voicemail. Way better than a missed call.
- **During high-volume periods.** If your CSR (Chapter 18) is on another call, the AI catches the overflow instead of sending it to voicemail.
- **Weekends and holidays.** Be “available” 24/7 without actually being available 24/7.

Website Chatbots (Your 24/7 Digital CSR)

The second AI tool every plumbing company should have is a website chatbot. And before you say “those annoying pop-ups?” - hear me out.

Modern AI chatbots are nothing like the clunky, scripted bots from five years ago. Today’s chatbots are powered by AI knowledge bases. You feed them information about your business - your services, your prices, your service area, your hours, your FAQs - and they learn it. Then they can have intelligent, natural conversations with website visitors 24/7.

Think of it as a virtual CSR sitting on your website around the clock. A visitor lands on your page at 11pm on a Sunday. They have a question. The chatbot greets them, answers their question, and - here's the key - collects their contact info and books the appointment. While you're asleep.

What a Good Plumbing Chatbot Does

Answers common questions instantly. “Do you offer emergency service?” “What areas do you serve?” “How much does a water heater replacement cost?” Your chatbot knows the answers because you taught it.

Qualifies leads. Just like the phone AI, the chatbot asks: What's the issue? Where are you located? When do you need service? By the time you follow up, the lead is pre-qualified.

Books appointments. Connected to your calendar or CRM (Chapter 17), the chatbot can schedule appointments directly. The customer picks a time, the chatbot confirms it, and you get notified. No phone call required.

Handles multiple customers simultaneously. A human CSR can handle one call at a time. A chatbot can handle 50 conversations at once. During a cold snap when everyone's pipes are freezing and your phone is blowing up, the chatbot handles the overflow on your website without breaking a sweat. It doesn't get tired. It doesn't get flustered. It doesn't put anyone on hold.

Learns and improves. The more conversations it has, the better it gets at answering questions and converting visitors. You can review its conversations and tweak its responses over time.

Where to Set One Up

- **Tidio** - AI chatbot with a free tier, easy to install on any website
- **GoHighLevel** - includes chatbot functionality alongside the phone AI
- **Drift** - AI-powered chat for service businesses
- **Intercom** - advanced conversational AI with knowledge base training
- **ChatBot.com** - drag-and-drop chatbot builder with AI capabilities

Most website platforms (WordPress, Wix, Squarespace, custom sites) support chatbot installation with a simple code snippet. Your web developer can set it up in 15 minutes.

The Knowledge Base Is the Secret

The difference between a useless chatbot and a powerful one is the knowledge base. A knowledge base is the information you feed the AI so it knows how to answer questions about YOUR business.

Your knowledge base should include: * Every service you offer and a brief description * Your service area (cities/zip codes) * Your business hours and emergency availability * Common pricing ranges (if you share pricing) * Your phone number and booking link * FAQs - the 20 most common questions customers ask * Your company story and differentiators

The more complete your knowledge base, the smarter your chatbot. Spend an hour building it out. That hour of work powers thousands of conversations over the next year.

These Are Not “Nice to Haves” Anymore

Let me be direct: AI chatbots and phone agents are not futuristic gimmicks. They’re on almost every website you visit now. Banks, airlines, retailers, restaurants - they all use them. Your customers are used to interacting with them. They expect them.

When a customer visits your competitor’s website at 11pm and gets instant answers from a chatbot, then visits YOUR website and sees... nothing. No chat. No way to get help. Just a contact form that might get answered tomorrow. Who do you think they’re calling?

The plumber with 24/7 AI coverage captures leads while the plumber with “business hours only” coverage loses them. Every night. Every weekend. Every holiday.

This isn't about replacing humans. It's about covering the gaps that humans can't cover. Your CSR goes home at 5pm. The AI doesn't. Your tech can't answer the phone under a house. The AI can. You can't talk to 50 people at once during a cold snap. The AI can.

AI handles the overflow. You handle the relationships.

Perry's Weekend Test

Perry is a skeptic. He doesn't trust "tech stuff." He installed a website chatbot on a Friday afternoon as a test - figured he'd try it for a weekend and see.

By Monday morning, the chatbot had fielded 14 conversations. Nine of those provided contact information and described a plumbing need. Perry called all nine on Monday. He booked 6 jobs. Revenue: \$3,800.

From a tool he set up on Friday afternoon. Over a weekend. While he was at his kid's soccer game.

Perry's not a skeptic anymore. Perry's chatbot has been running for 8 months and has generated over \$40,000 in revenue. It costs him \$49/month.

Pipe Dream vs. Pipeline

Pipe Dream: "AI is for big tech companies, not plumbers."

Pipeline: "My AI agent answers calls at 2am and my chatbot books jobs while I sleep. I never miss a lead."

Ryan's Rant

You're a plumber. You work with your hands. You crawl under houses and fix things that are broken. I get it - "AI" sounds like it belongs in a different universe.

But let me ask you this: do you use a phone? Do you use GPS? Do you use Google? Congratulations, you already use AI every single day. These tools are

just more of the same - technology that makes your life easier and your business more profitable.

An AI phone agent costs less than your monthly supply house tab. A website chatbot costs less than a single service call. And both of them generate revenue while you sleep, eat dinner, and spend time with your family.

You don't need to understand HOW they work. You need to understand THAT they work. And then you need to set them up. This week.

The plumber who's available 24/7 - even through AI - will always beat the plumber who's available 8-5 Monday through Friday. Always.

Wrench Turn Action Items

1. Sign up for a free trial of one AI phone agent. GoHighLevel, Smith.ai, or Goodcall. Set it to answer calls when you're unavailable. Run it for 30 days. Track every lead it captures that you would have missed.

2. Install a chatbot on your website this week. Tidio offers a free tier. Install it. Set up basic responses for your top 5 FAQs. Make sure it collects name, phone, and description of the issue. Time investment: about 1 hour.

3. Build your knowledge base. Write down: your services, your service area, your hours, your pricing ranges, your top 20 FAQs, and your booking process. Feed this to your chatbot. The more it knows, the better it performs.

4. Test it yourself. After setup, visit your own website incognito and chat with your bot. Call your own number after hours and talk to your AI agent. See what the customer experience feels like. Fix anything that feels off.

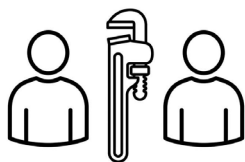
5. Track the ROI after 30 days. How many leads did the AI capture? How many would you have missed? What's the revenue from those leads? Compare that to the monthly cost. If the math works (and it will), keep it running and optimize.

*Now you know WHY AI tools are a game-changer for plumbing companies.
Want setup guides and configuration templates?*

*OnlyPlumbingSites.com/ai-tools. AI Tools for Plumbers: Phone Agents, Chatbots,
and Automation - Setup Guides and Provider Comparisons.*

Want us to set up your AI systems?

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/call



CHAPTER 20

“NOBODY WANTS TO WORK ANYMORE”

MARKETING ISN'T JUST FOR CUSTOMERS - IT'S FOR EMPLOYEES TOO

“I turned down \$180,000 in work last year because I couldn't find anyone to hire.” - Darryl, with a hiring problem disguised as a labor problem

Darryl runs a plumbing company that should be growing. He's got the calls. He's got the work. He's got the reputation. What he doesn't have is people.

Last year, Darryl turned down \$180,000 in work because he couldn't find a tech to hire. He posted on Indeed three times. Got 5 applicants total. Interviewed 2. Hired 1. That one quit after 3 weeks because he got a better offer from a competitor down the street.

Darryl says what every trade business owner says: “Nobody wants to work anymore.”

And I get it. The labor shortage in plumbing is real. There are more open positions than qualified candidates. Trade schools aren't graduating enough plumbers. The average age of a plumber is climbing. It's a genuine challenge. But here's what Darryl doesn't realize: the best plumbing companies don't struggle to hire. They have waiting lists. Techs WANT to work there. And the difference isn't luck - it's marketing.

Not customer marketing. Employee marketing.

Darryl's competitor - the one who poached his tech - has an Instagram page full of team content. Photos of the crew after a big job. A "Tech Spotlight" series featuring each employee. Videos of their annual BBQ. A "Why I Work Here" reel where techs talk about what they love about the company. Their website has a "Careers" page with benefits listed, culture photos, and a simple application form.

When a plumber in Darryl's city is thinking about switching jobs, they Google both companies. Darryl's company has a basic website, no social media, and an Indeed posting that says "Plumber wanted. Competitive pay. Great environment." With zero proof of any of it.

His competitor's company looks like a place people actually want to work. Because they've marketed it that way.

Darryl doesn't have a labor problem. He has a hiring **MARKETING** problem.

Your Online Presence Is Your Recruiting Presence

Here's something most plumbing company owners miss: **potential employees evaluate you the same way potential customers do.** They Google you. They check your reviews. They look at your website. They scroll your social media.

A tech considering your company will: - Google your company name and look at what comes up - Read your Google reviews (yes, employees read customer reviews) - Check your website for a careers page - Look at your social media to get a feel for the culture - Ask other plumbers what they've heard about you.

If your Google listing is half-finished, your website looks like it's from 2015, you have no social media presence, and your reviews are sparse - that tech is thinking: "This company isn't growing. This company isn't invested. I'll go somewhere that looks like they have their act together."

Everything you've done in this book to improve your customer marketing - your website, your reviews, your social media, your brand - also improves your ability to attract employees. It's the same work, serving double duty.

Recruiting Marketing Tactics

1. “Careers” Page on Your Website

This is the bare minimum. A dedicated page on your website that says: “We’re hiring. Here’s why you should work here. Here’s how to apply.”

Include: - What positions are open - Pay range (yes, include it - transparency wins) - Benefits (health insurance, PTO, retirement, truck, tools, training) - Culture description (what’s it like to work here?) - Real photos of your team - A simple application form or a way to contact you.

Most plumbing websites don’t have a careers page. Adding one immediately puts you ahead of 80% of your competitors in the hiring game.

2. Team Content on Social Media

Show your team. Show your culture. Show WHY your company is a great place to work.

- Team photos after a big job
- Employee spotlights (“Meet Mike - 8 years with us, specializes in gas lines”)
- Work anniversary celebrations
- New truck reveals (techs love new trucks)
- Training days and certifications
- Company events (BBQs, holiday parties, team outings)

This content does double duty: customers see a professional, organized company they want to hire. Potential employees see a company they want to join.

3. Employee Testimonials

Ask your best employees: “Why do you work here? What do you like about it?” Film their answers. Post them to your social media and careers page.

These are more powerful than any job posting. A real person, in their own words, explaining why they choose to work at your company every day. That's social proof for recruiting - the same way customer testimonials are social proof for sales.

4. Competitive Pay AND Transparency

“Competitive pay” on a job listing means nothing. Every company says it. It's the “quality work” of job postings.

Be specific. “\$25-\$35/hour based on experience. Health insurance after 90 days. Paid holidays. Company truck after 6 months.” Specific beats vague every time. Every Region of the US is different. Chicago plumbing wages differ greatly from major cities in Florida for example.

The companies that struggle to hire are usually the ones being cagey about compensation. The companies that have waiting lists? They're upfront about what they pay and what they offer. Because they know that transparency attracts confident, quality candidates.

5. Community Reputation

Good companies attract good people. When your company has 300 Google reviews, a professional website, wrapped trucks, and a visible brand - the word gets out. Techs talk. They know which companies are growing, which ones are stagnant, and which ones are a mess.

Everything you build for your customer marketing reinforces your employer brand. A strong customer brand makes you a desirable employer. A weak customer brand makes techs think twice.

Dominic's \$85,000 Lesson

Dominic lost his best technician to a competitor last year. The tech - a 6-year veteran who billed \$350K annually - left for a company he found on Instagram. Not through a job posting. Through Instagram.

The tech saw the competitor's Instagram content: team events, new equipment, a culture that looked positive and modern. He reached out. They offered him comparable pay plus a signing bonus. He left.

Dominic didn't just lose an employee. He lost \$350,000 in annual billing capacity. His other techs had to absorb the workload. Customer wait times increased. Reviews started mentioning longer scheduling. It took Dominic 4 months to find a replacement - a less experienced tech who needed training.

The total cost of losing that one employee: roughly \$85,000 in lost revenue, hiring costs, training time, and reduced productivity during the transition.

All because a competitor had better Instagram content.

Social media isn't just for getting customer calls. It's for retaining and attracting the people who make those calls possible.

Russell's Secret Weapon

Russell runs a successful plumbing company. He's on the tools most days. He doesn't have time for marketing, hiring, or operations management. He's too busy plumbing.

Russell's wife, Maria, handles everything else. She's the office manager, the marketing coordinator, the HR department, and the culture builder. She runs the social media. She manages the reviews. She handles hiring and onboarding. She plans team events. She answers the phone with a warmth that customers rave about in reviews.

Maria isn't a plumber. She's never touched a pipe. But she's the reason Russell's company runs smoothly, attracts great employees, and has a culture that techs don't want to leave.

Not every plumbing company has a Maria. But every plumbing company needs someone thinking about culture, hiring, and employee experience. Whether it's a spouse, an office manager, or you - someone needs to own it.

If you're a one-person show, that someone is you. Dedicate 30 minutes a week to employee marketing: post one piece of team content, update your careers page, or reach out to a potential hire. It's not a lot of time. But it compounds, just like everything else in this book.

Pipe Dream vs. Pipeline

Pipe Dream: "Nobody wants to work anymore - it's just how it is."

Pipeline: "I market my company to potential employees the same way I market to customers."

Ryan's Rant

You expect quality employees to show up when your Indeed ad says "plumber wanted, competitive pay, great environment" with absolutely zero proof of any of it? That's the hiring equivalent of your nephew website. A vague claim with nothing to back it up.

SHOW them the culture. SHOW them the pay. SHOW them why your shop is different from every other plumbing company with a "Help Wanted" sign. Would you hire a plumber based on an ad that said "we do good work, trust us"? No. You'd want to see reviews, photos, a real website. Your potential employees want the same thing.

If you can't show a prospective tech why your company is better than the one down the street - maybe that's the real problem. Not the labor market. Not "kids these days." Your inability to market yourself as an employer.

Fix that and watch the applications roll in.

Wrench Turn Action Items

1. Google your company name + "careers" or "jobs." What shows up? Anything? Nothing? If there's no careers presence when someone searches for jobs at your company, you're invisible to potential employees - the same way you're invisible to potential customers without SEO.

2. Add a “Careers” or “Join Our Team” page to your website this week. It doesn’t need to be elaborate. Company description. Open positions. Pay range. Benefits. A few team photos. Application form or contact info. That’s it. Get it live.

3. Post one piece of team content on social media. A team photo. A completed job celebration. A new truck. A work anniversary. Anything that shows your company has people and culture. One post. This week.

4. Ask your best employee: “Why do you work here?” Film their answer on your phone. 30-60 seconds. Post it to social media and your careers page. Real employee testimonials are the most powerful recruiting tool you have.

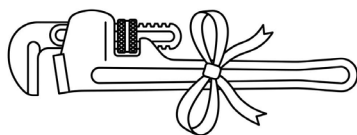
5. Be honest: would YOU apply to work at your company based on what you see online? Google yourself. Look at your website, your social media, your reviews, your Indeed posting. If you were a qualified tech looking for a new job, would you be excited to apply? Or would you keep scrolling? Your honest answer tells you everything you need to know.

Now you know WHY marketing for employees matters. Want help building your employer brand?

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/recruiting. How to Attract and Keep Great Plumbing Techs - careers page templates, social media strategies, and retention tips.

Want us to help build your recruiting presence?

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/call



CHAPTER 21

“THEY’LL NEVER FORGET YOU”

CUSTOMER RETENTION - THE MARKETING NOBODY TALKS ABOUT

“It costs 5x more to get a new customer than to keep one you already have. So why are you spending all your money chasing strangers?” - Walt, who figured out the cheat code

Walt runs a 2-truck plumbing company. Nothing fancy. No billboards. No massive ad budget. But Walt does something that 95% of plumbers don’t do, and it’s the reason his phone never stops ringing.

Walt gives gifts.

Not expensive gifts. Not elaborate gifts. After every job - every single one - Walt goes back to his truck and grabs a small thank-you basket. A box of chocolates, a \$5 gift card to a local coffee shop, and a handwritten note that says: “Thanks for trusting us with your home. We appreciate you. - Walt’s Plumbing.”

Total cost per basket: about \$12.

The first time Walt did this, the customer literally teared up. “Nobody has ever done this,” she said. “No plumber, no electrician, no contractor - nobody has ever given me a gift after doing work on my house.”

She left a 5-star review that night. She referred Walt to three neighbors that month. One of those neighbors referred two more people. From a \$12 basket, Walt generated over \$4,000 in new revenue.

Walt told me: “Every other plumber is trying to figure out how to get new customers. I figured out how to keep the ones I already have. Turns out, that’s the same thing.”

He’s right. And this might be the most underrated chapter in this entire book.

The Math That Changes Everything

Think about what it costs to get a new customer. Between Google Ads, SEO, your website, your time - you’re spending \$100-\$300 to acquire a single new customer (Chapter 2). Every new customer is expensive.

Now think about what it costs to keep an existing customer: almost nothing. A follow-up text. A thank-you gift. A sticker on the water heater. A check-in call six weeks later. We’re talking \$10-\$20 per customer in time and materials.

A new customer costs \$150+. Keeping an existing customer costs \$15. That’s a 10:1 ratio. And the kept customer already trusts you, already knows your work, and is 5x more likely to hire you again than a stranger is to hire you the first time.

Every dollar you spend on retention is worth 10 dollars you’d spend on acquisition. And yet, most plumbers spend 100% of their marketing budget chasing new customers and 0% keeping the ones they already won.

That’s like filling a bathtub with the drain open. You keep pouring water in, but it keeps leaking out, and you wonder why the tub never fills up.

Close the drain. Keep your customers. Watch what happens.

The Thank-You Basket

Walt's approach is simple and it works. But you can adapt it to your style and budget. The point isn't the specific gift - it's the gesture. It's doing something that no other plumber does. Something unexpected. Something that makes the customer think: "Wow. This company is different."

Ideas that work:

- **A small gift basket** - chocolates, a gift card, a branded item with your logo. \$10-\$15.
- **A branded action figure or toy** - sounds silly, but a little plumber figurine with your company logo on it? Kids love it. Parents remember it. It sits on a shelf for years.
- **A handwritten thank-you note** - this alone separates you from 99% of service companies. Not a printed card. Handwritten. "Thanks, Mike. That water heater was a beast but we got it done. Call us anytime."
- **A follow-up gift card** - a \$5 Starbucks card with a note: "Coffee's on us. Thanks for choosing [Company]."

The cost is minimal. The impact is massive. These customers will remember you for years. They'll tell their friends. They'll post about it on social media. They'll leave reviews without you even asking (although you should still ask - Chapter 5).

And here's the timing play: hand them the gift RIGHT after the job is done, right after they've paid and they're feeling good about the experience. Then, while they're holding your gift and feeling grateful, that's when you say: "Hey, if you get a chance, a Google review would mean the world to us." The conversion rate on that ask, in that moment, with a gift in their hand? Through the roof.

The Sticker Strategy

This one costs almost nothing and works for months - sometimes years - after you leave.

Get professional stickers printed. Not cheap, ugly stickers. Clean, well-designed stickers with:

- Your company name and logo
- Your phone number
- A QR code that links to your booking page or phone
- 3-4 maintenance tips specific to that piece of equipment
- A “When to call us” section

Make different versions for different equipment:

Water heater sticker: “Your water heater was serviced by [Company] on [Date]. Maintenance tips: Flush the tank annually. Check the anode rod every 2-3 years. If you notice rusty water, strange noises, or inconsistent temperatures - call us at [number]. Average water heater lifespan: 8-12 years.”

Garbage disposal sticker: “Serviced by [Company]. Tips: Run cold water when using. Avoid grease, bones, and fibrous foods. If it hums but doesn’t spin, press the reset button on the bottom. Still stuck? Call us at [number].”

Put the sticker ON the equipment you just serviced. On the water heater. On the garbage disposal housing. On the utility panel near the main shutoff.

Think about it like an oil change sticker. You know the little sticker they put in the corner of your windshield? The one that says “Next oil change: 45,000 miles or June 2026”? You see it every time you get in your car. And when that date comes around, most people actually go get their oil changed - not because they remembered on their own, but because the sticker reminded them. It works. It’s been working for decades. Your water heater sticker does the exact same thing.

And here’s where it gets even smarter: **add a promotion to the sticker.** Something like: “*Mention this sticker and get a water heater flush + maintenance for only \$99.*” Now you’ve turned a passive reminder into an active call to action. The customer sees the sticker, remembers you, AND has a financial incentive to call.

Why a water heater flush? Because flushing a water heater annually can add 3-5 years to its lifespan. A standard water heater replacement runs \$1,500-\$2,500. A \$99 annual flush that extends the life of the unit by several years is one of the best deals in home maintenance - and most homeowners don't even know it's a thing until you tell them. You're not upselling. You're saving them from a 4-figure replacement down the road. That's value. And when they DO eventually need a replacement? They're calling the company on the sticker. Not Google.

Here's why this is genius:

It provides genuine value. You're giving the customer maintenance tips that help them take care of their equipment. You're essentially saying: "I don't want your money unless you actually need my help." That might seem counterintuitive - why would you give them tips that might prevent a service call? Because it positions you as a company that CARES. A company that puts the customer first. And when something eventually DOES break - and it will - you're the plumber they trust. Not the cheapest one on Google. The one who gave them honest advice and left helpful information on their equipment.

It keeps your name in front of them. Every time they walk past their water heater, they see your sticker. Every time they use their garbage disposal, your name is right there. When something eventually breaks, your number is literally on the thing that's broken. They don't need to Google "plumber near me." They just read the sticker.

It generates calls passively. A plumber named Garrett told me he gets 3-5 calls per month from stickers he placed on water heaters over the last two years. Calls from people who say: "I saw your sticker on my water heater and it says to call if I notice [symptom]." Three to five calls a month. From stickers. That cost him \$0.15 each.

Where to put them (and where NOT to). Equipment in utility areas, garages, and under sinks - places where they're helpful, not an eyesore. Don't put stickers on faucets, countertops, or anything in the living space. That's tacky and disrespectful. Put them where they're useful: on the equipment itself, where the customer will see them when they need the information. Make them look professional and clean - not like a bumper sticker from a county fair.

The 6-Week Follow-Up

Here's a habit that takes 30 seconds and separates you from every other plumber in your city.

Six weeks after a job, send a text:

"Hey John, it's [Your Name] from [Company]. It's been about 6 weeks since we installed your water heater - just checking in to see if everything is still working great! Hope you're having a great week."

That's it. Thirty seconds. One text.

Here's what that text does:

It shows you care. No other plumber is checking in 6 weeks later. Nobody. The customer is shocked that you remembered them. That shock turns into loyalty.

It catches problems early. If something IS wrong, they'll tell you. Now you can fix it before it becomes a complaint or a bad review. You turned a potential negative into a positive.

It keeps you top of mind. That customer just got reminded that you exist. If their neighbor mentions a plumbing problem next week, guess whose name comes up?

It opens the door for referrals. You can even add: "If anyone you know needs plumbing help, we'd love the referral!" Most customers are happy to help a company that just checked in on them unprompted.

You can automate this with a CRM (Chapter 17) or do it manually. Either way, build it into your process. Every job gets a 6-week follow-up. No exceptions.

The Lifetime Customer Mindset

Here's the shift I need you to make: **stop thinking about customers as transactions. Start thinking about them as relationships.**

A transaction mindset says: "I fixed their water heater. That'll be \$800. Next."

A relationship mindset says: "I fixed their water heater. Now they're MY customer. How do I make sure they never call anyone else? How do I make sure they tell everyone they know about me? How do I turn this \$800 job into \$5,000 in lifetime value?"

The gift basket, the stickers, the follow-up text, the genuine care - these aren't "nice to haves." They're the difference between a customer who forgets you by next Tuesday and a customer who becomes an unpaid salesperson for your company for the next 10 years.

Think about it: when your existing customers rave about you to their neighbors, those neighbors call you already trusting you. No ad spend. No SEO. No Google Ads. Just a warm referral from someone who genuinely loves your company - because you treated them like a human being, not a transaction.

This is how businesses explode. Not through more ads. Through more care. The ads get them in the door. The care keeps them for life.

Holden's NFL-Level Service

Holden runs a plumbing company in a market with 50+ competitors. Same services. Similar prices. Similar skills. By every measurable metric, Holden should be just another plumber in a crowded field.

But Holden's customers describe hiring his company like they're talking about a 5-star restaurant. "They showed up early." "They explained everything." "They cleaned up better than when they arrived." "They gave us a gift basket." "They followed up a month later to check on us." "I've never experienced anything like it."

Holden treats every customer interaction like his team is playing in the NFL. Professional. Polished. Memorable. His competitors? They're playing T-ball in comparison.

Holden's Google reviews don't just say "good plumber." They say "BEST experience I've ever had with ANY service company." That's not an accident. That's by design. And it's the reason Holden charges 15-20% more than his competitors and still gets more calls.

When you elevate the customer experience to a level nobody else in your market is delivering, price becomes irrelevant. People don't choose the cheapest plumber. They choose the one they trust most. And trust is built through the details - the basket, the sticker, the text, the care.

Don't just do good work. Treat them like a valued human being. It all works out in your favor. The word-of-mouth leads from Chapter 1? This is how you CREATE them - on purpose, by design, every single time.

Pipe Dream vs. Pipeline

Pipe Dream: "I did good work. They'll call me again if they need me."

Pipeline: "I did good work AND I made sure they'll never forget me. They're my customer for life now."

Ryan's Rant

You spent \$150 in marketing to get that customer. You drove to their house. You spent an hour diagnosing and fixing the problem. You charged them fairly. You did great work. And then you... left. You packed up your tools, collected payment, got in your truck, and drove to the next job. You didn't leave a gift. You didn't leave a sticker. You didn't send a follow-up text. You just... disappeared.

And now you're going to spend another \$150 to get the NEXT customer. And the next one. And the next one. An endless cycle of paying to acquire strangers while ignoring the people who already trust you.

A \$12 gift basket. A \$0.15 sticker. A 30-second text message. That's all it takes to turn a one-time customer into a lifetime fan who sends you referrals on autopilot. You're already doing the hard part - the plumbing. The easy part is making them remember you. And you're skipping it.

Stop chasing. Start keeping. The plumber who keeps every customer will always beat the plumber who's constantly replacing the ones who forgot about him.

Wrench Turn Action Items

1. Buy 20 small gift items this week. Chocolates, gift cards, branded notepads - anything small and thoughtful. Put them in a box in your truck. Hand one to every customer after every job this week. Watch their reaction. That reaction is your answer to whether this works.

2. Design and order equipment stickers. Get a water heater version and a garbage disposal version to start. Include your company name, phone number, QR code, and 3-4 maintenance tips. Put them on every piece of equipment you service from now on. Cost: about \$50 for 500 stickers. ROI: years of passive callbacks.

3. Send a follow-up text to your last 10 customers right now. "Hey [Name], it's [Your Name] from [Company]. Just checking in - is everything still working great? Hope you're doing well!" Send it. Right now. See what comes back.

4. Build the 6-week follow-up into your process permanently. Whether you automate it with a CRM (Chapter 17) or set manual reminders on your phone - every customer gets a check-in at 6 weeks. No exceptions. Make it a habit.

5. Calculate: if every customer you served last year hired you ONE more time, how much revenue is that? Take your total customers from last year. Multiply by your average ticket. That number - that's the revenue sitting in your existing customer base, waiting to be unlocked by a \$12 basket and a 30-second text.

Now you know WHY customer retention is the most underrated marketing strategy in plumbing. Want templates, sticker designs, and automation setups?

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/retention. Customer Retention for Plumbers: Gift Ideas, Sticker Templates, Follow-Up Scripts, and Automation.

Want us to help build your retention system?

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/call

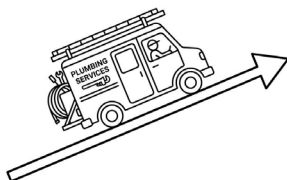
PART VII

THE PAYOFF

*“You’ve read the diagnosis. Now here’s the proof it works
- and the plan to make it work for you.”*

-Ryan Pietrzak





CHAPTER 22

“THE PLUMBER WHO BUILT A MARKETING MACHINE”

THE TRANSFORMATION

“*Every plumber is one or two decisions away from this.*” - Stuart, whose son doubled his revenue

Meet Jake.

Jake was every chapter in this book.

- He relied on word of mouth (Chapter 1).
- He didn't know his numbers (Chapter 2).
- His nephew built his website (Chapter 3).
- He didn't have a Google Business Profile - or if he did, someone set it up years ago and he'd never touched it (Chapter 4).
- He had 12 Google reviews after 15 years in business (Chapter 5).
- He had no idea what SEO was (Chapter 6).
- His website had three pages (Chapter 7).
- He'd never written a blog post or filmed a video (Chapters 8, 16).
- He tried Google Ads for a week with \$5/day and declared it a scam (Chapter 10).

- He was paying Angi \$1,500/month and couldn't tell you if it was working (Chapter 12).
- His last Facebook post was from 2020 (Chapter 13).
- His "brand" was a logo his buddy designed in 2011 (Chapter 15).
- He missed about 30% of incoming calls and followed up on exactly none of his estimates (Chapter 17).
- His receptionist had zero phone training (Chapter 18).
- He had no AI tools or chatbot on his website (Chapter 19).
- He'd turned down work three times last year because he couldn't find anyone to hire (Chapter 20).
- And he'd never once followed up with a past customer or left behind anything memorable (Chapter 21).

Jake's revenue: stuck at \$280,000 for five years. Enough to survive. Enough to pay the bills most months. Enough to keep the one truck running and the one helper employed. But not enough to grow. Not enough to save. Not enough to build something his family could rely on if he got hurt, got sick, or just got tired.

Jake was 44 years old. He'd been plumbing since he was 22. And for the first time in his career, he was starting to wonder if this was all there was.

Then Jake decided to change.

Not because he read a book (although I'd like to think this one would help). Because he got scared. A buddy of his - same age, same years in the trade, same quality of work - had a heart attack. Spent three weeks in the hospital. His plumbing company nearly collapsed because there was no system, no pipeline, no machine running without him. When his buddy came back, half his customers had moved on.

Jake looked at his own business and realized: he was one bad month, one injury, one illness away from the same fate. His business was HIM. Without Jake on the tools, there was no business.

So Jake made a decision. The most important decision of his career.

He decided to build a marketing machine.

Month 1-2: The Foundation

Jake started where this book starts: the basics.

He got a real website built. Not a nephew special. A professional plumbing website with service pages for every service he offered, city pages for his three main service areas, click-to-call buttons, real job photos, and a design that loaded in under 2 seconds on mobile. Cost: \$3,500. The most he'd ever spent on anything marketing-related. It felt like a lot. It was the best investment he'd ever make.

He claimed and completed his Google Business Profile. Turns out someone HAD created one years ago - with the wrong phone number. He fixed it. Added all his services. Uploaded 20 photos from recent jobs. Wrote a complete business description. Set his service area properly. It took about 45 minutes.

He started asking every customer for a Google review. Using the system from Chapter 5. Ask in person. Send the text with the direct link within an hour. Follow up once at 24 hours. He felt awkward the first few times. By the end of week two, it was automatic.

He set up call tracking. CallRail, basic plan, \$45/month. Now he could see where every call came from - Google, his website, his Angi listing, everything.

Results after Month 2: - 25 new Google reviews (from 12 total to 37) - Website live and indexed by Google - GBP fully optimized and starting to show in local results - Call tracking revealing that 60% of his leads were coming from Angi (which explained why he felt dependent on it)

Month 3-4: Building Momentum

Jake launched Google Ads. \$1,500/month. Targeted “emergency plumber [city],” “water heater repair [city],” and “drain cleaning [city].” Dedicated landing pages for each service. Call tracking on every campaign. His marketing person (yes, he hired one - a freelancer at \$800/month) managed the campaigns and optimized weekly.

He hit 50 new reviews. His review system was working. Five per week, consistently. His Google rating held steady at 4.8 stars. He was now at 62 reviews - still behind his biggest competitor's 300+, but growing fast.

He started posting job photos on Facebook. Three times a week. Nothing fancy. A before/after photo with a caption: "Replaced a corroded water heater in [City] today. If yours is over 10 years old, it might be time for an inspection." Each post took 3 minutes.

He reduced his Angi spend from \$1,500 to \$1,000/month. His Google Ads were already generating leads at a lower cost per customer than Angi. He didn't want to cut Angi completely yet - but he started shifting the balance.

Results after Month 4: - Google Ads generating 25 leads/month at \$60/lead - Close rate on Google Ads leads: 65% (vs. 20% on Angi shared leads) - Revenue up 15% from the same period last year - 62 Google reviews and climbing - Facebook page going from ghost town to 3 posts/week

Month 5-6: The Compound Effect Begins

Jake invested in SEO. He hired a legitimate SEO company (vetted using Neil's three questions from Chapter 6) at \$1,500/month. They started building service pages, optimizing existing content, building citations, and adding schema markup to his site.

He added service area pages. His three main service cities each got their own pages. Within 8 weeks, he started appearing in Google's Map Pack for two of the three cities.

He set up a simple CRM. GoHighLevel, \$97/month. Every lead got logged. Every missed call got a follow-up text within 5 minutes (automated). Every estimate got a 24-hour and 72-hour follow-up. His close rate started climbing.

He cut Angi to \$500/month. His owned channels - Google Ads, organic search, GBP, reviews - were now generating more leads than Angi, at a lower cost per customer. He kept Angi as a supplement but was no longer dependent on it.

Results after Month 6: - Reviews: 120+ (compound effect kicking in) - Organic traffic to website up 80% - Google Ads generating 35 leads/month - Close rate up from 55% to 68% (CRM follow-up doing its work) - Revenue up 35% year over year - First month Jake didn't stress about payroll in years

Month 7-8: Scaling Up

Reviews hit 150. At this point, Jake's review count was catching up to his biggest competitor. The gap that used to be 12 vs. 300 was now 150 vs. 320. Still behind, but the trajectory was clear. And his 4.8-star rating was actually higher than his competitor's 4.6.

Google Ads were generating 40+ calls a week. Jake had a problem he'd never had before: too much work. He was turning down jobs because he couldn't get to them fast enough.

Jake hired his first additional tech. Not because he was drowning (okay, a little because he was drowning). Because for the first time, the math worked. He had enough steady, predictable lead flow to justify the payroll. The new hire was \$55,000/year. The additional revenue capacity: \$180,000+/year. The math was obvious.

He launched Google Local Service Ads. On top of his regular Google Ads. Now he was showing up in two spots on Google search results - LSAs at the top and regular ads below. His competitors were getting pushed further down the page.

Results after Month 8: - 150+ reviews, 4.8 stars - Two techs plus Jake on the tools - Revenue run rate: \$380,000 (up from \$280,000 baseline) - Angi cancelled completely - all leads now from owned channels - Marketing spend: \$4,000/month total. Revenue from marketing: \$18,000+/month.

Month 9-12: The Machine Runs

This is where the compound effect became undeniable.

SEO started delivering. Jake's website was now ranking on page 1 for 15 keywords in his primary city. Organic traffic was generating 20+ calls per month - FOR FREE. Every organic lead was pure profit (no ad spend required).

He launched a maintenance plan. Based on Wayne's model (Interview #45) - a \$15/month plan that includes an annual inspection and priority scheduling. He signed up 40 customers in the first quarter. That's \$7,200/year in recurring revenue, plus the upsell potential on every inspection visit.

His brand became recognizable. Wrapped trucks (two now). Consistent uniforms. A professional website. Active social media. 200+ reviews. When people in his city saw his trucks or heard his name, they knew who he was. He wasn't just "a plumber" anymore. He was "THE plumber" in his neighborhoods.

He stopped being on the tools full-time. For the first time in 22 years, Jake spent three days a week managing the business instead of doing the work. He could focus on growth, customer relationships, and strategy instead of being under a house every day.

Results after Month 12: - **Revenue: \$520,000** (up from \$280,000 - an 86% increase) - **Google reviews: 250+** at 4.8 stars - **Website traffic: up 300%** from baseline - Calls from marketing: 60+/week from Google Ads, LSAs, organic, and GBP - **Team: Jake + 2 techs + a part-time office person** - **Angi spend: \$0** (cancelled at month 8, never missed) - **Total marketing investment over 12 months: approximately \$55,000** - **Additional revenue over 12 months: approximately \$240,000** - **ROI: roughly 4.4:1** - every dollar invested returned \$4.40.

The Real Potential Revealed

Jake is only one example. Here are some more realities that you can see if you implement the steps laid out in this book:

Terrence: \$220,000~\$520,000 in 3 years. 137% growth. Started with nothing - no website, no reviews, no ads. Built everything from scratch, methodically, one piece at a time. “The hardest part was starting. Once I started, the hardest part was being patient.”

Stuart: \$600,000~\$1.1 million in 3 years. His son - fresh out of college - came into the business and implemented everything: website, reviews, Google Ads, social media, CRM. Stuart’s total marketing investment: about \$95,000 over 3 years. Additional revenue: \$500,000. A 5:1 ROI. Stuart told me: “The decision was trusting someone to change things I was too stubborn to change myself. That was the hardest thing I’ve ever done. And the best.”

Sarah: \$180,000~\$1.2 million in 4 years. 567% growth. Sarah is one of the few women running a plumbing company in her area, and she turned it into a competitive advantage. She branded herself differently, marketed aggressively, and built systems that let her scale. “Marketing isn’t an expense. It’s the thing that pays for everything else.”

Herschel: \$0~\$420,000 in 3 years. Herschel started from absolute zero - no existing business, no customers, no reputation. But he did everything right from day one: professional website, review system from job one, Google Ads from month one, content from week one. He skipped the 15-year learning curve because he started with the playbook. “Being a great plumber and being a successful plumber are two different things. I decided to be both.”

There Is No Magic Bullet. There Is a Machine.

I want to be very clear about something: **there is no single trick that will do this.**

It wasn’t just the website. It wasn’t just the reviews. It wasn’t just Google Ads. It wasn’t just SEO. It wasn’t just social media. It wasn’t just the CRM.

It was the machine. Every piece amplifies every other piece:

- A great website + SEO = organic traffic that grows over time
- Reviews + Google Ads = higher click-through rates and lower cost per click
- Social media + content = brand trust that converts strangers into customers
- CRM + follow-up = higher close rates on every lead from every channel
- All of them combined = a marketing machine that runs while you're on a job, while you're eating dinner, while you're sleeping

No single piece does this alone. But together? They're unstoppable.

And here's the thing nobody tells you: **this transformation is available to any plumber willing to invest time, money, and consistency.** It's not reserved for companies with big budgets. Jake started at \$280K. Herschel started at \$0. The machine works at any scale - you just start where you are and build.

It doesn't happen overnight. Jake's transformation took 12 months. Stuart's took 3 years. Patience matters. Consistency matters more. The plumber who invests \$1,000/month for 12 months will always beat the plumber who spends \$12,000 in one month and quits.

Pipe Dream vs. Pipeline

Pipe Dream: "There's gotta be one simple trick to get more customers."

Pipeline: "I built a system where every piece supports the others. My marketing works even when I'm on a job."

Ryan's Rant

Every plumber is one or two decisions away from this. Not one or two YEARS. One or two DECISIONS.

The decision to get a real website. The decision to ask for reviews. The decision to invest in showing up on Google. The decision to stop being afraid of marketing and start treating it like the business tool it is.

Stuart told me something I'll never forget: "The decision was trusting someone to change things I was too stubborn to change myself." Twenty-eight years on the tools. A business that had plateaued. And one decision - to let his son modernize the marketing - changed everything. "I'm not on the tools anymore. First time in 28 years. My wife says I'm a different person."

That's it. That's the whole secret. There IS no secret. It's making the decision. It's starting. It's being consistent. And it's not quitting when month 2 doesn't look like month 12.

Which decision are you going to make today?

Wrench Turn Action Items

1. Rate your marketing machine right now. Give yourself a score out of 10 for each: Website. Reviews (count them). SEO (page 1 for anything?). Google Ads (running?). Social media (active?). CRM (exists?). Write the scores down. The lowest number is where you start.

2. Identify your weakest link. Look at your scores. Which one made you cringe the most? That's your biggest opportunity. Not the thing that's already working - the thing that's broken. Fix the weakest link first and the whole machine gets stronger.

3. Set a 90-day goal. What does your marketing look like 90 days from now? Be specific. "50 more Google reviews." "Website redesigned and live." "Google Ads running at \$1,500/month." "Posting on Facebook 3x/week." Write it down. Put a date on it.

4. Commit to one action from a previous chapter's Wrench Turn this week. Go back through the chapters. Pick one action item you haven't done yet. The one that would make the biggest difference. Do it this week. Not next week. This week.

5. Turn the page to Chapter 23 and build your plan. You've read the stories. You've seen the proof. Now it's time to build YOUR plan. Chapter 23 is your 90-day playbook. Let's go.

Want to see more transformation stories? Real plumbers, real numbers, real results.

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/case-studies. Real Plumber Transformations: Before and After Marketing

Ready to start your own transformation?

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/call



CHAPTER 23

“YOUR 90-DAY ACTION PLAN”

THE PLAYBOOK

“Stop watching. Start doing. The plumber who watches 500 videos and does nothing loses to the plumber who reads one chapter and takes action.” - Trent’s lesson, learned the hard way

You’ve read the stories. You’ve cringed at the mistakes. You’ve probably recognized yourself in at least one chapter - if not five or six. Maybe you saw a little Dave in yourself (Chapter 1). Maybe you winced at Tony’s nephew website because yours looks suspiciously similar (Chapter 3). Maybe you realized you’re Curtis with 7 reviews after 15 years (Chapter 5). Maybe you’re Jerome who can’t answer any of the five numbers (Chapter 2).

Good. That recognition is the first step. But recognition without action is just awareness - and awareness doesn’t pay the bills.

Now it’s time to stop reading and start doing.

This is your 90-day playbook. No fluff. No theory. Just steps. Week by week. In order. Designed so that by Day 90, you have a functioning marketing machine - not a perfect one, but a real one that’s generating leads, building your brand, and growing your business.

Before You Start: The “Pick One” Principle

If the full 90-day plan feels overwhelming, here’s the cheat code:

Pick ONE thing from this book. The one that made you cringe the most. Do it this week. Then pick another one next week.

Progress beats perfection. Always.

The plumber who does one thing imperfectly this week is miles ahead of the plumber who plans to do everything perfectly “when things slow down.” Things never slow down. Jorge - a plumber I talked to - told me he’d start marketing “when things slow down.” That was 11 years ago. Things never slowed down enough. And they never sped up either.

Don’t be Jorge. Start today. Even if it’s just one thing.

That said, if you’re ready for the full plan, here it is.

Week 1-2: Foundation

This is where you build the base. Nothing fancy. Just the fundamentals that everything else sits on.

- **Audit your current website.** Pull it up on your phone. Can you call with one tap? Does it load in under 3 seconds? Does it have service pages? Run it through pagespeed.web.dev and screenshot the score. (Use the scorecard at OnlyPlumbingSites.com/website-checklist)
- **Claim and fully complete your Google Business Profile.** Go to business.google.com. Claim your listing if you haven’t. Fill out EVERY section: business name, address, phone, hours, services (list each one individually), description, service area. Upload at least 10 real photos. (Chapter 4)
- **Set up call tracking.** CallRail, WhatConverts, or similar. \$40-\$50/month. Assign different tracking numbers to your website, Google Ads, and any other marketing channels. From this point forward, you know where every call comes from. (Chapter 2)

- **Create your direct Google review link.** Search “Google review link generator.” Save the link in your phone. You’ll use this every single day. (Chapter 5)
- **Calculate your 5 key numbers.** Average job ticket. Cost per lead. Close rate. Customer lifetime value. Marketing ROI. Even if you can only fill in 2-3 right now, start tracking. Write them on a sticky note. (Chapter 2)

Time commitment: 3-5 hours total across 2 weeks. **Cost:** \$0-\$50/month (call tracking). **What you’ll have:** A baseline. A foundation. The data and tools you need to make every decision that follows an informed one instead of a guess.

Week 3-4: Website

Your website is your 24/7 salesperson. If it’s broken, everything else you do is less effective. Fix it now.

- **If your site is bad - get a real one built.** Contact a professional web company (OnlyPlumbingSites.com or another pro who specializes in plumbing/home service websites). Budget: \$2,000-\$5,000 for a solid plumbing website. This is not the place to cut corners. (Chapter 3)
- **If your site is decent - make these fixes:** Improve speed (target under 3 seconds). Ensure mobile click-to-call works. Add service pages for each service you offer. Add city/area pages for each city you serve. (Chapters 3, 7)
- **Add your Google reviews to your website.** Embed your Google reviews or add a reviews section with a link to your Google listing. Social proof on your website increases conversion. (Chapter 5)
- **Add city/service area pages.** If you serve 5 cities, create a page for each one. Even a basic page with your services and city name is better than nothing. (Chapter 7)
- **Set up Google Analytics and Google Search Console.** Both are free. Google Analytics tracks website traffic. Search Console shows you how Google sees your site. Have your web person set these up - it takes 15 minutes. (Chapter 9)

Time commitment: Varies. If you're hiring someone to build/fix your site, your time is minimal - a few hours of input and review. If DIY, budget 10-15 hours. **Cost:** \$0 if fixing an existing decent site. \$2,000-\$5,000 if building new. **What you'll have:** A website that actually works - fast, mobile-friendly, with service pages, city pages, and reviews.

Week 5-6: Reviews

Your review system is the engine that powers trust, visibility, and growth. Launch it now and let it compound.

- **Launch your review generation system.** Ask every customer in person after the job. Send the text with your direct link within 1 hour. Follow up once at 24-48 hours. Every customer. Every job. No exceptions. (Chapter 5)
- **Goal: 5 new reviews per week.** Write it on a whiteboard. Track it. Tell your team. Five per week = 260 per year. In 12 months, you'll have transformed your online presence.
- **Respond to ALL existing reviews.** Every single one. Positive and negative. Go through your Google listing today and respond to each review. Professional, personal, within 24 hours going forward.
- **Add the review request to your end-of-job process permanently.** This isn't a one-time campaign. This is a permanent part of how your business operates. Job done → ask for review → send link → follow up. Forever.

Time commitment: 15-20 minutes/day (asking, texting, responding). **Cost:** \$0. **What you'll have:** A review system that generates 5+ reviews per week on autopilot. Within 6 months, you'll have 130+ new reviews. Within a year, 260+.

Week 7-8: Social Media & Content

You don't need to become an influencer. You need to be visible. Start showing your work.

- **Set up or clean up your Facebook business page.** Current logo. Current cover photo. Correct phone number and address. Link to your website. Business hours. Complete the “About” section.
- **Post 3x/week. Before/after job photos. Quick tips.** Customer shoutouts. Use the “take a job photo” daily reminder. Batch your content - take photos throughout the week, post them in batches. (Chapter 13)
- **Set up a Nextdoor business page.** Post an introduction. Engage when people ask for plumber recommendations. (Chapter 13)
- **Film 2-3 quick tip videos.** 60 seconds each. Phone camera. Answer common customer questions. Post to YouTube, Facebook, Instagram, and Google Business Profile. (Chapter 16)
- **Post on Google Business Profile weekly.** A job photo, a seasonal tip, a promotion. 2 minutes. Every Monday. (Chapter 4)
- **Start posting on Facebook Marketplace.** Post 1 listing per day for 30 days. Rotate services: water heater + install, faucet repair, garbage disposal + install. Add your phone number to each photo. Set up auto-reply for Marketplace messages. (Chapter 14)

Time commitment: 3-4 hours/week (photo-taking, posting, filming, Marketplace). **Cost:** \$0. **What you'll have:** An active social media presence that makes you visible to potential customers and positions you as a professional, active company.

Week 9-10: SEO Foundation

Now that your website is solid and your reviews are growing, it's time to strengthen your search presence.

- **Make sure every service has its own page on your website.** List every service you offer. Check if each has a dedicated page. Fill the gaps - start with your highest-revenue services. (Chapter 7)
- **Write 2-4 FAQ-style blog posts.** Answer questions your customers ask most often. "How much does a water heater cost in [city]?" "Tankless vs. traditional - which is right for you?" 500-800 words each. (Chapter 8)
- **Get listed on 10-15 online service based business directories.** Yelp, BBB, Angi, HomeAdvisor, Thumbtack, Nextdoor, Facebook, Yellow Pages, Manta, Foursquare, and others. Make sure your NAP (Name, Address, Phone) is IDENTICAL on every listing. Consistency matters for SEO. (Chapter 6) Find some Plumbing Specific ones for added SEO value like ThePlumbingDirectory.com
- **Ask your web person about schema markup.** Send the text from Chapter 9: "Does our site have schema markup? Do we have an XML sitemap submitted to Google Search Console?" Their answer tells you where you stand. (Chapter 9)
- **Evaluate your phone-to-booking conversion.** Listen to 5 recent calls. Calculate your close rate. If it's below 50%, look into CSR training (Chapter 18). Consider a company like PowerSellingPros.
- **Set up an AI phone agent or website chatbot.** Try a free trial of GoHighLevel, Tidio, or similar. Configure it for after-hours calls and website chat. Track leads it captures that you would have missed. (Chapter 19)

Time commitment: 6-10 hours total across 2 weeks. **Cost:** \$0 (if you write the content yourself). \$100-\$300 if you hire a writer for the blog posts. **What you'll have:** A website that's visible for more searches in more cities, with content that answers customer questions and directory listings that build Google's trust in your business.

Week 11-12: Paid Advertising

Your foundation is set. Your reviews are growing. Your website works. Now it's time to add fuel to the fire.

- **Research Google Local Service Ads (LSAs) for your area.** Check availability at ads.google.com/local-services-ads. If available, start the verification process - gather your license, insurance, and business docs. (Chapter 11)
- **Set up or optimize a Google Ads campaign.** Target high-intent keywords: “emergency plumber [city],” “water heater repair [city],” “drain cleaning near me.” Create dedicated landing pages. Set up call tracking. Budget: \$1,000-\$2,000/month minimum. (Chapter 10)
- **Set a minimum 90-day test budget.** Commit to 90 days at your budget level. Not 2 weeks. Not 1 month. Ninety days gives the campaign enough data to optimize and deliver meaningful results.
- **Set up conversion tracking.** Make sure every ad campaign tracks calls and form fills. Without tracking, you're guessing - and we're done guessing. (Chapter 2)

Time commitment: 3-5 hours for initial setup. 30-60 minutes/week for management (or hire someone). **Cost:** \$1,000-\$2,000/month for ads. \$500-\$1,500/month if hiring someone to manage them. **What you'll have:** Paid advertising that puts you at the top of Google for your highest-value services. Predictable, measurable, scalable leads.

Week 13 (Day 90): Review, Optimize, Celebrate

You made it. Ninety days. You've built something real. Now it's time to measure it, optimize it, and set the next goal.

- **Review all metrics.** Website traffic (Google Analytics). Calls by source (call tracking). Leads from Google Ads. Reviews added. Revenue change vs. 90 days ago. Write all the numbers down.

- **Calculate cost per lead from each source.** Google Ads, LSAs, organic, social. Which channel generates the cheapest leads? Which generates the most? Which has the highest close rate?
- **Identify what's working best - and double down.** If Google Ads are printing money at \$50/lead, increase the budget. If your review system is generating 8/week instead of 5, keep pushing.
- **Identify what's not working - and fix or cut it.** If a particular ad campaign isn't converting, adjust the keywords or landing page. If your social media isn't generating any engagement after 90 days, reconsider your approach or platform.
- **Set your next 90-day goals.** You've built the foundation. Now optimize and expand. More reviews. Better rankings. Higher budgets on what's working. New service pages. More content. The machine gets stronger every quarter.
- **Launch your customer retention system.** Order thank-you baskets and equipment stickers. Start giving a gift after every job. Set up 6-week follow-up texts. Build the habit of keeping every customer for life. (Chapter 21)
- **Celebrate.** Seriously. You built a marketing machine in 90 days. Most plumbers never do this in their entire career. Take yourself to dinner. Tell your family what you accomplished. You earned it.

The Full Checklist (At a Glance)

Weeks 1-2

Focus: Foundation

Website audit, GBP setup, call tracking, review link, know your 5 numbers

Weeks 3-4

Focus: Website

Fix or rebuild, service pages, city pages, speed, mobile

Weeks 5-6

Focus: Reviews

Launch system, 5/week goal, respond to all, make it permanent

Weeks 7-8

Focus: Social & Content

Facebook, Nextdoor, Facebook Marketplace, 3x/week posts, tip videos, GBP posts

Weeks 9-10

Focus: SEO & Systems

Service pages, blog posts, directories, schema, CSR training, AI tools

Weeks 11-12

Focus: Paid Ads

LSAs, Google Ads, landing pages, tracking, 90-day budget

Week 13

Focus: Review

Metrics, CPA by channel, double down on winners, launch retention system, set next goals

Palmer's Weekend of Action

One last story. Palmer is a plumber who read a book a lot like this one. Not mine - he'd never heard of me at the time. But a similar book about marketing for service businesses. He read it on a Thursday night. By Saturday morning, he'd made a decision: he was going to implement as much as he could in one weekend.

Saturday morning: claimed his Google Business Profile, uploaded photos, wrote his description. Saturday afternoon: texted his last 10 customers with a review link. Got 4 reviews by dinner. Sunday morning: signed up for Google Ads, set a \$50/day budget, created one campaign targeting "emergency plumber [city]." Sunday afternoon: filmed 3 tip videos on his phone and posted them to YouTube and Facebook.

Monday morning, Palmer's phone rang. A Google Ads lead. He closed the job for \$650.

Palmer spent one weekend implementing the basics. He got his first result on Monday. Within 2 weeks, he'd generated \$4,200 in new revenue from marketing he set up in two days.

"The only thing more expensive than marketing," Palmer told me, "is NOT marketing. I waited three years to do this. I should have done it three years ago." Don't wait three years. Don't wait three months. Don't wait until Monday. Start this weekend. Start tonight.

Pipe Dream vs. Pipeline

Pipe Dream: "I'll get to marketing when things slow down."

Pipeline: "I started today. It's not perfect. But I started."

Ryan's Rant

Jorge told me he'd start marketing "when things slow down." That was 11 years ago. Things never slowed down enough for Jorge to start. And they never sped up either. Jorge is in the exact same place he was 11 years ago. Same revenue. Same truck. Same stress.

Meanwhile, the plumber who started a marketing system 11 years ago? He sold his company for \$1.4M, retired at 55, and is fishing in Florida right now. Same starting point as Jorge. Different decisions.

Don't be Jorge. Be the plumber who reads Chapter 23 and does ONE THING before they go to bed tonight. Not tomorrow. Not "when things slow down." Tonight.

Which plumber are you going to be?

Wrench Turn Action Items

1. Print the 90-day checklist. Scan the QR code below or go to OnlyPlumbingSites.com/90-day-plan. Print it. Put it on your wall, your fridge, your dashboard - wherever you'll see it every day.

2. Circle everything you've ALREADY done. Go through the checklist. Some of you will find that you've already done a few things. Great. Celebrate that. Mark them off. You're not starting from zero.

3. Star the 3 things you're doing THIS WEEK. Not the whole plan. Three things. This week. Pick the three that will make the biggest immediate impact. Do them.

4. Put the checklist where you'll see it every day. If it's out of sight, it's out of mind. Tape it to your bathroom mirror. Put it on the visor in your truck. Set it as your phone wallpaper. Whatever works.

5. Set a calendar reminder for Day 90. Ninety days from today. Block 2 hours. That's when you review everything, calculate your ROI, and set the next 90-day goals. Put it on the calendar now, before you forget.

Ready to print your 90-day checklist and get started?

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/90-day-plan. The 90-Day Marketing Checklist - printable PDF + interactive version that tracks your progress.

Want us to build your marketing machine so you can focus on plumbing?

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/call

BONUS / RESOURCES

Downloadable Resources

Every resource mentioned in this book is available for free at **OnlyPlumbingSites.com/book-resources**. Scan the QR code or type the URL. No strings attached.

[QR Code: OnlyPlumbingSites.com/book-resources]

Recommended Tools

These are tools I've seen work for plumbing companies. I'm not affiliated with most of them - I'm just telling you what works based on what I've seen in the field.

Website: - WordPress (most flexible platform for plumbing sites) - OnlyPlumbingSites.com (plumbing-specific - yes, that's me, but it's also genuinely built for this) **I don't build on wordpress anymore as I personally find it limiting, especially with the technological advancements in 2026. I can build way better, way faster and provide better results for my clients without the headache of wordpress.**

Reviews: - Birdeye (automated review requests and monitoring) - Podium (text-based review generation) - Manual system (your phone + a text template - works just as well if you're consistent)

Social Media: - Canva (free graphic design - make professional-looking posts in minutes) - Later or Buffer (schedule posts in advance - batch your content)

SEO: - Google Search Console (free - see how Google views your site) - Google Business Profile (free - your most important local SEO tool) - Semrush or Ahrefs (paid - for serious SEO tracking, \$99+/month). For the nerds like me, I use DataForSEO's Api for keyword research and search volume.

Ads: - Google Ads (search advertising - show up when people search for your services) - Google Local Service Ads (pay-per-lead - the Google Guaranteed badge)

CRM: - GoHighLevel (marketing-focused CRM with automation) - Jobber (field service management + basic CRM) - Housecall Pro (scheduling, invoicing, and customer management) - ServiceTitan (enterprise-level - for larger operations)

Call Tracking: - CallRail (industry standard - starts around \$40/month) - WhatConverts (tracks calls, forms, and chats by source)

Video: - Your phone (seriously - it's all you need) - CapCut (free video editing app if you want to add captions or trim clips)

About OnlyPlumbingSites.com

I started OnlyPlumbingSites.com because I kept seeing the same problem: great plumbers with terrible marketing. Talented tradespeople who could fix anything in a house but couldn't get their phone to ring consistently.

I built the company specifically for plumbers. Not restaurants. Not lawyers. Not "small businesses." Plumbers. Because plumbing marketing has specific challenges - local competition, emergency intent, seasonal demand, trust factors - that generic marketing agencies don't understand....And, well, I'm a licensed plumber myself!

Here's what we do:

DIY (This Book + Website Resources) Everything you need to understand and implement plumbing marketing yourself. This book gives you the WHY. The website resources give you the HOW. Free guides, templates, calculators, and checklists for every chapter. No cost to you, \$0! All I ask for is a thank you and maybe even a review.

Done With You (Strategy + Coaching) Strategy calls where we audit your current marketing, identify your biggest opportunities, and build a custom

plan. You implement it - we guide you. Good for plumbers who want to stay hands-on but need expert direction. We are creating a guided video teaching series on everything taught in this book. By the time you read this, it may be LIVE on OnlyPlumbingSites.com/course

Done For You (Full-Service Marketing) We build your website, manage your Google Ads, handle your SEO, set up your review system, and run your marketing machine - so you can focus on plumbing. Monthly reporting. No long-term contracts. Results-based relationships.

I'm not going to hard-sell you. If you read this book and implement it yourself and crush it - that's the best possible outcome. I'd rather you succeed on your own than hire us and not be committed.

But if you read this book and think "I get it, I just don't have time to do it all" - that's what we're here for.

Final Words

You've got the playbook.

You know why word of mouth isn't enough. You know your numbers matter. You know your website needs to work, not just exist. You know Google Business Profile is free and powerful. You know reviews are the new word of mouth. You know SEO isn't optional. You know how service pages, content, and schema work together. You know Google Ads and LSAs can be money printers when done right. You know lead services are rented, not owned. You know social media is about visibility, not virality. You know your brand is more than a logo. You know video is the most underused tool in your arsenal. You know follow-up is where the money lives. You know your marketing affects hiring too. You've seen the transformation. You have the 90-day plan.

Now you've got two options:

Option 1: Do it yourself. This book and the website resources give you everything you need. Follow the 90-day plan. Take it one step at a time. Be consistent. Be patient. The results will come.

Option 2: Let us handle it. If you'd rather focus on what you do best - plumbing - and let professionals handle the marketing, that's what OnlyPlumbingSites.com exists for. Book a free strategy call and we'll build a plan together.

Either way, **stop waiting.** The plumber who takes action is the plumber who wins. Every single time.

Don't be Jorge. Don't wait 11 years for things to slow down. They won't.

Be Palmer. Pick one thing. Do it tonight. Then do another thing tomorrow. And another one the next day.

Ninety days from now, you'll look back at today and wonder why you didn't start sooner.

Let's get to work.

- Ryan Pietrzak Plumber since 2009. Marketer by necessity. Author by accident. Founder, OnlyPlumbingSites.com & ThePlumbingDirectory.com

Book a free strategy call: OnlyPlumbingSites.com/call

OnlyPlumbingSites.com/call

BEING A GREAT PLUMBER AND BEING A SUCCESSFUL PLUMBER ARE TWO DIFFERENT THINGS

You can do incredible work.

You can show up on time, treat customers right,
and take pride in every job you finish.

And still struggle to make the phone ring.

The truth is simple: great plumbing skills don't
guarantee a great plumbing business.

Today's customers find plumbers online.
They search Google, read reviews, and compare
websites before they ever pick up the phone.

The Little Plumber That Couldn't is a practical field guide
written by a plumber who learned marketing the same way
he learned plumbing: by figuring it out in the real world.

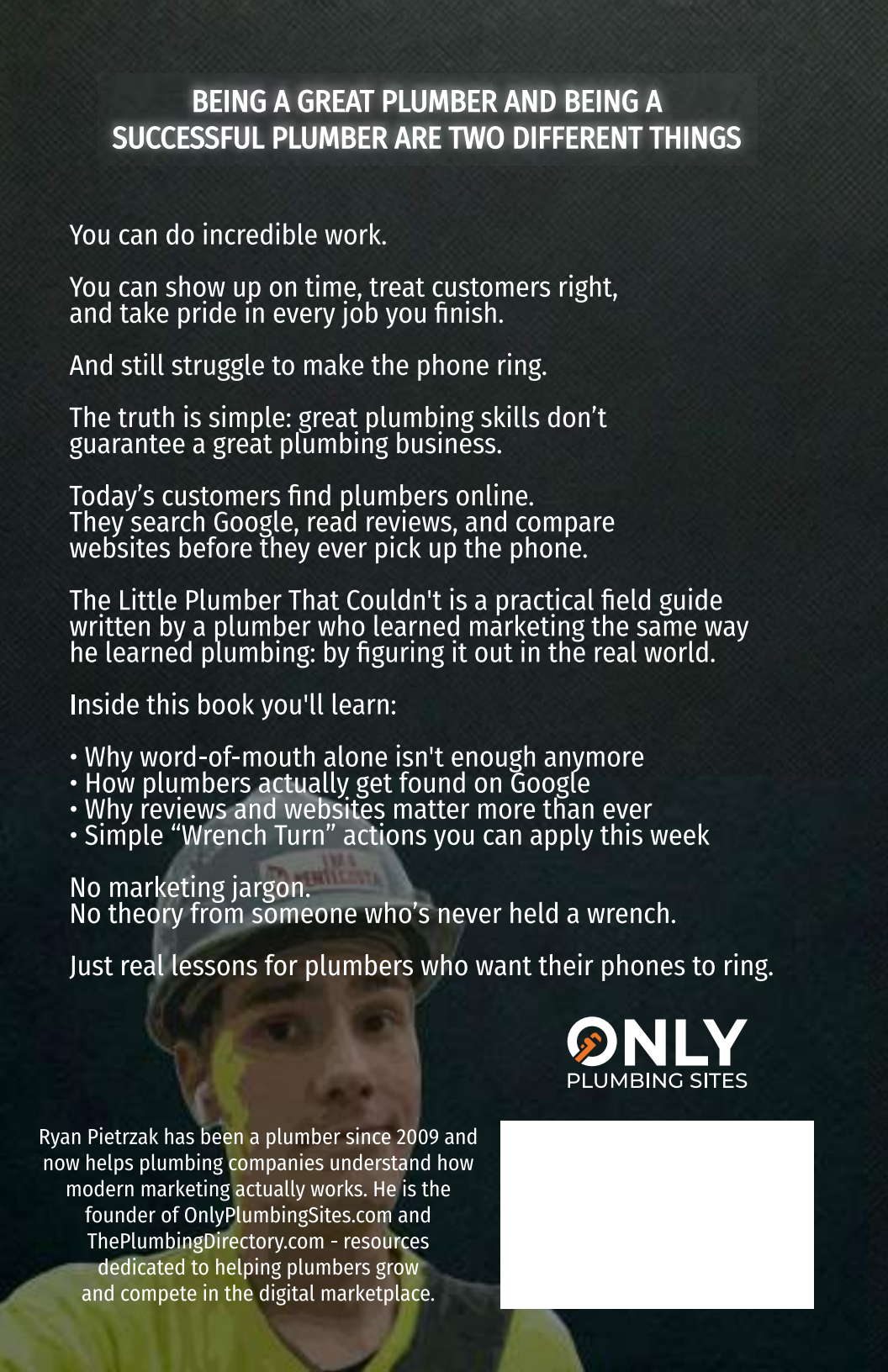
Inside this book you'll learn:

- Why word-of-mouth alone isn't enough anymore
- How plumbers actually get found on Google
- Why reviews and websites matter more than ever
- Simple "Wrench Turn" actions you can apply this week

No marketing jargon.

No theory from someone who's never held a wrench.

Just real lessons for plumbers who want their phones to ring.



ONLY
PLUMBING SITES

Ryan Pietrzak has been a plumber since 2009 and
now helps plumbing companies understand how
modern marketing actually works. He is the
founder of OnlyPlumbingSites.com and
ThePlumbingDirectory.com - resources
dedicated to helping plumbers grow
and compete in the digital marketplace.